Remember (My Love)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/50098417.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F, F/M, Gen

Fandom:
うる星やつら | Urusei Yatsura, She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Lum/Moroboshi Ataru, lots of friendships and platonic bonds

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Lum (Urusei Yatsura), Moroboshi Ataru, Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Ran (Urusei Yatsura), Benten (Urusei Yatsura), Oyuki (Urusei Yatsura), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Miyake Shinobu, Mendou Shutarou, Fujinami Ryuunosuke, Cherry (Urusei Yatsura), Sakura (Urusei Yatsura), Castaspella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Ten (Urusei Yatsura), Lum's Stormtroopers, almost every other SPOP character, and also many other UY characters, maybe too many to handle

Additional Tags:
Crossover, Dimension Travel, Earth characters on Etheria, Large Cast, mostly gen but with some ships, lots of characters bonding, Love Confessions, Wacky Shenanigans, Giant Robots, Sea Battles, Forced Enlistment, Friends on different sides of a war, Canon Divergence, Post Episode: S03E04 Moment of Truth, Angella lives, basically rewriting seasons 4 and 5 of SPOP, with UY characters added, i had a lot of fun writing this

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by xian70

Summary

When Force Captain Catra, driven by anger and resentment, opens an unstable dimensional portal, she doesn't expect it to bring to Etheria a group of bizarre characters from another world... including a lecherous, annoying boy and a beautiful alien princess in a tiger-striped bikini, whose feelings for each other seem at least as complicated as Adora's and her own.

Notes

I don't think these two fandoms have much fan overlap, but they are two of my all-time favorite series and I just HAD to write a crossover between them. Both shows are full of fun and interesting characters, so there will be a lot of interactions and character bonding. And I tried my best to make everything understandable even for those unfamiliar with either series.

The story is set right after s3e4 "Moment of Truth" for She-Ra (the episode in which Catra opens the portal), no matter when (but before the OVA "Inaba the Dreammaker") for Urusei Yatsura.

The first chapter, which is shorter than the others, takes place on Earth and is mostly UY-centric, while from the second chapter on we are on Etheria, the world of SPOP. I've already written the whole thing, and I'll be posting one chapter a week.

For those unfamiliar with either fandom, here are their basic premises:

- Urusei Yatsura: The insanely lecherous high school student Moroboshi Ataru and his self-imposed alien “wife” Lum live in the small town of Tomobiki, in Japan. Together with a large cast of eccentric characters (both earthlings and aliens), they are the protagonists of wacky adventures and bizarre situations that often lead to chaos and destruction.

- She-Ra: A war is raging on the planet Etheria between the evil Horde and the Rebellion led by the Princess Alliance. After finding a magical sword that transforms her into She-Ra, Princess of Power, young cadet Adora deserts the Horde to join the princesses, causing the wrath (and the heartbreak) of her former best friend Catra, who becomes her nemesis.

See the end of the work for more notes

The Dimensional Switch Portal

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Catra, please, don't!" screams Adora, tears in her eyes. Stripped of the magical sword that gives her the power to transform into She-Ra, and tied up with her hands behind her back in the laboratory of Hordak, the cruel lord of the Horde, the blonde girl makes a last desperate plea to her former childhood friend and now bitter rival, hoping that by some miracle she will listen to her, come to her senses, and abandon her insane act of self-destruction. Both Mara and Entrapta were clear: opening the portal will cause an immense catastrophe, not only for the planet Etheria, but for the very fabric of reality. But all is useless. Catra glances at her with her heterochromatic cat eyes, smiles (is that a smile? Or rather an evil smirk?) and pulls the lever. "No!" Adora cries. A greenish light floods the room. And as the portal opens wide, Adora feels as if her heart, like the world around her, has suddenly stopped.

It's a beautiful spring morning in Japan, and the sky, enlivened by the return of the first swallows, is completely blue. One can almost hear a cheerful piece of music in the air, like an upbeat soundtrack. The small, round, tiger-striped flying saucer hovers silently in the sky above Tomobiki-cho. It has long been a familiar sight to the residents of the neighborhood, who are no longer surprised to see it fly over their homes every day. Many have almost forgotten the panic and frenzy when, a few months earlier, Earth had been invaded by a warlike race of extraterrestrials, and was only saved because the aliens' bizarre customs prevented them from carrying out the invasion after one of their warriors,

the daughter of the alien warlord, was defeated by a randomly selected earthling – a Japanese, no less, and actually a high school student from Tomobiki! – in a tag competition.

Lum, the aforementioned young alien girl, who has now permanently moved to the planet to stay close to that boy, pauses for a moment in the doorway of the small spaceship that opens to the outside. She is ready to jump into the air; with one hand she straightens the folds of the school sailor's uniform that hides the tiger-striped bikini underneath, and with the other she smoothes the flowing green hair at the back of her neck, from which the two horns typical of her race peek out. Before she flies down to Earth, she turns to say goodbye to her friends who are remaining in the ship.

"I'm going to stop by my darling's house and then go to school with him," Lum says with a smile. "I bet he's still sleeping. If I don't pay attention to him, he'll be late as usual. Don't you mind working ahead on your own?"

"Don't worry, Lum! Go ahead and take care of your idiot boyfriend," Benten replies. The space biker is sitting cross-legged on the floor of the flying saucer's interior, a wrench in her hand and some grease and oil stains on her arms and the parts of her body not covered by her skimpy metal dress and shoulder chain. "I'm almost done connecting the last parts of the main generator. By the time you get back after class, everything will be working perfectly."

"I don't know how to thank you," Lum tells her friend. "You have always been better than me with this kind of mechanical equipment. It would have taken me at least a week to install Oyuki's new dimensional closet on my UFO."

"It was about time you made up your mind," says the third girl on the saucer, the ice queen Oyuki herself, a childhood friend of the other two. With her usual calmness and the impeccable elegance with which she wears her white winter kimono, she sits at the table sipping a cup of tea while watching Benten work. "As you

know, the dimensional tunnel technology on my planet is the best in this quadrant of the galaxy. So you no longer will have to worry about using your spaceship's hyperspace every time you want to visit me on Neptune."

"Thanks to you too, Oyuki," Lum tells her. "It was so kind of you to provide me with all the technology I needed."

"Of course, you'll get a regular bill for the materials," Oyuki comments.

"Of course," Lum says with a sigh. She is well aware of her friend's attention to every financial aspect: she has always been tied to money. *I hope at least Benten won't charge me for her work*, she thinks.

Then, before getting out of the flying saucer, she adds, "I really have to go now. I can't wait to see my darling again!"

"I still don't understand what you see in that earthling," Benten says, continuing to work with the wrench.

"I like Lum's husband, actually," Oyuki says with a smile. "I find him funny."

"Darling has a bit of a peculiar character, it's true," Lum concedes. "But that's how he is, you have to accept him. And deep down, very deep down, he has a big heart. See you later, girls," Lum says before she jumps from the saucer into the air and gently flies down towards the ground, towards the Moroboshi's home, where Ataru, the boy she loves more than anything, is waiting for her to go to school together.

Yes, it truly is a beautiful spring morning on Earth.

In the infirmary of Tomobiki High School, nurse Sakura is sorting some medical supplies into the lockers. But something is bothering her. Since the moment she woke up today, she has had a bad feeling. She cannot explain what it could be. The day began peacefully. The influx of students to the infirmary pretending to be sick was lower than usual, and she herself made sure to chase away most of those who came to her door just to have an excuse to admire her bust, barely covered by her white dress. Then, in the afternoon, she has a romantic outing planned with her fiancé Tsubame, who for once had managed to get away from his duties as an exorcist and had booked a table at one of the best restaurants in town. Nothing indicates any problems. And yet...

...and yet the beautiful nurse can't get it out of her head that something serious is about to happen.

"Your face looks gloomy. Have you been putting on any more weight?" Cherry asks suddenly, materializing on her desk without warning.

"Damn you!" Sakura yells, hitting her uncle, a traveling monk and professional jinx, on his head with a huge wooden hammer. "I told you a thousand times not to come and disturb me while I work! What are you doing here?"

"Don't get angry, you'll get wrinkles," he replies. Immediately another blow follows on the bald head of the elderly monk. This time it's so hard that the big hammer shatters.

"Wait a minute, niece, calm down... I have something serious to tell you," says Cherry, now with a few lumps on his head, just before Sakura, who grabbed him and lifted him by the scruff of his neck, can throw him out of the window.

"What do you want to tell me?" Sakura asks. "Speak quickly. I don't have time for your foolery."

"No foolery," Cherry replies. "Have you also sensed the approaching danger?"

Sakura stops abruptly and puts her uncle back on the desk. “Danger?” she asks. “What do you mean?”

“I have been feeling a bad omen since this morning,” says the monk. “It’s nothing new for me, but this time, it’s something much more serious than usual. I think there’s a threat hanging over us... and I don’t mean just Tomobiki, but the whole reality.”

“Uhmm...”, the nurse says. “Actually, I also have a strange feeling. But maybe that’s just because I didn’t sleep well last night.”

“Perhaps you ate too much again?” Cherry says. “Of course you’re putting on weight.”

Another hammer materializes in the woman’s hands and hits him over the head.

“It’s not about the food!” yells Sakura, who then becomes thoughtful. “Now that I think about it, I probably had a bad dream. But I can’t really remember...”

“I had a nightmare too,” says Cherry. “A menacing luminous vortex appeared to me, growing larger and larger until it covered the entire planet. And at its center, suspended in mid-air... a strange sword, European style, with a blue gem set in the golden hilt. Perhaps the origin of the vortex itself.”

Sakura pauses for a moment to collect her thoughts. The memory of her dream suddenly comes back to her. “Yes, that’s what I dreamed too. And in fact, since this morning, I really do feel a great danger approaching. But what does it mean, uncle?”

“We must find out,” Cherry replies. “And above all, we must perform a protective ritual with our spiritual energies as soon as possible. Maybe it’s not too late.”

In the large gym of Tomobiki High School, ten students stand with their backs to the wall during the morning break, angry and annoyed at having been brought there. Once again, they have been assigned to detention, and many of them feel it is unfair. In front of them, the burly and perpetually frustrated teacher Onsenmark, flanked on his right by the bizarre figure of the giant white cat Kotatsu-neko, explains to the principal the reason for his decision: "As usual, these rascals have disrupted class and destroyed most of the classroom equipment." The students grumble.

"Are they all students from Class 2-4, sensei?" asks the principal.

"Nine of them, yes," says Onsenmark. "There's the infamous Moroboshi Ataru, of course: when there's trouble, he's always around. Then there are Lum, Mendo Shutaro, Miyake Shinobu, Fujinami Ryunosuke, and... those four," he adds, referring to the so-called group of Lum's Stormtroopers – the bespectacled Megane, the slim Perm, the corpulent Kakugari and the short Chibi – four students who have taken it upon themselves to worship the beautiful alien girl and to protect her from any danger, i.e. from the advances of the other students of the class and especially from those of the most notorious womanizer of the school, Ataru. It is a paradox, however, that if there is one girl he seems to have no desire for, it is actually Lum, who instead is madly in love with him. "The tenth student is Ran, from Class 2-7," says Onsenmark.

"I've nothing to do with this!" Ran cries, clenching her hands in front of her face. "I'm innocent! It's all Lum-chan's fault that I got into trouble, just like always!"

"What are you talking about, Ran-chan?" Lum replies, turning to her pink-haired childhood friend. "If you hadn't come to my class during recess and tried to get back at me again, nothing would have happened!"

"How can you say that?" Ran tells her, losing her good girl aplomb, raising her voice and clenching her teeth. "Your darling tried to kiss me!"

“You’re the one who tried to seduce him!” Lum points out. “And you did it on purpose, because you know what he’s like, that he’s not able to resist temptation.”

“That idiot Ataru tried to hug me too!” Ryunosuke interjects. “That’s why I had to hit him and throw him against the wall.” As she speaks, she mimics the uppercut she gave the boy, pulling up to her elbows the sleeves of her male uniform – the only one her miserable father allows her to wear in order to hide her feminine features.

“And me too!” adds Shinobu with an angry expression on her girl-next-door face, framed by her bob haircut. “I didn’t want to disturb the class, but I couldn’t help throwing that heavy school desk at him! But Ataru’s like that, it’s true, he’ll never change!”

“Moroboshi got what he deserved,” adds Mendo, the only one of the boys who wears a white uniform instead of the regular dark blue to distinguish himself from the others, running his hand with a sigh through his immaculately combed hair, except for a cowlick that accentuates his elegant appearance. “He’s always bothering the girls. What I don’t understand is why I, the great heir of the rich and noble Mendo family, am forced to stay here with a low life like him to receive a punishment I don’t deserve.”

“Cut the crap, Mendo!” Ataru shouts. “I saw you when you slimely approached Lum and Shinobu, taking advantage of the fact that I was temporarily knocked out. You put on so many airs of seriousness and integrity, but deep down you’re as much of a womanizer as I am, and maybe worse! Learn to keep your dirty hands off Lum!” Hearing these last words, the alien girl smiles.

“How dare you compare yourself to me, Moroboshi?” Mendo shouts, drawing the samurai sword he always carries at his side and pointing it at his rival. “Besides, why are you so jealous of Miss Lum, when you always treat her so badly and constantly claim that you don’t love her?”

“The relationship between that annoying Lum and me is only our business!” Ataru retorts, bending down on one knee and taking the blade of Mendo’s sword between his hands to parry his blow. “Get over it, you and all these other interlopers!”

“Oh, darling!” exclaims Lum, “I’m so happy that you too realize that there is a special relationship between us. That’s one of the most romantic things you’ve ever said to me!”

“Shut up, you damn nuisance!” Ataru tells her.

“Ataru! Don’t insult our goddess Lum, damn you!” the four Stormtroopers shout, approaching him menacingly. “She’s an angel!” says Megane.

“No!” Ataru replies. “She’s a devil!”

“That’s enough! Everybody stop!” shouts Onsenmark, completely ignored by his students. “Don’t start fighting again. I won’t let you destroy the gym as well as the classroom. Principal, punish them!”

The principal steps forward. He sighs, cleans his glasses with a piece of cloth, puts them back on, and then begins his lecture in a gentle tone. “Boys, girls, come on, behave yourselves.” Behind him, the giant Kotatsu cat nods.

“Principal, you’re too kind,” Onsenmark insists. “With these delinquents, a small talk is not enough. If we don’t punish them severely, who knows what will happen. They are capable of destroying the whole school.”

Just then, as if to confirm his words, the entire gym wall begins to shake. Fragments and debris fall from the ceiling. “Aaahh, an earthquake!” Shinobu cries, running to seek shelter in Ryunosuke’s arms, who stands next to her and wraps her arms around her protectively.

“Please, stay calm! Don’t panic!” the principal yells.

Before anyone can react, however, the large glass window of the gym shatters, and the red space bike ridden by Benten, with Oyuki behind her, flies into the hall. “Lum, hurry, there’s an emergency!” the biker shouts.

“Benten-sama! Oyuki-san!” Ataru exclaims with a stupid smile on his face, happy to see the two alien girls and ready to jump into the air towards them. Suddenly, a strong electric shock emanating from Lum’s fingertips zaps him, knocking him to the ground. “Be a good boy, darling,” the alien says, turning then to her two friends. “Girls, what’s going on?”

“We had just finished installing Oyuki’s dimensional tunnel generator on your flying saucer,” Benten explains as her bike lands on the gym floor, “and we turned it on to test it. But something went wrong. Just as the UFO passed over the school, a strange rift opened up in the air below. We tried to turn the machine off, but it was no use: something was interfering with the instrumentation.”

“It’s very strange indeed,” Oyuki adds, keeping her composure. “The rift has formed above the roof of the school, and it’s getting bigger. But my machine isn’t supposed to work like that. If you cut the power, the tunnel should close immediately. I don’t understand what could have caused this behavior.”

“We know what it is!” says a voice. Everyone turns to the door of the gym and sees that Sakura, dressed in her traditional *miko* or Shinto priestess dress, has made her entrance together with her uncle Cherry. The two of them are accompanied by Ten, Lum’s little cousin, who rushes into her arms out of breath and says: “Oh, Lum-chan, I’m so scared!”

“What’s wrong?” the girl asks, caressing Ten’s head.

“There’s a hole in the sky above the school,” Ten answers. “I almost fell into it while flying here!”

“It’s a dimensional portal,” Cherry explains. “Caused by an interference between the alien technology on Lum’s UFO and the exorcism attempt Sakura and I were making... It was probably fate.”

“Damn old jinx!” Ataru yells. “As always, when something bad happens around here, you’re involved.”

“This time, my uncle has nothing to do with it,” Sakura intervenes. “A protection ritual like the one we were performing could never create a portal of this size by itself, let alone keep it open, even in combination with your alien technology. It could only happen if someone from the other side did the same.”

“From the other side?” Mendo asks. “What do you mean?”

“She’s right!” Oyuki says. “We are talking about a dimensional portal, or a passage between two different dimensions. It can only exist if it’s opened from both sides... and by a combination of magic and technology.”

Another rumble shakes the hall. Those present look up in horror as the roof of the building is blown off. High in the sky above them, they see a large, dark disk floating in the air. Screams of terror fill the room.

“Help! Somebody save me!” Ran cries.

“Lum-chan!” Ten shouts.

“Every man for himself!” Megane screams. And then, turning to his companions: “Let’s get out of here, quickly!” Kakugari grabs the smaller Chibi, puts him under his arm and prepares to run like the others.

But before anyone can take a single step, the disk suddenly falls, crashing to the floor of the gym and over the students. A flash of light fills the entire room. Every sound stops, replaced by an unnatural silence.

Slowly, one by one, Sakura, Onsenmark, the principal and Kotatsu-neko, who had closed their eyes to avoid being blinded by the light, carefully open them again. Looking around, they notice that the half-ruined gym is empty. There is no sign of the mysterious portal... but also no sign of the students. "Where did Moroboshi and the others go?" Onsenmark asks.

"The portal swallowed them... and then closed," Sakura answers. The priestess pulls out her *gohei*, the wand she uses for Shinto rituals, and waves it in the air. "No reaction," she says. "There is no trace of supernatural phenomena. The portal is gone."

"Gone? Nurse Sakura, what does that mean? Where are the students?" Onsenmark asks.

"Lum and the others were sucked into the void... and probably transported to another dimension," Sakura says.

"My pupils!" the principal exclaims. "We have to save them! We can't lose them… The school's reputation is at stake!"

"Unfortunately, it won't be easy to find them," Sakura says. "We have no idea where they went or how to get them back. Maybe I can do something, but..." The priestess pauses for a moment to think. Then she continues: "...I'm going to need some help." Behind her, Kotatsu-neko crosses his paws and nods.

As the light fades, Shinobu tries to open her eyes again. The first thing she realizes is that she is still in Ryunosuke's arms, who is holding her for protection. A slight blush colors her face. The second thing she notices... is that she and her friends are no longer in the Tomobiki High School gym. She looks around: she and her classmates, plus Lum's alien friends, are standing in a huge hall with high green and metal walls, a sort of laboratory. The floor is littered with mechanical debris, as if there had been

an earthquake or some kind of terrible battle. The humming of industrial machinery is an incessant background. In the distance, beyond two gigantic collapsed columns, one to the right and one to the left, are some people dressed in bizarre clothes. And closer, right in front of them, with a confused and astonished expression... a feline girl with a wild-looking mane and intense eyes of two different colors, whose hand is still gripping a lever, and a distressed blonde girl in a red jacket, tied to a pole, look at them, perplexed.

For a moment, nobody knows what to say. And then, of course, the silence is broken by that idiot Ataru, who jumps towards the two girls with his eyes wide open and his tongue hanging out, shouting: “Hey, pretty ladies! Want to go on a date with me? What’s your address and phone number?”

Chapter End Notes

> The title of this first chapter is a fusion between the titles of She-Ra (2018) season 3 episode 6, “The Portal”, and Urusei Yatsura (1981) episode 107, “Dimensional Switch, Where’s Darling?”.
>
> All chapters will actually have a title that mixes episode titles from both series. The fic itself takes its title from season 3 episode 5 of She-Ra, “Remember”, and UY’s third movie, “Remember My Love” (1985).

Signals of Love and Conflict

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“What the heck?” says Catra as she sees the horny boy leaping into the air and rushing towards her. She doesn’t have time to react before an electric shock hits the boy, knocking him down to the floor of Hordak’s sanctum. Along with the discharge, an angry voice is heard shouting, “Darling no baka!”

The catgirl looks around, trying to figure out what’s going on. The lab is devastated by the previous battle. Adora, tied to the post, looks as confused as she is. Hordak, still distraught, is on his knees behind the rubble. A dozen strange individuals, never before seen, have materialized in front of the machine built by Entrapta. But more importantly, that same machine is in pieces, destroyed by an excess of energy, and Adora’s sword, which had been hovering in its center, powering the portal, has fallen to the ground. The portal itself closed. It didn’t work... how is that possible?

“Adora!” Glimmer calls. Right. Beyond the rubble, across the room, Sparkles is there with her friend Arrow Boy and the cursed Shadow Weaver. Catra’s eyes narrow in anger. But before she can do anything, Glimmer teleports to the blonde girl’s side.

“Glimmer, quick!” Adora cries. “We have to escape!”

“Don’t worry, Adora, I’ll set you free right away,” the princess of Bright Moon replies, untying the bonds that were holding her friend.

“You won’t do it!” exclaims Catra, ready to lash out at them. But an arrow shot by Bow comes between her and the two princesses, spreading a net that prevents the Force Captain from passing.

“The sword, Glimmer! Take it!” says Adora. In response, Glimmer teleports back a few feet to the portal machine, grabs She-Ra’s sword, and vanishes in a flash. Catra watches in dismay as the princess reappears behind the debris, where Adora has already joined Bow and Shadow Weaver.

“You won’t be able to escape!” the catgirl repeats. But she knows it’s too late. She has failed once more. From the main door, the four rebels are joined by the other princesses who entered the Fright Zone, namely Mermista, Perfuma and Frosta, and the whole group prepares to teleport away, with Shadow Weaver and Glimmer holding hands to boost their own powers…

“Wow! How many beautiful ladies! Sweeties! Would you like to go on a date with me?” the annoying boy from earlier shouts as he runs towards them. How did he recover from the electric shock so quickly? And who the hell is he anyway?

“Darling, don’t you dare!” a green-haired girl yells, lifting herself into the air and floating towards him. She can fly? Is she a princess?

“Lum-chan, don’t leave me here!” cries a child who can also fly. The three of them, the boy, the girl and the child, reach the group of Adora and the other rebels just as they are enveloped by Glimmer’s magic, amplified by Shadow Weaver’s. In a flash of purple light, the princesses and the three intruders vanish from Hordak’s sanctum and teleport to safety. Once again, Adora had the upper hand, Catra thinks. Once again I have failed!

As the feline commiserates and Hordak regains his footing and staggers to the center of the room, a large group of Horde soldiers, led by Force Captains Grizzlor and Octavia, enter the lab. Better late than never, Catra thinks.

“Lord Hordak!” Grizzlor shouts, “Are you hurt?”

“Capture the intruders!” Octavia orders, pointing to the dozen people who have come out of the portal and are standing next to

the broken machine. Soldiers surround them, weapons in hand. It's true, Catra reflects. I forgot about those other idiots. But who are they? Are they part of the Rebellion?

Some of the mysterious individuals show signs of resistance. A couple of them clench their fists. One even draws some sort of sword. But in the face of the Horde soldiers, who are more numerous and better armed, they understand that it is useless to try to fight. Not to mention the fact that they all look around in confusion, trying in vain to figure out where they are. The soldiers quickly subdue them.

Hordak says nothing, still shaken by Entrapta's supposed betrayal. Catra understands that it is time to take control of the situation. "Well done, Force Captains," she tells Grizzlor and Octavia. "I'll take care of Lord Hordak. You secure the area and have a team come in to clean up the lab." And then, pointing to the intruders, she adds: "And throw these guys in the cells."

"Yes, Commander," Grizzlor replies. With a few hard shoves the intruders are taken away.

Carried by Glimmer's magic, the Princess Alliance materializes once again in the council chamber of Bright Moon Castle. After a moment's pause to look up at the vast, bright ceilings, laughter and shouts erupt from the ranks of the princesses, who hug each other.

"We did it! Did we do it? Yes, we did it!" says Bow.

"The rescue mission went smoothly, as planned," says Mermista. "I had no doubts, with such an amazing member like me!"

"I'm probably going to be grounded for the rest of my life, but Adora's safe, and that's all that matters," laughs Glimmer.

And as if in response to her words, Queen Angella steps forward. “Glimmer!” she calls. “Are you okay? Are you all safe?”

“Mom!” Glimmer says, abruptly stopping her laughter. She can’t explain why, but she feels a strange relief watching the queen walk toward her, as if something inside her had told her she would never see her again: highly unlikely, since Angella is an angelic and immortal creature.

A wave of strange warmth finds its way into her heart. Her gaze becomes shy and her eyes turn to the ground. “Mom... We’re fine, as you can see. I know you’re upset that we went on a mission without your permission, but we couldn’t wait any longer and let the Horde...”

Her sentence is interrupted by Angella’s sudden hug. “Oh, Glimmer, I was so worried about you!”

Taken aback, Glimmer hesitates for a moment, then hugs her back. “Mom... I’m so sorry for having disobeyed you.”

“The important thing is that you all are safe,” the queen of Bright Moon replies. “And it seems you were right. Your mission, as improvised as it was, was successful,” she adds, smiling at Adora. Then she raises her gaze and points at Shadow Weaver: “But she must return to her cell!”

“Is that how you thank me for saving Adora?” the masked sorceress says coldly. “And for showing your daughter the great power she would be capable of if only she decided to fully embrace her connection to magic?”

“You were draining her energy!” Bow says, turning to Shadow Weaver. “You used her to torture Catra!” Hearing these words, Adora’s expression suddenly darkens. “If I hadn’t stopped you, who knows what would have happened,” Bow continues.

“I did what I had to do,” Shadow Weaver says, her voice monotonous.

“Silence, witch,” Angella snaps. Behind her, two Bright Moon guards step forward and grab Shadow Weaver’s arms. “The two of us will talk later. Take her back to the spare room... I mean, to the prison!”

The guards drag Shadow Weaver away, who offers no resistance.

The room falls silent. Only then do Angella and the princesses realize that there are three strangers with them, staring at them in confusion.

“Uh... what place is this? Who are you?” asks a girl with flowing green hair from which two small horns protrude. Her arms are wrapped around a dumb-eyed boy. Both are wearing strange dark blue uniforms. And suspended in mid-air is a little child with green hair identical to the girl’s, but with a single horn.

“Horde soldiers!” Frosta shouts, pointing at the three intruders.

“Uhhhm...” says Adora. “They don’t look like soldiers to me... And they’re certainly not wearing the standard Horde uniforms.”

“Ladies!” says the boy, suddenly regaining a serious expression. “Allow me to introduce myself. My name is Moroboshi Ataru, and I’m Japan’s number one playboy. Perhaps some of you would like to know me better?”

“Darling, I told you to stop!” the green-haired girl shouts. “Don’t you realize we are no longer on Earth?”

“And what about that, Lum?” Ataru replies. “It’s not the first time you and your strange devices have landed me on another planet.” Then he glances at the group of princesses and adds: “I must admit, though, that judging by the people here, this is one of the most pleasant places you have taken me so far.”

“Um...” Perfuma says, stepping forward. “Excuse me, but... how did you get here?”

“We would like to know that too!” Lum exclaims. “A moment ago we were on Earth. And then this strange portal brought us here to this other planet!”

“Other... planet?” Adora gasps.

“Well, sure,” Lum says. “This certainly doesn’t look like Earth to me. What is your world called?”

“Etheria...” Bow answers. “But... this is unbelievable! Are you really from another planet?”

“Are there really other planets?” asks Perfuma. “And are they inhabited?”

“What’s so strange?” Lum says. “Everyone knows that! Didn’t they teach you anything in school?”

“There are many planets! And also many troublemakers coming from them,” Ataru says. “I know something about that. Space is a really bizarre place, believe me.”

“I, for example, come from the planet Oniboshi,” Lum adds, pointing at herself and smiling. “And so is my little cousin Ten, here.”

“Oniboshi?” Glimmer asks in surprise. “Yet another planet?”

“Yes, this pain in the ass is an alien. I wish she had never come to Earth and I had never met her!” says Ataru.

Lum suddenly frowns, turns to him and... bites his arm with her sharp teeth. “Darling, don’t you dare insult me!”

“Aaargh!” Ataru cries.

“You idiot!” says Ten. “Haven’t you learned yet that you don’t want to make Lum angry?”

“Shut up, Jariten!” Ataru yells and tries to hit the kid on the head, but he dodges just in time.

The princesses look confused, baffled by the bizarre and erratic behavior of the intruders. Angella turns to Glimmer: “Perhaps it’s time to bring your aunt Castaspella here. She can cast a truth spell to find out if these crazy people are really who they say they are, or if they’re just pulling our leg.”

“Mara’s message said that she had hidden Etheria inside the empty dimension of Despondos to protect the rest of the universe from some danger,” Adora recalled. “And Light Hope revealed to me that I myself come from another world... So it’s true: there are other planets. And these guys are from there... from out there.”

The blonde takes a step towards Ataru, Lum and Ten and stares at them intensely. Lum glances back curiously.

“Do you know the First Ones?” Adora asks. “Have you ever heard of a gigantic Horde army from another world? Do you know who I am? Who is my family? Please, if you know anything, answer me!”

“Uhmmm,” Lum replies. “I really have no idea what you’re talking about.”

“Enough nonsense!” Angella says. “As soon as Castaspella arrives, we will...”

Her sentence is interrupted by a flash of light that makes the entire room vibrate. Everyone shudders. They feel as if reality ceases to exist for a moment, before time resumes its course. Some of the princesses scream.

“What was that?” Glimmer says, shaking.

“What happened?” Bow exclaims. “It’s like the whole world got the hiccups!”

“I have no idea,” Angella says. “But we will investigate. In the meantime, put these three in the spare room, too, quickly,” she

orders. “There’s enough space anyway… And bring some cushions back in.”

Four more guards, led by General Juliet, enter the chamber and escort Ataru, Lum and Ten out.

The green energy barrier that serves as the Fright Zone’s cell door, a sort of force field, rises with a hum. “The prisoners are secured, Force Captain Grizzlor,” says a Horde soldier.

“Very well,” replies the large hairy beastman. “Two of you stay on guard. Be careful, we still don’t know how dangerous they are.” And he walks away.

The teenagers in the cell stare at each other in confusion. Their wrists are bound by strange chains, also formed by energy, that leave them hardly any freedom of movement. “Where the hell are we?” Perm exclaims.

Ryunosuke sits cross-legged with her back to the wall and looks around. There are only seven of them locked in there: herself, Shinobu, Mendo and then Megane, Perm, Kakugari and Chibi. “Where did they put Ran, Benten and Oyuki? Why didn’t they put them here in this cell with us?” she asks.

“It’s almost as if they wanted to separate the earthlings from the aliens,” Shinobu says.

“And where are Miss Lum and that moron Moroboshi?” Mendo asks.

“But most of all, where are we?” Kakugari cries.

“It’s obvious that we have been transported to another world,” Shinobu says. “That dimensional portal that nurse Sakura talked

about... it ran over us and brought us here."

"Here... where?" asks Chibi.

"I don't know," Shinobu replies. "Another planet, I guess. Populated by strange creatures and anthropomorphic animals, like that big beast that locked us up just now."

"And like that hot catgirl in the lab...", Ryunosuke adds.

The others' eyes turn to her. "Hot?" Shinobu asks with a smirk.

Ryunosuke suddenly blushes. "I mean... hot... in the... in the sense of...", she stammers embarrassed. "Enough! I don't like girls. You know very well. I'm a chick, damn it!"

"Calm down, Ryu," Shinobu tells her and puts a hand on her shoulder with a smile. "Let's not lose our heads. First we have to find out where we are."

"It feels like a cyberpunk movie," says Megane. "Or maybe steampunk. Have you seen this cell? And the lab from before? The technology seems rather patchy, as if they build everything out of spare parts... But the general organization of this facility is decidedly military. Very, very interesting... Bwahahahahaha!" and he bursts out in a manic laugh. The others look at him in dismay.

"How dare they keep the heir of the noble Mendo family locked in jail? They'll pay for this!" shouts Mendo.

"Someone is approaching!" Kakugari says. Indeed, some footsteps can be heard from outside the cell. And a few seconds later, outside the cell door, another creature with distinctly alien features appears, covered in turquoise fur, with yellow eyes and a red sleeveless uniform. He holds a pad in his hand.

"Prisoners, I am Sergeant Cobalt," he says. "My job is to assess your abilities, decide what to do with you, and understand if you can be useful to the Horde. But first, can you confirm that you're not an active part of the Bright Moon Rebellion?"

“Horde? Rebellion?” Shinobu exclaims. “What are you talking about? We know nothing of that. What place is this?”

Cobalt remains silent for a moment, scanning their faces. Then he decides to answer the question. “You are in the Fright Zone, the central operational hub of the Horde’s regular army. You’ve been imprisoned for sneaking in here and you’re accused of conspiring with the so-called Princess Alliance against our commander in chief, Lord Hordak.”

“But we did nothing,” Mendo says. “We were brought here against our will.”

“This is not our world,” Shinobu adds. “We are from Earth, from another planet. We have nothing to do with you or your enemies.”

Cobalt falls silent again. Then he taps something on his pad. He mumbles to himself: “Seven prisoners... Six males and one female...”

“I’M A CHICK TOO, DAMMIT!” Ryunosuke shouts, standing up and shaking her chains.

Cobalt frowns and looks at her more closely. He corrects what he’s typed on the tablet, muttering “Five males and two females,” then turns and starts to walk away.

“Wait!” Shinobu calls him. “Where are the other girls that were with us? Why are they not here?”

Cobalt turns back to them and answers: “The other three intruders were isolated because our instruments detected strange readings in them... They are suspected to be princesses. Unlike you, who have no power, they actually show signs of magic. For this reason, they are being kept in isolation and under the strictest surveillance reserved for the most dangerous prisoners. I can tell you no more.” With that, he turns around again and walks away.

“No, wait!” Shinobu yells.

“You can’t leave us here!” Megane shouts.

“Let us out! We want to go home!” Perm, Kakugari and Chibi cry.

“This is an insult! You will pay for this!” shouts Mendo.

They get no answer. And soon all they can hear is the constant low hum of the Fright Zone’s machinery.

“What do you think, Tsubame?”

On Earth, in the Tomobiki High School gym, nurse Sakura thoughtfully interrogates her fiancé, who is wrapped in his black cloak. He looks at the debris that still covers the floor. Above them, the roof is partially destroyed, but the building does not appear to be in danger of collapsing. Benten’s space motorbike lies abandoned and leaning on its side in the middle of the gym.

“I’m no longer picking up any form of supernatural energy, Sakura,” Tsubame replies. “Whatever it was, there’s no trace of it anymore.”

“It was a dimensional portal, as I explained to you. And before it closed, it took away Moroboshi Ataru, Lum and their friends. If we want to bring them back here, we have to find a way to reopen it.”

“Unfortunately, it won’t be easy,” Tsubame says. “From what you told me, the portal was created by a combination of alien technology and magical ritual. We could try to recreate the same combination... but that won’t be enough. It will be necessary for someone on the other side to do the same thing. In fact, if the portal is not opened simultaneously from both sides, in both dimensions, the transfer will fail. The portal itself would be

unstable, with potentially disastrous consequences for the fabric of reality.”

“Then what do you suggest?” Sakura asks. “You know that I trust you absolutely when it comes to this sort of thing.”

Tsubame pauses for a moment to think. Then he answers, “Maybe we should concentrate on finding a way to communicate with the other dimension. If there’s someone there with psychic powers, or at least enough spiritual energy, we could establish a telepathic contact... Talking to them would be the first step in working together to reopen the dimensional gap.”

“So what are we waiting for?” Sakura says. “Let’s combine our energies and get to work!”

“Okay, let’s try again.”

Castaspella’s hands quickly trace the symbol of the spell in the air inside the spare room, then project it towards Ataru, Lum and Ten. “Now it should work. The truth spell will force them to tell us everything.”

“Assuming you drew it right this time,” Shadow Weaver says with a hint of sarcasm from the back of the room.

“Shut up!” shouts Angella, who then turns to her sister-in-law. “Castaspella, don’t listen to her. She’s just teasing you. Remember, you are the head sorceress of Mystacor, the realm of our most powerful sorcerers. I trust you.”

“Thank you.” Castaspella says with a shy smile to Angella. Then she glances back to the three people under her spell. “And you, now speak.”

“Uhhh, Casta... spella?” Ten says, laughing. “Seriously? What kind of names do you have here? Then my name is Breathafira! And that idiot Ataru... Womaniza Goodfornothinga!”

“Enough jokes!” says Castaspella, red in the face. “Tell us who you are.”

“We’ve already told you,” Lum replies. “My name is Lum, of the Oni race. This boy is my darling and beloved hubby, Ataru, and he’s from Earth. And this is my little cousin, Ten.”

“Don’t mind her, pretty lady,” Ataru intervenes. “I’m not her husband. We’re not married, even if she thinks we are.”

“What are you talking about, darling? You proposed to me! And you know I love you!”

“But I don’t love you! When are you going to get that through your head?” Ataru says.

Castaspella and Angella look puzzled. “But in the end, are you married or not?” the head sorceress asks.

“Yes!” Lum replies. And at the same time, “No!” Ataru says. “She’s just a ball and chain to me. But I’m free as a bird and available... if you’re interested in a date with me!”

Castaspella shudders. “Boy, I could be your mother... I mean, your aunt!” she says.

Ataru pauses for a moment to think. And then, not at all discouraged, he asks her: “Do you have any pretty daughters? Or little sisters?”

“Stop this nonsense!” Angella says, stepping between Castaspella and Ataru. Her voice makes it clear that she is losing her temper. “Let’s clear things up. Are you part of the Horde? Or are you allied with them?”

“We’ve already said that we know nothing about this Horde,” Ataru replies. “Get it into your head, once and for all!”

“They speak the truth,” Shadow Weaver shouts. “Even a child would understand that.”

“I told you to shut up!” Angella tells her. Then, after a pause, she calms down and turns to Ataru: “Boy, maybe you’re sincere. But you have to understand that all this... it’s really hard for us to accept. The very idea of the existence of other planets, of other worlds, was foreign to us until a few days ago. We have only recently learned that our own planet, Etheria, is prisoner in an isolated dimension. We have never seen the stars, let alone other inhabited worlds.”

“You’ve never seen the stars?” Lum asks astonished. “How is that possible?”

“We have only heard of them”, Castaspella adds. “From the legends.”

“But the stars are everywhere!” replies Lum. “They fill the cosmos, they dance around us. Planets, life... and the fate of mankind itself depend on them!”

Angella and Castaspella remain silent for a moment. Then Angella speaks again: “Alright, let’s say we believe you. So now...”

A sudden thud is heard behind them. Everyone turns to see Adora, Glimmer, and Bow lying on the floor, piled on top of each other, behind the wide open doors.

“Glimmer! Were you eavesdropping?” Angella asks.

“Sorry, mom,” Glimmer replies, embarrassed, and rises to stand. Next to her, Adora and Bow do the same. “But we were too curious.”

Angella takes a deep breath. Then she continues: “I should have known that it would be impossible to keep the three of you away

from anything interesting that happens in Bright Moon. Well, then. I was just telling these... guests... that they are now free to move around the castle until we decide what to do. I'll assign you guys to be their guides. In the meantime, we will prepare more comfortable accommodations for them. I do not want them to share this room with Shadow Weaver."

The three friends smile. Glimmer enters the room and walks over to Ataru, Lum and Ten. "Welcome to Bright Moon!" she exclaims. "I am Princess Glimmer. This crop-top-wearing, good-looking guy is Bow, and this blonde jock is Adora. Together we are the Best Friend Squad. Come on, let's show you the castle!"

Ataru and Lum glance at each other for a moment, then follow the three out of the room. Ten catches up with them, flying through the air.

Seeing the child, Bow's eyes light up. "Wow, this is the cutest baby in the universe! How am I supposed to do anything when something this cute exists?"

Ataru rolls his eyes. Lum smiles. Adora and Glimmer exchange an amused look and continue down the corridor, followed by the others.

"You know, Bright Moon is one of the largest and most important kingdoms on Etheria," Glimmer says, continuing to walk. "And it's the headquarters of the Princess Alliance, the beating heart of the Rebellion against the evil Horde."

"Princess Alliance..." Ten says. "That means... everyone here is a princess?"

"Almost everyone," Bow answers. Then he becomes sad for a moment. "I might be the only one who is not a princess."

"Why would you want to be a princess?" Ataru asks him.

"Why not?" Bow replies. "Princesses are beautiful, strong and brave. They fight against the bad guys. And they have magic

powers. Glimmer, for example, can teleport and throw sparks... And earlier you saw Perfuma, Mermista, and Frosta, who each rule their own kingdom, using their magic to control the plants, the sea, and the ice, respectively."

"Lum is a princess too!" Ten exclaims enthusiastically.

"Yes, we've seen that you have special abilities," Glimmer says, addressing the alien girl. "You can emit electric shocks... and fly, right?"

"Yes, but Ten didn't just mean that. I'm a princess, even if not officially... because my dad rules on Oniboshi. He's the main warlord of the planet!"

"Warlord?" asks Adora excitedly. "As in he's a conqueror? Like Hordak?"

"He's an invader!" Lum replies cheerfully. "He does it for a living, but he's not very good at it. Most of the time he fails miserably. Like when we invaded Earth, for example. Darling here single-handedly forced our entire army back."

Adora, Bow and Glimmer stare at Ataru in surprise and admiration. "Wow...", Adora says. "You must be really strong, Ataru."

Ataru laughs and puts his hand behind his neck. "I'm a true champ, yes."

"Darling was able to grab my horns after only ten days," Lum continues. "And so we Oni retired peacefully, as agreed. But I decided to stay at his side, because I fell in love with him!"

"Unfortunately!" Ataru and Ten say in unison.

Adora and her friends look confused.

The group walks to the large outdoor garden. After a few steps, they sit down on a bench and Lum, legs crossed, starts talking

again, saying: “I wonder where Shinobu and the others are? We must find our friends and then return to our world.”

“The girls must be saved at all costs,” Ataru agrees. “But Mendo, Megane and those other idiots... as far as I’m concerned, they can stay where they are!”

“How can you say such a thing?” Bow replies, shocked. His voice cracks. “And the value of friendship? Doesn’t that count for anything?”

“Are you for real, dude?” Ataru says.

“Either way, you came through Hordak’s portal...” Glimmer says. “I don’t think it’s going to be easy to open another one.”

“The last She-Ra made it so we could never open another portal,” Adora confirms. “But somehow Entrapta managed to do it, using my sword, so she has proven that it can be done. But going back to the Fright Zone to ask for her help is too dangerous. What if Hordak and Catra take the sword back?”

“Who are these people?” asks Ten.

“Hordak is the cruel lord of the Horde. He has been trying to take Etheria by force for many years,” Bow replies. “He wanted to open a portal to communicate with a vast army in space, and have it come all the way here to help him.”

“Entrapta was one of us, a princess, I mean...” Glimmer adds. “She’s an expert scientist and an avid robot builder. But for some reason, she switched sides and allied herself with the Horde.”

“And Catra... well...” Adora says, lowering her eyes. “Catra used to be my best friend. But she didn’t mind staying on the path of evil and fighting against us... against me. You must have seen her before, in the lab. She was the girl with the cat ears and tail!”

“Oh yes, that stunning beauty with the slim body, brown hair, beautiful freckles on her face, and two different colored eyes!”

says Ataru. “Do you happen to have her phone number?”

Adora frowns.

“Stay away from her!” Glimmer says. “She’s dangerous, treacherous... and irritating! She really is the worst!”

“I’m born for danger,” Ataru says. “You’ll see, one way or another I will be able to convince her to go out with me.”

Adora suddenly feels the urge to put her hand on the sword. But before she can make a single move, an electrical discharge from Lum’s fingertips electrocutes Ataru and crushes him to the ground. Within a few seconds, however, the boy is back on his feet, shaking as if nothing had happened and regaining his stupid smile.

“But... is he always like this?” Glimmer asks, pointing at Ataru.

“Even worse!” replies Ten.

“Darling is an inveterate womanizer,” Lum adds. “All he thinks about is women.”

“Such behavior is highly frowned upon here,” says Bow. “It could even be considered sexual harassment!”

“Even where we come from, really,” Lum says. “I only tolerate it because I love him…”

Suddenly the alien stops talking, changes her expression and bursts into tears.

“Lum, what’s going on?” Glimmer asks surprised.

“D-darling... Darling said earlier that he doesn’t love me... that I’m just a ball and chain! And that woman cast a truth spell! So darling was telling the truth! And I... I had always hoped...”

Ataru turns around in embarrassment.

“Don’t worry,” Glimmer says, leaning in to hug the crying Lum. “It’s a very complicated spell, and difficult to cast correctly. And aunt Casta always had trouble drawing it without mistakes. My dad was one of the few sorcerers who always knew how to do it well. Or so they tell me, since I can’t remember him. He fell in the war against the Horde when I was very young.”

Lum hiccups a few more times. Then she calms down and says to Glimmer, “I’m sorry...”

“Don’t be”, the princess replies. Then she turns to everyone else. “Enough sadness. You know what we can do to cheer ourselves up? Let’s raid the kitchens!”

“Good idea!” says Adora. “I’m hungry as a wolf!”

“Me too!” Ataru says. “What have you got to eat here?”

“Sweets and cakes of all kinds,” Bow answers. “Ideal for an afternoon snack. Let’s have a look!”

And with that, the six friends make their way back into the building.

“Well, Sergeant Cobalt?” Catra asks, her voice echoing through the corridors of the Fright Zone.

“My assessment is complete, Force Captain,” the turquoise-furred official replies, consulting his pad. “I believe the seven prisoners in cell B1 can be drafted into our ranks, provided they first undergo intensive training. They don’t have great fighting skills, although one of them seems to be well trained in the use of a sword. However, they all show considerable resistance to physical damage, making them potentially good infantry. Moreover, the two

female specimens are also endowed with surprising strength, much higher than what their body type would suggest."

"Very well, Sergeant. But those seven are of little interest to me. The other three, however, the ones who claim to be 'aliens', whatever that word means... are definitely more interesting. I don't know if they are princesses or not, but they certainly have something special about them. I want to question them myself."

"Yes, Commander. According to your orders, they are locked up in cell A1 under maximum surveillance. There are guards watching them around the clock."

"Excellent. And now..."

Catra is interrupted by the arrival of her fellow Force Captain Scorpia, who approaches her at a brisk pace. "Scorpia, I warn you. If you try to hug me, I'll lock you in a cell too!" the feline yells at her.

"Oh, um, sorry, Wildcat," the tall scorpion woman says, stopping short, ten feet away.

"What do you want? I don't have time to waste," Catra says.

"Hey, so, I know you made a heat of the moment decision which I totally get, but, um, you didn't really want Entrapta to stay on Beast Island forever. Anyway, I was thinking we could go back and get her? I mean, she is our friend", Scorpia says.

Catra grows pale. As if the nightmares that have plagued her every night since she banished the tech princess weren't enough – not to mention the stupid guilt that hangs over her for what she's done, and the enormous desire to make things right with Adora that boils inside her – now Scorpia is making it worse.

"Again?" the catgirl replies, her glance hardening. "Entrapta betrayed us, and she got what she deserved."

“But she didn’t betray us. She wanted to save us from the portal...”

“A portal that didn’t work! All those stories about the world being destroyed were just talk. The only thing the portal did was bring this bunch of idiots here. And besides, we lost Adora and the sword after working so hard to capture them!”

“But...” Scorpia says.

“Leave me alone. And go away, I don’t need you anymore.”

Saddened, Scorpia begins to walk away.

“Oh, and Scorpia?” says Catra.

Scorpia stops. A smile returns to her face as she turns to the catgirl.

“Keep Emily out of my sight or I’ll sell her for scrap. Understood?”, Catra says, before walking away down the corridor towards the detention cells.

After standing still for a moment, Scorpia also walks away, determined to protect Emily, Entrapta’s pet robot, in any way she can, now that her friend is no longer in the Fright Zone to do so in person.

“Darling, stop eating like that!” says Lum. “You’ll get a stomach ache.”

“But these cakes are so good!” Ataru replies between bites.

Bow and Glimmer look at him astonished. They are sitting cross-legged on a carpet on the floor of Glimmer’s room in Bright Moon,

surrounded by plates full of cake. “I never thought I’d find anyone with an appetite like Adora’s,” Glimmer says. Next to her, said blonde girl is also busy devouring large quantities of food.

“And you should see nurse Sakura,” Ten says. “Nobody beats her when it comes to eating. She’s really something.”

They all laugh together. Finally, the situation relaxes a bit.

“So, you were explaining us about She-Ra...” Lum says.

“Ah, right,” Bow continues. “Like I said, thanks to the magic sword of the First Ones, Adora can transform into this eight-foot warrior princess with incredible power...”

“Who are these First Ones?” asks Ten. “You mentioned them before.”

“They were an ancient civilization that colonized Etheria over a thousand years ago. Before they mysteriously disappeared, they left behind several artifacts and ruins, full of strange devices with very advanced but also dangerous technology. Only Entrapta understands something of it. It’s said that they knew how to travel between worlds. But they also did something mysterious to the planet itself. And it’s their fault that the portal was so unstable.”

“And this She-Ra is a princess, right?” Ten asks. “Lum-chan, you told me Shira-hime’s fairytale once. Are they the same person?”

“Shirayuki-hime,” Lum points out. “And no, Ten, I don’t think so. Shirayuki is an Earth princess. Of course, the names sound alike... It’s an extraordinary coincidence.”

“Even the names Earth and Etheria look similar in a way,” Bow says. “I wonder if there’s a connection... Maybe our worlds are the equivalent of each other in parallel dimensions!”

“Bow, now you’re just diving into some wild theories!” Glimmer scolds him.

“Lum, I notice you don’t eat much,” Adora says between bites. “Don’t you like sweets?”

“I do, Adora,” Lum answers. “But these are a little bland for my taste. Couldn’t we add some sauce like Tabasco or chili?”

Glimmer stares at her, eyes wide. “Tabasco?”

“Don’t mind her,” Ataru says. “Lum is an alien, remember? This idiot only likes spicy food... very spicy!”

Lum sticks out her tongue and smiles at Ataru, who sticks out his back and smiles himself.

Bow looks at them and grins. “Aaaw, how cute. It appears that you’re very close... and in love!”

“Don’t be absurd!” Ataru says. “I already told you that she is a ball and chain for me!”

“And you?” Lum asks. “Glimmer and Bow, you’re together, right?”

“W-what?!” the boy and the girl answer in unison, embarrassed. “What do you mean?”

“It seems obvious to me from the way you act around each other,” Lum replies.

“N-no... We’re just best friends!” Glimmer says, blushing. Bow, for his part, seems to have lost his words.

Lum stares at them, perplexed. Then she turns to Adora. “And you, Adora?”

“Me what?” the blonde asks, stopping eating for a moment.

“Are you in love with anyone?” Lum asks.

Adora instantly freezes. She too blushes visibly, but at the same time her eyes fall on deep sadness. “N-no...” she answers. “I was

raised in the Horde. And there, interpersonal relationships are strongly discouraged...”

“You grew up in the Horde? Really?”

“Yes,” Adora says. “I’m an orphan, or so I was told, and I was raised by Shadow Weaver. You know, the masked creepy lady who was locked in the spare room with you? She’s the one who trained me. And pretty harshly.”

“I understand,” Lum says. “I had my share of strict teachers, too. Like CAO-2 or Crab-sensei...”

“She was actually more than a strict teacher,” Adora says. “She made me suffer a lot, but especially made Catra suffer.”

“Catra? But isn’t Catra your enemy?” asks Lum.

“Catra and I grew up together, as I told you,” Adora answers. “We were very close until I found the sword and left the Horde to come here to Bright Moon. She’s not a bad person, or so I hoped... But then she decided to open the portal, even though she knew the consequences would be disastrous.”

“Then why did she do it?” Ataru asks.

“She makes bad decisions,” Adora answers. “That was one of them. Luckily, there were no irreparable consequences. Otherwise, I don’t know if I would have been able to forgive her. Even now, to tell the truth, when I think of her, I...”

But before she can continue, a strong tremor runs through the room. A flash of lightning shakes the entire surrounding reality. Then everything calms down.

“What was that?” Ataru yells in horror.

“The same strange phenomenon as before,” Bow says.

“A fracture in the reality...”, Adora says. “It’s the portal’s fault! Entrapta was right. Reality itself is breaking down... We are in danger!”

“Great. Just great,” Glimmer says. “What could be worse?”

“Is there any food left?” asks Cherry, suddenly materializing among them and beginning to gorge on cakes.

An explosion follows. As the smoke clears and the boys and the girls rise from the floor with blackened faces, the monk adds: “And here I am, my friends. Frankly, I was expecting a more... traditional welcome.”

Chapter End Notes

> The title of this chapter is a fusion between the titles of She-Ra (2018) season 2 episode 3, “Signals”, and Urusei Yatsura (1981) episode 116, “The Glove of Love and Conflict”.

And Then There Was Nobody Taking Control

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Who is this... annoying creature?” asks Shadow Weaver, not hiding the deep loathing in her voice.

“Don’t mind me. I’m only here for the food,” says Cherry, the object of such loathing, as he continues to gorge, sitting at the table between Ataru and Adora, who keep him company.

“Hold your tongue,” Angella says to Shadow Weaver. “We didn’t release you to insult our guests. Though I must say, the amount of food that monk is devouring is beginning to make him a rather... unwelcome guest.” Glimmer glances at her mother in silent reproach.

“Then why did you decide to let me out of my prison?” the sorceress replies. “Have you finally realized that I pose no threat to you? I’m not the villain in this story. Or perhaps it’s because of those flashes of destructive energy I felt earlier?”

“That’s right,” Castaspella confirms. “As much as it pains us to admit it, you’re a master of dark magic, and we may still need your help. We have to understand what it is and what danger we are in.”

“The portal is to blame,” Adora says, interrupting her meal for a moment. “Perhaps reality did not suddenly collapse as Mara and Entrapta feared, but something catastrophic did happen. And surely Hordak’s portal had something to do with it.”

“Adora’s right,” Shadow Weaver says. “This is not about dark magic, but something far more serious. Being trapped in the void dimension of Despondos should have made it impossible to open a portal on Etheria, but somehow the princess of Dryl, Entrapta, managed it.”

“When Catra pulled the lever,” Adora adds, “I had a very bad feeling. As if nothing was right anymore. Everything around me was falling apart. And then there was nobody taking control. But it only lasted a moment.”

“You felt what could have happened if the portal had not been stabilized by some incredible and fortunate coincidence,” Shadow Weaver says. “We must thank the one that was opened at the same time on the other world, bringing your... guests here. Otherwise, reality would have been destroyed instantly, or at least at a much faster pace than what is happening now. So maybe we still have hope instead.”

“And what would that be?” asks the queen.

“We must reopen both portals. These intruders must return to their own world. Their presence on Etheria unbalances the fabric of reality. Only by putting everything back in its place will the fracture be healed and the universe become stable again.”

“How much time do we have?” Angella asks.

“Not much,” Shadow Weaver replies. “Each flash seems to last longer than the one before. Soon reality will be unable to withstand the strain, and that will be the end of us all.”

“Glimmer, summon the other princesses,” Angella tells her daughter. “Call a meeting. We must decide what to do about this now.”

Benten glances over the energy barrier that seals off the Fright Zone cell where she and her two companions have been locked up. “That catgirl is coming back again,” she says.

“Ugh, once more?” Ran exclaims. “But what does she want with us? And why did she isolate us from the others? Not only did I end up here without doing anything wrong, as usual, but I have to share a cell with you two!”

“Cut it out, Ran!” Benten replies sharply. “Instead of complaining, let’s figure out how to get out of here.”

“Do you think that this catgirl is an inhabitant of the planet Nekoboshi?” Oyuki asks. “She looks a lot like Ginger, one of the three middle school girls who insist on challenging us all the time. Although Ginger only has cat ears and no tail...”

Meanwhile, the aforementioned feline has reached the cell door. The force field lowers for a moment to let her in. The two guards accompanying her remain outside. “Prisoners, stop wasting my time. Confess once and for all. You’re princesses of the Alliance, aren’t you?” she asks the three alien girls.

“I’m not a princess, Miss Cat, but the queen of planet Neptune,” Oyuki replies, keeping her tone deferential. “And it’s very rude of you to hold us here. If you don’t release us soon, we will release ourselves. We have only remained patient and calm out of good manners since we are on your planet.”

“You better listen to her, kitty!” Benten adds defiantly. “Oyuki seems so calm and friendly, but believe me, you never want to see her angry.” Ran shudders behind her. She remembers what her friend’s wrath can be like.

The feline hesitates for a moment, then bursts into laughter. “You think you impress me?” she says. “You’re addressing Force Captain Catra, second-in-command of the Horde, conqueror of the Crimson Waste, and terror of Etheria. I’m not going to be intimidated by some third-rate princess. Come on, quickly, tell me again where you come from and what your intentions are.”

“Ugh, again?” Benten retorts. “Look, we’ve already explained to you that we ended up here against our will. We are from other

planets. Let us go. We have to find our friends."

"Other planets, huh?" asks Catra. "Have you ever heard of the Galactic Horde? Do you know Horde Prime?"

"Never heard of them," says Benten.

"Then you're lying. According to my boss Hordak, his big brother Prime is a big shot, and has long ruled undisturbed over much of the galaxy."

"The galaxy is much bigger than you think, kitty," Benten replies. "Besides, there are so many races and peoples that it's certainly not easy for someone to rule over everything. Most of the galactic peoples coexist peacefully. Most wars are now fought just for fun... or for the sake of a challenge. My own race, the Gods of Luck, know something about this."

"Rubbish!" Catra yells. Looking away from Benten and Oyuki, the Force Captain then focuses on Ran, who had remained silent during the entire conversation. "You with the pink hair. Why do you not speak? Do you have nothing to say?"

"I don't know anything, I've nothing to do with this," Ran whimpers. "I always get into trouble because of Lum-chan and those two, but I'm innocent! I just want to go home to my beloved Rei!"

"Damn it, Ran!" Benten yells at her. "Have some dignity! You can't blame everything on Lum!"

"You talk to me about dignity?" Ran retorts. "After years of you and Lum involving me in your pranks? But don't worry, it's Lum I hate the most. Sooner or later she will have to pay for everything!"

"Lum, huh?" says Catra. "She's the green-haired girl who left with Sparkles, Adora and the other princesses, right?"

“Yes, that’s her,” says Ran. “She has been tormenting me ever since we were childhood friends! I’ve always suffered the pains of hell because of her. We were always together, doing the same things, but it was always me who was punished! Ah, how I hate her!” And as she speaks, her hair rises, her teeth grow sharp, and an evil aura swirls around her.

Catra gazes at her in astonishment and rapture. “C-childhood friend?... Suffered?... P-punished?” she whispers softly, staring at Ran with a strange intensity.

“That’s right! I would do anything to take revenge on her! Even unleash death and destruction!” says Ran.

Catra remains silent for a moment. Then a smirk appears on her face. She claps her hands. “Guards!” she calls. “Take the handcuffs off this pink-haired prisoner and get her out of here. I want to talk to her, face to face. I feel I can trust her. We have a lot in common. Leave the other two in the cell.”

Ran smiles. Benten and Oyuki look surprised and worried.

Scorpia walks slowly and somberly through the corridors of the Fright Zone. Behind her, a few steps away, a cute spherical robot follows suit.

The Force Captain stops, turns around and says to the robot, “Emily, I told you to stay in my room. Don’t show yourself around or Catra will get angry! You know she’s having a bad time... You’ll see, soon she’ll be in a good mood again, and she won’t threaten you anymore. Maybe she will also change her mind about Entrapta and agree to bring her back from Beast Island...”

The robot makes a series of noises. Then it turns and runs back.

Scorpia sighs, then she starts walking again. After a few steps, she reaches her destination. The large training room where new recruits are briefed. She sighs again and says to herself, "Come on. You can do this. Push down doubts and insecurities," and she opens the door.

As she approaches the desk, she looks at the rows of chairs in front of it. Seven seats are occupied by the prospective new members of the Horde, the seven 'earthlings' (as they define themselves) who have come through the portal. Along the walls, a few standing guards are supposed to keep them from escaping.

Another sigh, and Scorpia, standing in front of the desk, smiles and begins her speech. "Uh, guys... Welcome. I'm Force Captain Scorpia. Nice to meet you, really. I've been assigned to oversee your training and teach you the most important things you need to know if you really want to become a Horde soldier."

"If we really want…?" replies Megane. "I don't think you're giving us any choice!"

"Exactly," Shinobu adds. "You're practically forcing us!"

"Joining an evil army wasn't exactly my life goal!" Ryunosuke says.

"Come on," Scorpia replies with an embarrassed laugh. "I know the job doesn't look good... in fact, it totally sucks... and the benefits aren't exactly appealing. But if you take it the right way and put in the effort, there will be plenty of career opportunities. You will also make a lot of friends. Oh, and the food is great. Sometimes we even have the gray kind of ration bars, not only the brown kind!"

The earthlings look at each other in silence, puzzled.

"So, let's get started," Scorpia says, then tries to pull a sheet out of a folder. But her pincers cause all her papers to fall to the floor. "Oops," she says. "Well, it doesn't matter. What I wanted to tell you is that the Horde expects you to help us conquer all of Etheria and to eradicate the threat of the princesses."

“Threat?” Shinobu asks. “Are princesses dangerous?”

“Oh yes,” Scorpia says. “They are powerful and completely devoid of conscience. Vicious, violent instigators who don’t even know how to control their powers. At least that is what Lord Hordak says. To tell the truth, I’ve met a few, and they didn’t seem so terrible... Besides, I’m a princess myself.”

“What?” the gang ask.

“That’s right,” Scorpia says. “The whole Fright Zone used to be my family’s kingdom, but then Hordak showed up and... well... you know. The rest is history.”

“I don’t understand,” Perm says. “You’re a princess? And yet you fight them?”

“Now that you mention it, I admit it makes little sense...” says Scorpia.

“That’s not the only thing that doesn’t make sense here,” says Mendo.

“Anyway!” Scorpia says, clearing her throat. “Now let me introduce you to my assistants.” From the door at the back of the room, three soldiers enter: a buff girl with shoulder-length brown dreadlocks tied back in a ponytail, a frail and rather fragile-looking blond boy, and a tall anthropomorphic lizard. “Their names are Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. They will be your training partners. And they will take care of guiding you through the Fright Zone, showing you the barracks where you will sleep, the mess hall, the gym for combat training, the weapons and armor storage, and the workshop where they will make your uniforms.”

“Uniforms?” Ryunosuke asks, suddenly interested. “Can we choose them? Will I finally be able to have a female uniform?”

“I’m afraid the uniforms for the cadets are mostly unisex,” a confused Scorpia answers. “But why would you ever want a female uniform, dude? Not that I’m judging, mind you, but...”

“I’M A CHICK, DAMMIT!” Ryunosuke yells.

Scorpia freezes for a moment. Then she apologizes embarrassed: “Sorry! I’m so sorry if I offended you! I didn’t mean to be insensitive! I promise to use proper pronouns from now on! I just... I can’t quite figure out what pronouns to use with you. But you’ll see that I will learn: I promise!”

Suddenly, a flash of lightning shakes the room. It’s as if reality is being torn apart and reassembled on the spot. It ends in an instant, but everyone remains in suspense for a moment.

“Oh boy,” Scorpia laughs. “These strange phenomena are becoming more frequent. Maybe the weather is changing. Well, guys, I will now leave you to my assistants to show you around. See you later. Have a nice stay!” And with that, she exits the room, leaving the seven earthlings in the company of the three Horde soldiers.

“...and then there was the time when Lum-chan, while we were playing as children, destroyed my mother’s favorite doll with a dart,” Ran says. “When my mom asked if it was her fault, the coward denied it. And so I got so many spankings because of her!”

“Tell me about it,” Catra replies. “Adora once convinced me to sneak into Shadow Weaver’s lair with her, taking advantage of her absence, even though we were always forbidden to do so. But the witch came back and discovered us... And of course, she only punished me, while for Adora there was a reproach so tender that it almost seemed like a gesture of affection.”

The two girls sit cross-legged, facing each other, on the bed in Catra’s private room, exchanging experiences. The more they talk, the more it seems to Catra that she has finally found a kindred

spirit, someone who can understand how she feels and how much she has suffered all these years.

"Lum was my best friend, but for one reason or another everything worked out well for her," Ran adds, "and I paid the price."

"I hear you," Catra says. "A lot of bad things have happened to me, too. And it's always Adora's fault. Everyone thinks she's special, while no one seems to recognize my worth. No matter how hard I try, how much effort I put in... what I do never seems to be enough for anyone. And the more I think about it, the more I realize that everything that has gone wrong in my life is because of Adora."

"It's the same for me. Every failure of mine, every humiliation, was always Lum's fault," Ran adds. "And it happened with love as well... I had fallen in love with a beautiful boy, and of course she took him away from me. And the worst thing is that she left him after a short time because she realized that deep down, she didn't even like him!"

"I too have suffered in love because of... Adora. We used to talk of ruling the world together, but then she left... and she broke my heart. She always wanted more... but all I ever wanted was her," Catra says, surprising herself with the words coming out of her mouth: her feelings are a subject she has never mentioned to anyone before. How is it possible that this alien girl with curly and fluffy pink hair has the power to make her open up like this? "But that's all over now. I've decided that this is a closed chapter in my life. All I can think about now is revenge. Against her and against the princesses!"

"I hate princesses!" Ran exclaims. "Lum is a princess, Oyuki is a queen, Benten is even a fucking goddess of luck! But I'm nothing... just their victim."

Catra watches her with sincere pity.

“And... I’ve been trying to get back at Lum for a long time, too,” Ran continues. “I usually target her darling, but sometimes I try to hit her directly. Yet I have always failed, even though I have a lot of aces up my sleeve. For example, I have experience with some esoteric magic techniques... and then I’m very good with technology! My specialty is building robots, although I usually prefer to make them very small, like explosive dolls, which I also use to send messages!”

“You can build robots?” Catra wonders. “What a lucky coincidence! We had a sort of Chief Technology Officer who specialized in robotics, but... we had to let her go.” The catgirl pauses for a moment to think. Then she glances at the alien and says, “If you’re interested, I could offer you to take her place.”

“Could I take revenge on Lum-chan this way?” Ran asks.

“Of course!” Catra answers. “On her and all the others. All those who never saw your worth and made you suffer.”

A smirk spreads across Ran’s face.

“Give me your hand! Together we will do great things... my friend!” says Catra. Ran wastes no time in shaking hers.

As they step out of the Horde cadets’ gym, still sweating from training, Lonnie nudges Ryunosuke with her elbow. “You’re so cool, Ryu!” she says with a smile. “Really good at close combat. You surprised me. You will surely become a perfect Horde soldier!”

Ryunosuke blushes at the compliment. “Thanks, Lonnie... I’m not interested in becoming a soldier, but I like fighting. On Earth, I was forced into it by my reckless dad. I always had to fight him since I was a child, and that’s how I learned to defend myself.”

“Shinobu did well too,” Lonnie adds, looking behind her as the other cadets leave the gym and walk down the hall. “I almost couldn’t believe my eyes when she grabbed Rogelio and catapulted him over her head!”

“Yes, she looks so weak and vulnerable, but she has hidden superhuman strength,” Ryunosuke laughs. “The others are useless instead.”

Behind the two girls, Shinobu supports Mendo, gently helping him to walk. Rogelio follows, his uniform slightly torn. And then all the others appear, battered and limping.

“Ugh!... If they had left me my samurai sword, I would’ve done much better!” Mendo says.

“And here I was complaining about gym class at Tomobiki High!” says Kakugari.

“I feel all broken up!” adds Perm. “I can’t make it if training is like this every day.”

“I don’t understand why we have to learn hand-to-hand combat when this army has all these weapons and armors,” says Megane. “When are they going to give us an exoskeleton or laser cannons? I can’t wait!”

Last in line are the two smallest and thinnest of the group: Kyle and Chibi. Kyle looks shyly at the boy next to him and says, “Um... so... are you bullied by your friends too?”

“Um, yeah,” Chibi answers just as shyly. “Especially by Kakugari. But I must say that he’s also the one who protects me the most. Deep down, he cares for me... and I care for him. Friendship is the only thing that keeps me going.”

“I understand,” Kyle replies. “Me too, without Rogelio... I mean, without my friends, I would be lost. And I’m glad that you’re going to be part of our team from now on. We really needed reinforcements!”

“Is your war going that badly?”

“Honestly, I don’t know... Lord Hordak is always locked up in his laboratory, and even Catra never tells us anything. You know, she used to be our friend, too. But lately she has become more and more distant and grumpy. Maybe the power has driven her mad... or maybe it was Adora’s abandonment. The two of them were so close. I never imagined that they would find themselves fighting each other, on opposite sides of the war. And to think that when Adora was here, she was the one who wanted most to rise in the ranks of the Horde. Catra had always seemed less interested in that. She just liked to wreak havoc and mayhem... with Adora at her side, of course.”

After a brief stop at the barracks to clean up and change clothes, the group heads for the mess hall. “I guess you’re hungry,” Lonnie says.

“You can really say that!” Megane replies. “What I wouldn’t give for a bowl of curry ramen!”

“Or a double order of yakisoba!” adds Perm.

“You’re thinking too small! I want sukiyaki with lots of meat!” says Kakugari.

“Or some okonomiyaki,” shouts Chibi. “With shrimp and otafuku sauce!”

But when they approach the food counters, each with their own tray in hand, the earthlings are perplexed. “What is this stuff?” they say. There are only unsettling gray bars on the counters, with a texture and composition that is hard to figure out.

“How lucky!” Kyle exclaims. “Today we have the gray kind of ration bars! Yum!”

Rogelio, next to him, lets out an enthusiastic growl.

Shinobu, Ryunosuke, and Mendo raise their eyebrows.

Once at the tables, when they taste the ration bars, the reaction is even worse.

“What is this crap?”

“It’s inedible!”

“I refuse to eat this disgusting stuff!”

This time it’s Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio who look at them baffled. “You don’t like it?” Lonnie asks.

“Not even in the lowest street food stalls have I ever tasted anything like this,” Mendo says in disgust.

“Well, just try to like it,” Lonnie says. “There’s nothing else here. Either eat this or starve.”

In the end, hunger wins out, and everyone resigns themselves to eating the rations.

Between bites, Ryunosuke talks to Lonnie again. “Listen... can I ask you something?”

“Of course. Go ahead,” the girl answers.

“Why is there no difference between men and women here? You live together, sleep together, fight together... wear the same uniforms... Do you ever feel the need to look more feminine?”

Lonnie stares at her for a moment, unable to fully comprehend the question. “What do you mean? What kind of difference should there be?”

“I always wanted to be more like a girl,” Ryunosuke says. “Delicate and elegant like Shinobu, for example, or like Ran. That’s my dream. But I don’t know how to do it, I’m even afraid that I’m not capable of it... Instead, I see that you don’t seem to have a problem acting like a guy... You’re tough and even

muscular like a boy. Does that not bother you? Don't you want to learn to be more feminine?"

Lonnie thinks for a moment. Then she replies: "I am who I am. No one is forcing me to be more masculine or feminine. And anyway, I would see no reason to appear any different than I am. Why would I do that?"

"Well, because girls are nicer... prettier... more attractive..." Ryunosuke answers confused. "Don't you think so?"

"Not really... What do you mean?" Lonnie asks.

"But... seriously!" Ryu says. "How can you not see it? Even among you in the Horde, there must be nice girls who try to be pretty and take care of their appearance. That catgirl from earlier, for example: didn't you notice the eyeliner she wore, or her tight and elegant uniform?"

Lonnie bursts out laughing. "Catra?" she says. "You just picked the wrong example! If there's anyone around here who's not kind or nice, it's her. She's always angry, she's violent, she's upset with everyone and the whole world!"

"Is she so mean? What's her problem?"

"Where do you start?" Lonnie laughs again. "Her whole personality is her problem. But I guess it all goes back to the way she was treated by Shadow Weaver. You know, that sorceress raised her, basically like a mother. But whatever Catra did, she didn't like it. The witch abused her her whole life, ever since she was a little kid. It has been pure hell. I almost feel sorry for her."

Ryunosuke stops to think. Her face becomes sad. And then she says: "I understand... I know what it's like to grow up with a parent who demands too much from you. I always had problems with my dad's expectations."

Lonnie puts her hand on her shoulder. "But you're here now. Forget your father. He doesn't count anymore. Here in the Horde,

all that matters is how you behave, how you defend yourself, how you fight. The expectations of others should have no value."

Ryunosuke gives her a glance, and smiles.

Strange noises are coming from Entrapta's former laboratory in the heart of the Fright Zone. Scorpia, who was walking along the corridor outside, stops in front of the door. There is no doubt: someone is working inside, using the tools and equipment the princess of Dryl had brought from her castle.

A smile spreads across Scorpia's face and she opens the door impatiently. "Entrapta!" she shouts. "You're back? I knew Catra wouldn't let you..."

Her sentence is cut short when she sees that the person tinkering in the lab is not Entrapta, but one of the girls who came through the portal, the one with the curly pink hair. She wears a welding mask and is working on something mechanical. At her side, assisting her work, stands Catra herself. Large sheets of plans and drawings are spread out on a nearby table.

Irritated by the intrusion, Catra turns and addresses Scorpia. "What do you want?"

"Uh, hi, boss," the scorpion princess replies. "I didn't expect to find you here. What's happening? What are you doing?"

"As of today, Ran will be putting her skills at the service of the Horde," Catra answers. "She's designing a new weapon that will allow us to defeat Adora and those damned princesses once and for all."

Ran herself interrupts the welding for a moment, lifts her mask and smiles. "Hello," she says to Scorpia. "I'm building a giant

robot! Powered by a Virtual Energy Recovery system, its codename will be... Oni Killer, model A. It's going to be incredibly cute! I'm thinking of giving it my likeness, even if Catra-chan is unsure about that!"

"C-Catra-chan...?" Scorpia asks, perplexed by the alien girl's sudden familiarity towards the feline.

"Now go away, Scorpia, we have to work!" Catra orders. "And don't bother us anymore. I've no time to waste with you!"

"But I..." Scorpia says.

"Go away!" Catra shouts. "Find something else to do! Go check on the other prisoners, for example. But leave us alone!"

With her tail between her legs, Scorpia storms out of the room. First her new goons from the Crimson Waste, now this bizarre girl: it seems that Catra is doing everything to replace her with new friends. A sharp pain grips her heart.

Somberly, Scorpia follows the corridor leading to the detention cells.

Noticing her arrival, the two guards on duty at the cell door stand at attention. "Rest," the Force Captain says. "You can go. I would like to talk to the prisoners alone."

The guards leave. Scorpia opens the door and enters the cell. Benten, who was dozing, opens her eyes and says, "Ugh, what is it now?"

"Hi, girls," Scorpia says. "I... I came to see how you're doing. Do you need anything?"

"Are you kidding us? Tell us instead: where are our friends? And how are they?" asks Benten.

"They have begun training to become soldiers of the Horde," Scorpia answers. "And I guess they are making progress. As for

the girl with the pink hair...” Scorpia’s face darkens. “...Catra has taken her under her protection. After sending Entrapta to Beast Island, she wasted no time in finding a replacement...”

“Entrapta?” Oyuki asks.

“Yes, she was my friend…”, Scorpia says. “You know, she was the one who helped Hordak build the portal that brought you here.”

“And what is Ran doing together with Catra?” Benten asks.

“I think she’s building a new weapon to be used against the princesses. Oh, but maybe I shouldn’t tell you these things. You know, since you’re our enemies and all... But are you really enemies? I don’t understand anything anymore... I should probably get some rest...”

And turning around, Scorpia leaves the cell. The energy portal closes and the two guards return to their positions in front of the door.

Benten winks at Oyuki. “It’s time to get out of here,” she says.

The queen of Neptune nods. Snowflakes begin to form in the air around her.

“Why do you disregard my orders, Force Captain Catra?” says Lord Hordak, who is examining the remains of the destroyed portal machine in his laboratory. At his feet, the little Imp sits on the floor, playing with a piece of metal. “I said I didn’t want to be disturbed, especially not by you. You have disappointed me greatly. Not only did you set off the portal machine before it was ready, but you couldn’t even prevent the Rebellion from infiltrating the Fright Zone.”

“Yeah, like I said before, it was Entrapta who...”

“I told you never to mention that name in my presence!” shouts Hordak. “Fortunately for you, it is possible that my signal to Horde Prime went through. At least I hope so. That’s the only reason you’re here instead of facing punishment for your failure.”

“Don’t worry,” Catra replies. “Now I have something better in mind. Let me introduce you to someone...” Behind her, Ran steps forward. Hordak stares at her curiously.

“Good moooorning!” the alien girl chirps, hopping. “My name is Ran. And I’m building you a beautiful and very giant robot that will defeat Lum-chan and your princesses in the blink of an eye!”

“A... giant robot?” Hordak asks, curious.

“Exactly, a giant robot”, replies Catra, with ill-concealed pride. “This girl is skilled with technology *and* black magic. She was able to develop an energy source that will make this machine virtually unstoppable. Ran, explain to Lord Hordak how it works.”

“It’s very simple,” Ran says. “The Virtual Energy Recovery system draws energy from its surroundings and transfers it to the Oni Killer model A... and I mean any kind of energy. Even magical! This planet seethes with magic, though for some strange reason much of it seems to be trapped by some form of archaic technology that keeps it at its very core. But in the air, in the trees, all around us, there is still enough magic to give my robot incredible strength and make it invincible. The princesses won’t be able to defeat it, because if they try to get close to it, the VER system will suck their energy as well!”

“Hm...” Hordak mutters. “Interesting...”

“Sucking other people’s energy is my specialty, after all!” Ran smiles.

“Don’t you want to conquer Etheria before your big brother Horde Prime gets here?” asks Catra. “He doesn’t sound like the type to

accept failure."

"What do you suggest, Force Captain?"

"We will attack Bright Moon with the Oni Killer model A robot," says Catra. "Thanks to it, getting through the treacherous Whispering Woods and finding the right path will be child's play. But that's not all: at the same time, we'll perform a disturbance maneuver to distract the princesses, and in the meantime, we'll launch an attack on Salineas and destroy the Sea Gate. That way, we will control the seas, and they will have no way to come to each other's aid."

"Very well," says Hordak. "I'm impressed. Is that all?"

"There is one more thing," Catra says. "I want to go back to the Crimson Waste."

"To do what?"

"There is something there that we must recover. Something very important that would be dangerous if it fell into the hands of the princesses. Give me permission to assemble a team and leave as soon as possible. In the meantime, we will plan our other attacks."

Hordak takes a step forward. "Proceed, Force Captain. It is time to conquer this planet once and for all."

Summoned by Glimmer, the princesses of the Rebel Alliance quickly enter the council chamber of Bright Moon and take their respective seats. Ataru, Lum and Ten watch them curiously. The first to arrive are Perfuma, Mermista and Frosta, whom they have already met. Ataru tries to wink at Mermista, but is immediately scowled at by the girl, who has come accompanied by an

eccentric mustachioed guy with a red neckerchief, who sits next to her. “Darling, behave yourself!” Lum scolds, nudging him.

There are also other princesses that Ataru and Lum haven’t met yet. “These two are Spinnerella and Netossa, two of our strongest and most experienced warriors,” Bow whispers to them, pointing to a pair of princesses sitting side by side, a slim, dark-skinned girl with black eyes and fluffy silver-blue hair, and a wide-hipped girl with light pink skin and long lavender hair. “And that’s Huntara,” he adds, pointing to a tall, huge girl with an extremely built physique and white hair pulled back in a long ponytail, intent on chopping a piece of wood with a large knife. “She’s really tough, be careful not to make her angry!”. Huntara looks at them sideways. Ataru feels a shiver run down his spine.

Lum has taken off her school uniform and is now displaying only her skimpy tiger-striped bikini. Some of the princesses, especially Mermista, stare at her with a slight blush, perhaps because they are not used to such uninhibited clothing.

“And then there’s...” Bow continues.

“Did someone say Swift Wind?” Suddenly, a winged white unicorn enters the room.

“No one said Swift Wind!” Glimmer shouts at him.

“But you just did!” the animal replies.

“No, I meant... Ugh!” Glimmer says. But she lets Swift Wind sit at the table anyway, making room for him. Ten glances at him in surprise.

“Lum-chan, did you see that? A talking horse!” the kid says.

“It’s probably normal on this planet for horses to talk, since no one else seems surprised,” Lum answers.

Queen Angella also sits at the table, flanked on one side by Castaspella, her sister-in-law, and on the other by Shadow

Weaver, the dark sorceress whom everyone here regards with suspicion. There is even Cherry, in a corner, though most of those present try not to pay attention to him. Next to Bow, of course, are Adora and Glimmer. And it is the latter who begins to speak.

“You too have probably felt the recent flashes that threaten the fabric of space-time,” she says. “They’re a result of the Horde portal that Catra recently opened. While we were able to recover Adora and her sword, the opening of that portal created an instability that we must correct before the consequences are catastrophic.”

“What can happen that is so serious?” asks Perfuma.

“Reality will not withstand the strain,” Shadow Weaver interjects. “And soon it will be destroyed, collapsing in on itself.”

A murmur of both shock and concern fills the room.

“Unfortunately, Shadow Weaver is right,” Castaspella says. And after a brief pause, she adds: “That felt weird to say... However, we must act quickly to remedy this situation.”

“And what can we do?” asks Mermista. “I don’t think our powers can fix this.”

“Should we punch Hordak and Catra?” Frosta offers, wrapping large ice gloves around her hands.

“Reality is made unstable by the presence of the people who came here from the other dimension,” Shadow Weaver says. “Not just these four intruders,” she adds, pointing at Ataru, Lum, Ten and Cherry sitting at the table, “but also the other ten who have remained in the Fright Zone. We must find a way to send them all back to their own world.”

“I wouldn’t ask for anything better!” says Ten.

“But how can we do that?” asks Adora. “We are not able to open portals, even with my sword at our disposal... Only Entrapta can,

but I really don't think it's a wise choice to bring the Sword of Protection back to the Fright Zone and give it to the Horde..."

"No, Adora, it isn't," Shadow Weaver says. "For one thing, we have no guarantee that Entrapta and Hordak's machine still works. If you recall, it was destroyed during the transfer of these people here to Etheria. Also, its behavior was abnormal from the beginning. Something interfered with Hordak's portal, and we're unlikely to be able to replicate the anomaly unless we figure out what it was first."

"I know who was responsible," Cherry says suddenly. Everyone turns to him with curiosity, waiting for him to continue.

"It was..." the monk resumes "...this boy," he points at Ataru. "His fate is one of misfortune. I can see it written on his ugly face!"

A huge wooden hammer, somehow materialized in Ataru's hands, falls on Cherry's head.

"Cut the crap!" Ataru replies. "It's your fault and your damn niece's! You were the ones who told us that you performed a strange ritual that interfered with Lum's UFO technology."

"What? A ritual?" Castaspella asks.

"Yes. This old man is a Buddhist monk. And his niece is a Shinto priestess. Whenever they get together to deal with spirits, exorcisms and magic, they always cause all kinds of problems!" says Ataru.

"I don't really understand everything you're saying," Castaspella says, "but if that's true, it explains a lot. Somehow you created a portal on your world and opened it at the same time as the one Catra opened here. This produced an interference: a link was established between the two portals, bringing the two dimensions into contact."

"Then all we have to do is the same thing again," Glimmer says. "We need to open a portal here and one there at the same time,

and they can go back!”

“That’s easier said than done,” Shadow Weaver states. “First of all, and I have to reiterate this, allowing Entrapta and the Horde to tinker with Adora’s sword to open another portal here on Etheria is very dangerous. Second, we should find a way to contact someone in the other dimension so they can open a portal from their side. And finally, have you forgotten that the other ten Earth travelers are still prisoners in the Fright Zone? There is no way to escape from those cells... I managed it, but it was almost a miracle, and I have great powers of black magic. I don’t think a handful of ordinary kids can...”

Her sentence is interrupted by the arrival of two Bright Moon guards who enter the war room. “Your Majesty!” one of them says, turning to Queen Angella. “There are two visitors who came here in a Horde skiff. They seem to have flown through the Whispering Woods.”

“What?” Angella asks, rising to her feet. “Who are they?”

“Excuse us...” Oyuki says, entering with extreme elegance, walking with short steps in her white winter kimono. “Hey Lum, what’s up?” Benten greets, raising her arm in a salute and coming beside her, laughing.

“Benten! Oyuki!” Lum shouts and flies towards them, happy to see her friends again. “You are here? How did you escape?”

“It wasn’t difficult,” Benten says. “The cell and the guards certainly couldn’t withstand the fury of Oyuki’s frost. And as soon as I saw the flying vehicles in their hangar, I couldn’t resist stealing one to get here. The engine is not quite as powerful as my space bike, but it still flew at full speed, and it was a lot of fun.”

“And Ran? Shinobu? Ryunosuke? Shutaro, Megane and the others?” Lum asks.

“Ran has joined the enemy,” Benten answers, suddenly bitter. “We had to expect something like that from her. Ugh, she’s the usual troublemaker. Apparently, she became very close friends with that damn catgirl who captured us.” Hearing these words, Adora turns pale.

“The others were forcibly recruited into the Horde,” Oyuki adds. “We could not free them, not without the two of us fighting an entire army alone.”

The princesses around the table glance curiously at the newcomers. Angella orders the guards to bring two more chairs and invites Benten and Oyuki to sit down as well. “It seems that there is a way to escape from the Horde cells, after all,” she says with a smile while turning to Shadow Weaver.

“It seems so,” the dark sorceress admits reluctantly. “But there is still the problem of freeing the other eight prisoners. And, of course, finding a way to communicate with the other world, as well as opening a portal without returning She-Ra’s sword to Entrapta in the Fright Zone.”

“Entrapta?”, Benten asks Oyuki. “Where have I heard that name before?”

“Don’t you remember?” the queen of Neptune replies. “That scorpion woman told us about her... She said that Entrapta was banished by Catra to a place called Beast Island.”

“Beast Island?” Adora gasps. “With the blood beetles? And the trees with razor-sharp blades instead of leaves? It’s real?”

“Oh, yes,” says Shadow Weaver. “But it’s much worse than that. We told you those children’s stories so you wouldn’t be scared.”

“But then... we can’t just leave her there,” Adora says. The other princesses look puzzled.

“What do you mean?” asks Mermista.

Adora continues: “If Catra and the Horde banished Entrapta, that means she’s no longer on their side. We could rescue her and bring her to Bright Moon. And she could help us open the portal here, safely!”

“Entrapta and ‘safely’ are not words that go together in the same sentence,” Bow says. “She has a habit of blowing up everything she touches. But you’re right, Adora. We have to save her! She is our friend!”

“She *was* our friend, you mean,” Mermista corrects. “She betrayed us, remember?”

“Who knows if we can trust her again!” Frosta says.

“And then, Adora, have you ever heard of anyone coming back from Beast Island? Do you even know where it is?” says Perfuma.

“No...” Adora answers sadly. She remains mute for a moment. Then, pulling herself together, she adds: “But we have to try. Does anyone have any idea how to find and reach Beast Island?”

Everyone remains silent. Then Lum asks innocently, “Don’t you have a spaceship?”

Chapter End Notes

> The title of this chapter is a fusion between the titles of Urusei Yatsura (1981) episode 75, “And Then There Was Nobody!?”, and She-Ra (2018) season 5 episode 6, “Taking Control”.

Promise to Catch the Heart

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"So, let's recap," Queen Angella says. All around her, the people sitting around the table in the war room listen intently. "We have two missions to accomplish simultaneously, and we cannot afford to fail. The first is to retrieve Mara's abandoned spaceship from the Crimson Waste. If we're lucky, we can use it to find a way to reach Beast Island, rescue Entrapta, and bring her back safely. She will help us open a new portal here in Bright Moon."

"Great!" says Bow. "I just hope we can get the ship up and running again. The last time we were there, it didn't exactly look in good shape..."

"We'll help you," says Lum. "Benten, Oyuki and me are quite familiar with space travel technology!"

"The second, possibly more dangerous mission," Angella continues, "will be to free the other earthlings held captive in the Fright Zone. I don't like the idea of sending a group of our warriors back there again, but there is no other choice if we want to return everyone to their world."

"Don't worry, mom!" Glimmer says. "Teleporting me and a team over there will be a piece of cake. Shadow Weaver has shown me what my magic can accomplish when I let go of my inhibitions!"

"That's what really worries me," Angella says.

"Your daughter is stronger than you suspect," Shadow Weaver says. "Have trust in her and her immense potential."

"In the meantime, I will try to find a way to open a line of communication to the other world," Castaspella says. "Perhaps with the help of this monk," she points at Cherry, "we can contact

someone on the other side and ask them to open a portal themselves."

"We'll contact my niece Sakura," Cherry says. "And her fiancé, Tsubame. If there is anyone in Tomobiki with the necessary spiritual energy, it is them."

"Good," Angella says. "At this point, we only have to decide how to divide ourselves up, that is, who will participate in each of the two missions."

"I'll go to the Crimson Waste," Adora says. "Mara and her ship still hide many secrets, some of which concern me personally, and I want to find out. Besides, it would be risky to bring She-Ra's sword back to the Fright Zone."

"I'll go with you, Adora," Bow says. "I'll have to repair the ship."

"Me too, blondie!" Huntara adds. "It's been a long time since I've been back to the Waste, I need to check how things are going there without me."

"Oh, Bow," Glimmer says beside him. "That means we have to split up, since I need to be part of the mission in the Fright Zone. Promise me you'll be careful and stay out of harm's way!"

"Don't worry, Glimmer. Remember, we have She-Ra with us. What could possibly happen to us?"

"I'm going to the Fright Zone with Glimmer, of course," Shadow Weaver says. "I must help her improve and control her teleportation power."

"I don't like this idea at all," Angella says. "But unfortunately, it's inevitable. But I warn you, witch, do not try to pull any tricks on her, or my revenge will be terrible."

"If you really don't trust me, why don't you come with us to keep me under control?" the sorceress replies.

“You know very well that I cannot leave Bright Moon unguarded and the runestone unprotected,” the queen replies. “The Horde would take advantage of it immediately. But rest assured, the other princesses will come with you. They will help free the prisoners and keep an eye on you at all times.”

“Yes!” says young Frosta. “We’re used to sneaking into the Fright Zone by now! We’ve done it twice already!”

“Don’t make me think about it,” says Mermista. “I still have bad memories of those sewers.”

“Don’t worry, dearest,” says Sea Hawk. “I will be by your side, protecting you from any danger.”

“Ugh,” says Mermista. “I guess I can’t help it...”

“We will also come with you!” Spinnerella says, holding hand with Netossa, who is sitting next to her.

“No, Spinnerella,” Angella tells her. “I would like you and your wife to accompany Adora, Bow and Huntara to the Crimson Waste. I don’t want them to go alone. It’s still a hostile environment, and we can’t afford any unexpected setbacks. Only Perfuma, Frosta, Mermista, and Sea Hawk will go to the Fright Zone, along with Glimmer and Shadow Weaver.”

“Don’t forget me!” Swift Wind interrupts. “This time, I will not be left behind! I will follow She-Ra on her mission as her faithful steed.”

“And us?” Benten interjects. “We don’t want to stay here and sit back. We want to participate too!”

“It would be dangerous to send you on a mission as well,” Angella says. “The purpose of this operation is to return you all to your own universe. If one of you goes missing, or worse, is killed in battle, all our efforts will be in vain.”

“We’re tough guys!” Benten adds, putting her arm behind Oyuki’s shoulders. “This one girl, for example, could defeat most of your enemies all by herself. Not to mention Lum with her electric shocks. And I’m very good at fighting with my bare hands. I’m a tough nut to crack. Trust us!”

“All right,” Angella says after a moment’s thought. “We may need all the strength we have. If you really wish to be involved, you may do so. Benten and Oyuki, you will join Glimmer and the princesses on their mission in the Fright Zone to free your friends. Ataru and Lum, you will instead go with Adora, Bow and the others to the Crimson Waste and then to Beast Island to rescue Entrapta.”

“And me?” asks Ten.

“Ten-chan, it’s too dangerous,” Lum says to her young cousin. “I want you to wait for us here, together with Cherry, aunt Angella and aunt Casta. Agreed?”

Ten is disappointed, and he doesn’t seem convinced at all. But he looks down and replies, “Okay...”

“Very good,” says Angella. “Then get ready. Let’s not waste any more time. I’m sure everything will be fine!”

“Great, mom, you’re amazing!” Glimmer exclaims, happy to see her mother finally taking on the attitude of a dynamic and proactive leader.

Shouts of approval and cheers fill the war room as everyone rises to their feet and prepares for action.

“Careful,” Catra says to the four-armed lizard girl, who is carrying several crates of technological materials from the makeshift site in

the narrow canyon where the Horde has set up its outpost. “We need this junk intact so Ran can perfect her robot.”

“Sorry, boss,” the horned goon girl says, trying to keep her friend from dropping the crates. “We’re not so good at carrying things without breaking them. We are much better at scavenging!”

“Whatever,” Catra says. “Be more careful. All material that was on the spacecraft must be sent to the Fright Zone immediately. Once that is done, we will decide what to do with the ship itself, whether to scrap it or not.”

“Yes, boss!” the horned goon girl replies, walking away with her partner and helping her hold up the crates. In the distance, other Horde soldiers are moving more equipment.

“Pff!” exclaims Catra, running a hand through her hair. “I’m surrounded by idiots. And thank goodness I ordered Scorpia not to come with us to the Crimson Waste. She would have been too much. To command these troops, I don’t need anyone else... except you, of course, Force Captain Ran!”

“Uh, how good that sounds!” laughs the pink-haired girl, coming from behind a crate. “Force Captain Ran!” she repeats. “How intimidating!” The alien is wearing a modified Horde uniform. To the black and red colors, she has added an apron and pink lace ribbons, while the Force Captain badge is tied in a bow around her neck. “Ran-chan is sooooo happy!” she says.

“Restrain yourself, Force Captain,” Catra hints. “Remember why you are here. You have to supervise the dismantling of the spaceship. Fortunately, we were able to get it before the rebels arrived. I’m sure Adora would have loved to get her hands on it before we did. But for once, we got there first!”

“It’s a really interesting ship,” Ran says, looking up. Above them stands the gigantic craft, lifted up by some supporting pillars. “I think I’ve never seen a design like this before. A bit primitive, maybe, very minimalist in the lines and crude in the user

interface. But we will undoubtedly acquire many useful components to improve the Virtual Energy Recovery system and automate its input circuitry in the future... Perhaps we can upgrade the Oni Killer from model A to model B sooner than the projected timeline."

"I'll pretend to understand," Catra says, typing some information into the tracker pad she's holding.

"Now I'm going to see if the main engine parts have already been loaded onto the transports," Ran says. And jumping with joy, she walks away.

Catra sighs, rolls her eyes, and returns her attention to the pad. But only a few moments pass before her ears hear footsteps approaching from the opposite direction the alien girl left. She turns to see Ran coming towards her again.

"Are you back already? That was fast," Catra says.

"What, did you miss me already?" Ran asks her with a wink, moving closer until her face is inches from Catra's.

"Have you checked the engine parts yet?" says the catgirl.

"Nah, these guys look like they've got it covered," Ran replies, raising her arm and pointing at the soldiers outside. Then the girl clicks and winks again. "I'd rather hang in here with you."

Catra squints suspiciously and growls before pushing Ran against a crate.

"What's going on?" she says angrily.

And just then... another Ran enters the area, humming from the direction she went before. "Everything is fine! Looks like the engine's already loaded. I did..." Seeing a copy identical to herself, the girl stops short. After a few seconds, she yells, "What's going on? I had no idea the Horde had the technology to make copies of people! Did they use a duplicator gun or a space copier? And

anyway... how come my double doesn’t have the prime symbol to distinguish itself from the original?”

Catra’s eye twitches. Then she turns back to the other Ran, her hands still on her shoulders, and asks: “Who are you and what exactly are you trying to pull?”

The other Ran smiles mischievously before changing form. In front of Catra’s and Ran’s astonished eyes, the creature returns to their original appearance: a reptilian being with a slender build, light green skin and elf-like ears. Catra screams and stumbles back. Ran gasps, eyes wide.

“Pleasure to meet you, kitten,” the shapeshifter says. “The name’s Double Trouble, and I’m about to become your new best friend.”

“Oh yeah?” Catra glares. “I’m done with best friends.”

“But why?” Ran interjects. “I thought I was your best friend now...”

“No, I meant...”, Catra says. “Ugh, whatever, let’s forget it.”

“Hello, dolly,” says Double Trouble, this time to Ran. “And who are you, mmm?”

“Me?” replies the alien girl. “I’m Ran-chan.”

“A lovely doll, indeed,” Double Trouble comments with a soft smirk.

“Enough!”, Catra tells the shapeshifter in an irritated tone: “What do you want from us?”

“It’s not what I want from you, it’s what you want from me...”, they answer with a wicked smile. “For a price, of course.”

Large birds fly over the group of princesses as they walk across the sand of the Crimson Waste desert, trampling with each step. The landscape is dotted with occasional dunes, with a few cacti scattered about. Huntara leads the party, followed by Adora and Bow, then Swift Wind, Ataru and Lum, and finally Netossa and Spinnerella.

“I can’t believe the Horde beat us to the ship,” Adora says. “But I should have known: Catra is always one step ahead of us lately.”

“Ugh, the sun is so hot... It’s enough to fry an egg!” Ataru complains, sweating.

“What’s a sun?” asks Swift Wind.

“Don’t you know what the sun is?” Ataru wonders. “Oh yes, you’re an animal. You don’t have enough intelligence to grasp the things we humans understand thanks to our superior brain.”

“It’s not like that,” Bow tells him. “There is no sun on Etheria. The light you see comes from a system of moons. Remember, we are in Despondos, an isolated and dark dimension. We have neither stars nor sun!”

“Well, with the heat in this desert, you wouldn’t think so!” says Ataru.

“Darling, please, would you rub some sunscreen on my back?” Lum asks, flying to his side.

“Not a chance!” Ataru complains. “We’re not on vacation! Besides, I’d rather rub it on someone else...”

“And on whom?” asks Lum pouting.

“On her, for example!” Ataru answers and approaches Netossa enthusiastically. “Miss, may I put some sunscreen on your back?”

“Ew, go away!” Netossa replies, hastily dismissing him and hurrying back to Spinnerella’s side. The wind princess smiles and takes her wrist. The two walk on, hand in hand.

“Darling, you were unlucky!” Lum laughs. “I really don’t think that princess is interested in you!”

“Whatever,” Ataru comments disappointed. “It’s her loss. But I’m sure that I will catch her heart sooner or later. Where are we going anyway?”

“I don’t know... But Adora and that other buff woman,” she says pointing at Huntara, “seem to know their stuff.”

“It seems to me that they don’t have all their marbles,” Ataru comments. “Did you see how they tasted the desert sand before?”

“It must be a local custom,” Lum comments. “Let them do it their way. They are the experts here.”

“Halt!” Huntara signals. Everyone behind her stops.

“What is it?” Bow says.

“Have we arrived?” asks Swift Wind. “I’d really need a water trough and some grooming...”

“I should have known!” says Huntara. “They took the ship to the Valley of the Lost.”

“Is it a nice place?” Bow asks. “From the name, it doesn’t seem like a nice place.”

“It’s a smuggler’s haven and my home,” Huntara answers with a menacing expression.

“Oh... It’s a nice place then!” Bow says with a tentative smile.

Huntara motions for the group to move on. As they pass a large cliff, a valley stretches out before them, full of houses, bridges

and people.

“How big it is!” says Adora. “How are we supposed to find anything in there?”

“This has been my gang’s base since I arrived here,” Huntara answers. “Nothing can hide from me in this valley. Follow me and don’t say a word. The valley seems to be crawling with Horde soldiers.”

Leading the way, she begins to descend into the vast canyon.

In Bright Moon’s throne room, Glimmer snorts before addressing her mother. “By now Adora and the others must have reached the Crimson Waste. Maybe they’ve already found Mara’s ship. What are we waiting for to go on our own mission?”

“Patience, Glimmer,” Queen Angella answers. “Although I’ve agreed to let you take this risk, you will not leave until you have worked out a foolproof plan.”

“The plan is simple, mom,” the princess replies. “Teleport us to the Fright Zone with my powers enhanced by Shadow Weaver. Defeat the Horde soldiers. Free the imprisoned earthlings. And come back here. Simple, like I said!”

“You don’t know how many soldiers will be waiting for you, and whether you’ll have to fight Force Captains... or maybe even Hordak himself,” Angella says. “You don’t know if the earthlings are still locked in their cells, or if they’ve agreed to become Horde soldiers instead. And most of all, you don’t know if we can trust Shadow Weaver.”

“Mom, I assure you!” Glimmer says. “She helped us before, and she will again. She has no reason to be loyal to Hordak. By the

way, where is she now? You didn't lock her back in the spare ro... in the prison?"

Angella takes a deep breath. "No," she answers. "She's with your aunt Castaspella and that old monk. They are trying to establish telepathic contact with the other world. But I don't think they're making a lot of progress..."

Just then, Castaspella enters, gesturing angrily. She is obviously upset. "I can't do this! I can't do this!" she shouts, walking over to Angella and Glimmer.

"What's wrong, aunt Casta?" the princess asks worriedly.

"The monk is driving me crazy!" replies Castaspella. "I've never met anyone so annoying!"

Glimmer laughs. "What are you talking about? You're trying to work with Shadow fucking Weaver, and you find a harmless old man annoying?"

"Language, Glimmer!", says Angella.

Castaspella sighs. "You have no idea," she replies before bringing her hand up to her face.

"I'm sure your vast experience in managing the sorcerer community will help you overcome such minor difficulties," Angella tells her with a sour smile.

"No, listen, I..." Castaspella says. "No... you know what? I will step aside. I'll let Shadow Weaver work with him alone. Even though she's an evil and power-hungry person, she's also a skilled manipulator. I'm sure she'll be able to get away with..."

"I can't stand him anymore! I'm going crazy!" Shadow Weaver shouts in frustration as she walks into the throne room.

Angella and Glimmer look at each other in confusion. "You too?" Glimmer asks her.

“That Cherry is getting on my nerves,” the sorceress replies. “If he keeps this up, I will need therapy! A long therapy!”

Angella stays silent for a moment, as if trying to find the right words. Then she shakes her head and asks: “Where is Cherry now? Did you leave him alone?”

“You won’t believe this,” Shadow Weaver replies. “But after devouring half the food in the kitchens of your castle by himself, after tormenting us with his bad omens, after disappearing and reappearing from nowhere at the most intrusive and unexpected moments, after spouting sibylline phrases, absurd proverbs and cursed prophecies, after repeatedly insulting us by saying that our faces are deeply unfortunate, constantly with the same ugly expression... he suddenly caused a random explosion in the middle of the room. I don’t know what came over me, but I couldn’t help but throw him out of the tower window!”

Angella blanches, convinced that she didn’t hear correctly. “Did you... did you throw him out of the tower?”

“I can’t believe it either,” Shadow Weaver confirms.

“But then you killed him! He must be dead from the fall!”

“I’m afraid we’re not that lucky,” Castaspella interjects.

“It’s incredible that he’s still alive,” Shadow Weaver adds sheepishly. “I saw him trotting off into the Whispering Woods. I don’t know why he went there, and I hope he never comes out again. As for me, I have a strong and sudden craving for a relaxing chamomile herbal tea. Double chamomile.”

“I’m coming with you,” says Castaspella. “And let’s make it triple.” And she and Shadow Weaver walk out of the throne room side by side, leaving Glimmer and Angella staring at each other in bewilderment.

“Rebels! Stop...” the Horde soldier warns, just before a gust of wind blows him into the air, slamming him against the wall of the alley behind and then sending him sprawling to the ground.

“And that makes five!” says a smiling Spinnerella, whose powers caused the gust.

“Tsk! Amateur!” Netossa retorts as one of her energy nets knocks out two more soldiers. “I’m already at eleven!”

“Are you really competing to see who can defeat the most enemies?” Ataru asks, hiding on his knees behind a large crate.

“Darling! Cheer for me!” Lum yells at him, as she flies across the narrow street in the agglomeration of houses and huts at the bottom of the valley, before emitting an electrical discharge that electrocutes a soldier on the spot. “That brings me up to fourteen!”

“Ugh, this Lum is a tough one,” Netossa comments. “I’m going to have to try a lot harder if I want to win... I wonder if I should start doing some research to find out what her weakness is?”

“Can I join the competition?” comments Swift Wind, kicking a soldier. “But I’ve lost count... Am I at five? Or six? Maybe six! I should have brought a scoreboard...!”

“Be careful! Reinforcements are coming!” Bow shouts.

And indeed, from a side street filled with tattered shacks, more soldiers run forward, this time accompanied by three battle robots bearing the insignia of the Horde. Adora wastes no time in coming forward. “These are mine!” she says.

And raising her sword to the sky, she recites the words “For the honor of Grayskull!”, which transforms her into She-Ra.

“Wow!” Ataru says, admiring the girl’s glowing transformation into an eight-foot-tall warrior. “That was a sequence worthy of a magical girl anime! And she really is a rare beauty. I absolutely have to ask her out again!”

While Adora, now She-Ra, easily gets rid of the robots by slicing them with her sword, Bow and Huntara take care of the last remaining soldiers. Soon there are no more enemies in the alley around them.

“Obviously our presence in the valley has not gone unnoticed,” Huntara says. “Probably Catra and the other soldiers who are looting the ship are already waiting for us. And I’m sure my former goons are with them, too.” She grits her teeth. “Well. I just never got a chance to fire them. I’ll fix that now.”

“But where did they take the ship?” asks Swift Wind. “It’s not here in the midst of these slums. How do we find it?”

“I can help with that!” says Bow. He holds something in his hand that he took from one of the unconscious soldiers. “Horde badges have tracking devices built in. I can hack into their system and see where most of the Horde soldiers are in the valley!” He brings his track pad closer to the badge, pulls out a cable, and plugs it in. “There you are! They’re in that canyon just outside the village.”

“We can’t attack like this in the open. It’s not wise,” Spinnerella comments.

“Don’t worry, I’ve a plan,” Adora says. “I will go forward as She-Ra to divert Catra’s attention. She’s definitely the most dangerous foe.”

“You can’t go alone, Adora,” Bow says. “What if Catra is accompanied by Scorpia or some other Force Captain who is very strong or has strange powers?”

“Ugh, all right,” Adora admits. “Netossa and Spinnerella will come with me. While we distract Catra, you, Bow, together with Ataru and Lum, will sneak aboard the ship and try to get it to take off

and carry it away. Huntara and Swift Wind will cover your back and stand guard at the edge of the canyon, preventing the other Horde soldiers from interfering. All clear?”

“Yes!” the others answer in unison.

“Then let’s go! We can do this!”

Entering the dense forest, attracted by an enticing aroma of food, Cherry reaches a grassy clearing, at the edge of which, near the trees, lies a bizarre hut. The doorway is protected by a curtain. The scent comes from inside.

“May I come in?” Cherry asks, pulling back the curtain and entering the hut. “Is there anything to eat, by any chance?”

“Razzle Dazzle!” a voice shouts. And a broom falls on his head.

“Ouch!” Cherry says. “What the...?”

“Loo-kee, go away!” yells a tiny, elderly woman with a bushy nest of gray hair. She is the one holding the broom. “The berry pie isn’t ready yet! I told you you had to wait before you could taste it!”

“Dear madam, perhaps you have mistaken me for someone else...” says Cherry.

The old lady adjusts the large round glasses on her nose, watches him carefully for about ten seconds, and then says: “Ah, Cherry, dearie, it’s you! Why did you say you were Loo-kee? You’re always joking!”

“I didn’t say I was anybody...” protests Cherry.

“Always joking, yes, always! You and Loo-kee are just the same. You’ll never change!” And turning, she approaches the oven, from which comes a sweet smell of pie.

“Hmm... that smells good!” Cherry says. “But how do you know my name?”

“Silly! How could Madame Razz not know your name, Loo-kee?” the old woman replies, putting on her gloves and taking the steaming pie out of the oven.

“I said I’m not Loo-kee! Can I have a piece of pie, please?” Cherry says, reaching for the pan.

The broom falls hard on Cherry’s head again. This time, however, the broom magically moved on its own, without Razz holding it.

“Ouch!” says the monk.

“I told you to wait, Loo-kee!” Razz says. “It’s too hot. A few more minutes.”

Cherry looks at her in confusion. “You know, madam,” he says after a moment. “There is something very strange here... I sense a bad omen. Perhaps you’re possessed by an evil spirit.”

Razz laughs. “Evil spirit? Don’t say such silly things, dearie! There are no evil spirits here. Just me and my friends.”

“What friends? I don’t see anyone else,” says Cherry.

“Nonsense!” says Razz. “I’ve got Broom here, and my friend Loo-kee too! But he’s always hiding.”

“There’s really something wrong with you, madam,” says Cherry. “And you remind me of my sister, Sakura’s mother. She’s a stubborn one too...”

“Ah, I forgot!” Razz suddenly exclaims. “While we wait for the pie to cool, there is something that I have to give you. I promised

you!”

“And when did you do that? This is the first time we’ve met!”

“You’re so funny, Cherry dearie!” Razz says, rummaging in a drawer. “Always, always joking! But where did I put it?”

Cherry is so perplexed he doesn’t know what to think.

“Oh, there it is! I found it!” shouts Razz, pulling a strange object out of the drawer. It looks like some kind of chip, irregularly shaped.

“What is it?” Cherry asks.

“Mara left it for Adora,” Razz answers, handing the object to Cherry. “She wants to talk to her. I promised to get it into her hands, but that was before everything changed. Time is no longer what it used to be. Now it’s your turn, Cherry dearie, to take it to Adora.”

“To Adora?” Cherry asks. “The blonde girl with the sword?”

“The sword, yes!” laughs Razz. “You see? When you want to, you understand things, Loo-kee.”

“I’m not... Never mind!” Cherry says, tucking the chip into his robe. “But okay. I’ll give this thing to Adora. Can I have a piece of pie now?”

An energy net hits two Horde soldiers standing at the edge of the outpost, knocking them unconscious.

“Boom. Nets,” Netossa comments with satisfaction. “If I haven’t lost count, that makes sixteen for me.”

“The usual braggart,” Spinnerella comments next to her. A whirlwind rises from her hands, carrying three more soldiers into the air. “They won’t bother us anymore.”

“Catra’s over there!” Adora exclaims, noticing the feline girl at the back of the tent, next to some crates. “She’s mine! You make sure there are no other Force Captains.” And she jumps forward, running with her sword in her hand.

Seeing her coming, transformed into She-Ra, Catra smirks at her. But strangely, she doesn’t utter any of her usual provocative phrases, preferring to run away instead. She-Ra, of course, pursues her, as she always does.

Upon reaching the edge of the canyon, Catra stops and turns around. Adora stops as well. “You can’t escape, Catra,” she says.

“Are you sure?” she replies. And with extreme agility, she climbs along the rock face.

She-Ra leaps to the top as well. The two rivals find themselves on a ridge. Adora transforms her magic sword into a lasso, and with a quick movement, wraps it around Catra’s body.

“Are you out of form?” she asks with a smile. “It’s never been easier to catch you.”

“Who says you caught me?” laughs Catra. And indeed, unbelievably, she breaks free. *How did she do that?* Adora wonders. *I’m sure I was holding her tight, leaving her no room to move.*

Before She-Ra can react, Catra is already close enough to kick her. Adora tries to block the blow with one arm, but Catra takes the opportunity to leap onto her shoulders and somersault past her, landing behind her and delivering a hard punch to her back, followed by another kick to the back of her knee.

This isn’t her usual way of fighting, Adora thinks, surprised. Her affected leg gives way, and she finds herself in a half-kneeling

position, from which she quickly rises. She turns to see Catra running along the ridge. She immediately throws herself back in pursuit, further away from the ship.

Meanwhile, back at the outpost, Netossa and Spinnerella look around to see if there are any more soldiers to defeat. At one point, they hear the sound of clapping hands. And from behind a crate someone steps forward... Catra again!?

“What? You’re here?” asks Spinnerella. “But who was Adora running after?”

“I have to admit,” Catra replies with a mischievous smirk. “Every time I delude myself into thinking that the Rebellion could pose a potential threat to us, you immediately prove me wrong by demonstrating your colossal stupidity. It’s so easy to fool you!”

“I don’t know what trick you used, but don’t underestimate us,” Netossa tells her. “You have no chance against an experienced warrior such as myself.”

“Oh, really?” Catra laughs. “Your ridiculous nets may be effective against ordinary Horde soldiers, but they are useless against real threats, like me.”

Without giving her a moment to react, Netossa pulls out a spray bottle of water, points it at Catra, and douses her. The catgirl, wet and startled, screams and tries to jump away. In response, the princess catches her in a net. Catra falls to the ground.

“You were saying?” Netossa laughs.

Catra, stretched out on the ground and harnessed, hisses.

“Well done, darling,” Spinnerella says to her wife, standing a few feet away. “Now let’s make sure there are no other enemies.”

“You’re right,” Netossa says. “Catra rarely moves without that Scorpia. She’s probably hiding somewhere...”

“Scorpia isn’t here,” says a female voice just behind them. “But I am!”

Spinnerella turns around and comes face to face with Ran, who is tiptoeing towards her. She doesn’t have time to react before Ran’s hands cup her jaw. And then the new Force Captain’s lips meet hers. Ran is kissing her on the mouth!

Netossa stands dumbfounded and watches the scene. “S-Spinny!”

“Eeew!” Spinnerella exclaims. “What are you doing?” she says, pushing Ran away, who glances at her mischievously.

“Spinny! She... she kissed you!” Netossa yells.

“Why did you do that?” Spinnerella asks, confused. She raises her arms, ready to summon a whirlwind to strike the Force Captain. But suddenly she feels her strength failing. “What... what’s happening to me?”

“I have the ability to suck the life energy of others through my lips,” Ran explains with a smile. “Now your magic is useless! You have no power left.”

Spinnerella falls to her knees. Behind her, Netossa stands still in shock. “She... she kissed you!” she continues to stammer.

“D-darling, be careful,” Spinnerella tells her, trying in vain to get back on her feet.

“N-no one but me had ever kissed you...!” Netossa says. She is so shocked that she doesn’t notice Catra behind her, freeing herself from the net that was holding her.

“Darling!” Spinnerella cries.

But it’s too late. With her hands clenched into fists, Catra strikes her at the back of the neck. Netossa falls to the ground. Seconds later, Spinnerella lies next to her, now unconscious.

“Well done, Force Captain Ran,” Catra says. “These two are out of the game. Let’s immobilize them before they wake up and then we’ll check how Double Trouble is doing with Adora.”

Taking advantage of the fight outside, Bow, Ataru and Lum enter the ship unseen. “Damn, they looted everything!” Bow whispers, looking around. The control panels are open, cables sticking out. “I wonder if the ship can still function.”

“It’s a mess,” Lum says. She looks at the bridge and then adds: “It’s basic technology, but... it will take hours to get the connections back!”

“Well, that’s just great. My usual bad luck,” Ataru says. “We find a spaceship, but it’s a wreck! Wouldn’t it be dangerous to go into space with it?”

“But we’re not going into space, darling!” says Lum. “Beast Island is on this very planet. All we need is for the ship to fly a little. Of course, it’s in really bad shape... It seems that the Horde soldiers also took apart the main engine...”

“There’s no engine?” Bow asks. “That’s not good!”

“They took it,” Lum confirms. “We need to find the parts and put them back together!”

“Maybe they’re in all those crates we saw before we boarded”, says Ataru.

“We have no choice,” says Bow. “Let’s go back down and find them, hoping our friends have defeated the bad guys by now.”

After tying the unconscious Netossa and Spinnerella to a post, Catra and Ran make their way towards the canyon wall. Just then, She-Ra leaps off the ridge and lands with a thud in front of them. She carries her defeated enemy on her shoulders, prisoner of her lasso.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra says to her.

Adora is surprised to find herself facing yet another catgirl. “Catra! But how? I just caught you!” Astonished, she lets her prisoner fall to the ground.

“Ouch!” the shapeshifter exclaims as they returns to their original form. “Sorry, kitten, I tried my best, but distracting this goddess is one thing, defeating her is another.”

“Don’t worry, Double Trouble,” Catra tells them. “You did well. I grew up with this stupid blonde and you fooled her. That is more than enough to convince me of your abilities.” Then she turns to Adora herself: “As you can see, princess, I have much more resources than you could imagine.” And with a sudden movement, she pulls out the whip that was wrapped around her waist and takes an attacking stance. Ran retreats a few steps and hides behind her.

That whip again? Adora thinks and suddenly blushes when she sees the catgirl with the weapon in her hand. *Damn, she’s hot.*

Catra cracks her whip and lunges at She-Ra, who jumps aside just in time. With a mental command, Adora transforms the lasso that held Double Trouble captive back into a sword, allowing the shapeshifter to regain their freedom. Double Trouble wastes no time in getting behind Catra as well and positioning themselves next to Ran.

And just as the feline prepares to strike She-Ra again with her whip, and Adora raises her sword to parry the blow and counterattack, a powerful tremor ripples through the canyon. The

wall shakes, some rocks crumble. But most of all, reality itself seems to vibrate. Everything becomes bright, and for a few seconds, it feels as if the whole world has ceased to exist. Then everything returns to normal. All four combatants stand there motionless for a moment.

“What the hell was that?” Catra asks. “It’s not even the first time this has happened...”

“Another one of those flashes that threaten to destroy reality!” Adora says, lowering her sword. “They’re getting stronger!” Then she looks the catgirl straight in the eyes. “Catra, this is serious. The world is in danger. Let’s stop fighting.”

“And you expect me to believe you?” says Catra defiantly.

“If we don’t get the earthlings back to their world soon, reality will collapse for good,” Adora explains. “That’s why we’re here. We need Mara’s ship to bring back Entrapta. She’s the only one who can open a new portal.”

Hearing these words, the feline’s ears perk up. Her tail twitches nervously. “E-Entrapta...?” she stutters. Her guilt, which she had been desperately trying to keep at bay, suddenly resurfaces, along with the images of the nightmares that have been plaguing her for nights.

“Catra,” Adora says with a particularly stern and intense expression. “I know you banned Entrapta on Beast Island. Benten and Oyuki heard about it from Scorpia. I don’t know why you did it, but she was your friend too. You can’t possibly want her to stay there.” Offering her hand, she adds: “Please help us! Come with us to rescue her!”

Catra hesitates. Still holding the whip, her body shifts from the attack position. Behind her, Ran and Double Trouble look at her in confusion.

“Please!” Adora says again, still holding out her hand. Her gaze is less stern now, almost soft, pleading. The catgirl lowers her own.

Entrapta was my friend, Catra thinks. *That's true. I banished her to Beast Island. I did it out of anger, out of jealousy, out of frustration. But she didn't deserve this fate. I could use this opportunity to right one of my many wrongs... But if I do, what will be the consequences?*

"Catra-chan...?" Ran asks.

After a few moments of silence, the catgirl slowly rewinds the whip around her waist. Adora looks at her, trying to catch something in her indecipherable gaze.

"All right... Truce," Catra says.

Adora's face lights up, a smile creeping across it.

"This is not because I like you," Catra adds. "We will go together to retrieve Entrapta from Beast Island. We'll reopen a portal and send those idiots back to their universe. But afterwards... Entrapta will return to the Fright Zone. The war will resume. You won't win. The Horde will take Etheria."

Adora's smile gets wider and wider. *Did the dummy hear everything I said?*, Catra thinks. *Or just the first words?*

"Kitten, you surprise me," Double Trouble says.

"Don't we fight anymore?" Ran asks naively.

"No, Force Captain," Catra answers and turns to her. "For the moment. Change of plans. We're going to Beast Island with these idiots, make sure they don't play any tricks and try to escape in our ship. Have the engine and the other parts brought back aboard. We have to get it working again."

"Where are Netossa and Spinnerella?" Adora asks.

"No worries, princess, they're fine, just unconscious," Catra answers.

“I’ll take care of the windy one,” Ran sings. “I’ll give her one more kiss and she’ll get all her energy back,” she pivots on a foot and go back to the outpost.

Just as she passes the spaceship to reach the two prisoners, Bow, Ataru and Lum come out on the ship’s access ramp.

“Ran-chan?” Lum says, surprised to see her old friend right in front of her.

“Ran! Honey!” Ataru yells and runs towards her with open arms. “Kiss me baby, let’s get started!”

Ran punches him in the face, knocking him out. “L-Lum-chan,” the pink-haired girl says, surprised. “You’re here?”

“Benten and Oyuki told us that you had allied yourself with the Horde, but I never thought to see you in such a uniform,” Lum says, looking at the Hordak symbol – two fearsome bat wings – that adorns the girl’s robes. “How could you?”

“I just saw the right opportunity for revenge,” Ran says. Her hair stands up, sharp fangs sprout from her mouth, and her voice rises. “The Horde is the strongest side in this world. Together with them, I will easily defeat you!”

“But Ran-chan, be reasonable!” says Lum. “Don’t you want to go home? Do you wish to stay here forever? Think of Rei... Surely he’s waiting for you on Earth.”

“Rei...” Suddenly, Ran’s attitude changes. The thought of the boy she loves is enough to calm her down. Her expression becomes softer. “Oh, Lum-chan!”, Ran cries and runs to hug her friend. “I’m so sorry! I never meant for this to happen! I felt so alone! You know I would never hurt anyone... I’m cute and helpless, it wasn’t my fault.”

The alien in the tiger-striped bikini rolls her eyes, but hugs Ran back. Bow stares at them in confusion.

“What’s going on? Did we win?” Swift Wind suddenly exclaims, landing next to them from the sky. On his back is Huntara, who immediately drops to the ground.

“My former goons won’t bother us anymore,” she says. “How are things here?”

“Everything is fine!” Adora says, approaching them. Catra and Double Trouble walk behind her. Seeing them, Bow draws his bow and Huntara grabs her staff, preparing to attack. Adora wastes no time reassuring them. “No, stop. We made a truce.”

“A truce?” Huntara asks.

“We can take the ship,” Adora replies. “Catra will come with us to Beast Island to retrieve Entrapta. Saving reality from destruction takes precedence over the war... at least for now.”

Bow lowers his weapon. Huntara, confused, puts down her staff as well. “Can we trust them?” she asks.

“I hope so,” Adora answers, glancing in Catra’s direction.

“What about you, Ran-chan?” Lum asks. “Will you come with us?”

“Of course, Lum-chan,” Ran smiles at her. “You know I will always be on your side.”

“I hope you’ve no bad intentions...”

“Why? Don’t you trust me? You’re mean, Lum-chan...”, the girl whines.

“It’s just that I know you all too well,” her friend replies.

On the sidelines, unseen by the others, Catra approaches Double Trouble and whispers to them: “I and Force Captain Ran will go with the rebels to Beast Island to retrieve Entrapta. But in the meantime, I have a mission for you. If you accomplish it well, you’ll be handsomely rewarded.”

“Oh, I see now, kitten,” the shapeshifter replies. “You’re playing a double game. Wonderful!”

“Of course,” Catra whispers. “Adora is easy to deceive. She always underestimates me. She’s been doing it since we were children, when she thought she had to protect me. But I’m stronger than she or anyone else ever believed.”

“I have no doubts,” Double Trouble says. “So, what do you want me to do?”

“While we are on the island, you will infiltrate Bright Moon. With your skills, it will be as easy as pie. You’ll distract them, cause discord, and waste their time. Maybe you’ll even knock out their communication systems. Meanwhile, Hordak and our forces will launch the attack on Salineas. With She-Ra absent, destroying the Sea Gate and taking total control of the seas will be a piece of cake.”

“How diabolical!” laughs Double Trouble. “But it’s going to cost you. I’m not cheap.”

“Don’t worry, money’s no problem,” Catra says, smuggling them a purse full of coins, which Double Trouble rushes to pocket.

“When we return from Beast Island,” Catra adds, “Adora will find that the war has continued without her. And her desperation will grow when Ran’s robot Oni Killer model whatever will deliver the final blow to her and the entire Rebellion!”

Chapter End Notes

The title of this chapter is a fusion between the titles of She-Ra (2018) season 1 episode 11, “Promise”, and Urusei Yatsura OVA “Catch the Heart” (1989).

Only You in the Moment of Truth

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"How's it going, Bow?" Adora asks her friend as she enters the bridge, where he is lying on his back, working on the underside of the spaceship's console. "Were you able to get the ship working again?"

"With Ran and Lum's help, I rewired the engine," Bow answers. "The connections are fine. Everything should be working, but... for some reason it's not."

"What do you mean?"

"Not even the two aliens have a clue. They say the technology is a bit outdated... and it couldn't be otherwise, since this ship is over a thousand years old... but they're not quite sure why isn't turning on. Neither am I, to be honest."

"Maybe there's a piece missing," Adora says.

"But we reinstalled everything the Horde took!"

"What if it's something the Crimson Waste scavengers stole?" Adora says. "After all, the craft has been abandoned in the desert for a long time."

"Blondie!" Huntara calls, entering the ship. Behind her are Spinnerella, Netossa and Swift Wind. "We need to talk!"

"Ugh," Adora says. "What is it, Huntara?"

"Maybe you trust this catgirl, but I don't. Are you sure she will respect the truce?"

“Catra gave us access to the ship, didn’t she?” Adora answers. “And she agreed that Ran would help us get it working again... or at least try to.”

“It could be a deception to get us to let our guard down,” the amazon says.

“Huntara is right, Adora,” Netossa adds. “We are naive to trust Catra. Earlier, I saw her conspiring with Double Trouble... And strangely, that shapeshifter is no longer here. She must have sent them somewhere to commit some treachery!”

Adora thinks for a moment, then says: “But we have no choice. We have to trust her if we want to rescue Entrapta from Beast Island.”

“Netossa and I were thinking of returning to Bright Moon,” Spinnerella adds. “Flying on the back of Swift Wind, it will take us little time. In case Catra and Double Trouble are up to something, we better be there to protect the kingdom and the runestone.”

“Are you okay with that, Swifty?” Adora asks the unicorn.

“Sorry to part with you, Adora,” Swift Wind replies. “But the idea of flying aboard a spaceship doesn’t really appeal to me. And also... Beast Island doesn’t seem like a good place for me.”

“Don’t worry, Swifty, I totally understand,” Adora says. “That’s fine: go back to Bright Moon with Netossa and Spinnerella. Explain how things are going, and warn Glimmer and the other princesses, if they haven’t already left on their own mission. I don’t think Catra will try a surprise attack, but you never know. I’ll keep an eye on her and Ran while we’re on Beast Island, if we can get this ship off the ground. And Bow, Huntara, Ataru and Lum will help me.”

“No,” Huntara says. “I thought about it a lot, and I decided that I need to stay here and take back the Waste for the Rebellion and for my people. I won’t abandon my home again.” Then she looks Adora straight in the face and adds: “Do you mind, blondie?”

“No, it's okay,” Adora answers with a smile. “In fact, thank you for all the help you have given us so far. From now on, we can handle this on our own. After all, I am She-Ra, the great warrior who tamed the beasts of Beast Island with a single word, according to the ancient legends that Perfuma loves to mention.”

“You’re cool, blondie!” Huntara laughs. She and Adora exchange a fist bump, then the amazon leaves the spacecraft, followed by Netossa, Spinnerella, and Swift Wind.

Outside the ship, sitting on some crates at the bottom of the canyon, are Ataru, Lum, Ran and Catra. As she passes them, Spinnerella glances in Ran’s direction, blushes slightly, and then quickly averts her gaze. Netossa also turns to the alien girl, but with a much fiercer look. Ran doesn’t even notice, as she is busy chatting and laughing with Lum.

Ataru, on the other hand, is staring intensely at Catra, who is sitting alone, cross-legged, licking the back of her hand like a cat, and ignoring the others.

At some point, however, feeling observed, the feline turns to him. “Why the hell are you staring at me, you stupid earthling?” she asks, annoyed.

With a more serious look than usual, Ataru replies: “I wanted to figure out if you’re really as mean as everyone says...”

Catra growls. Lum and Ran also stop talking to each other and turn in her direction.

“Adora told us that the two of you were once friends,” Ataru continues. “‘My best friend,’ she said, actually. And she wondered why you chose to stay in the Horde instead of joining her in the Rebellion.”

“Adora never understood anything,” Catra says dryly. “She certainly never understood anything about me, or at least not

enough to care. She didn't even understand the reason I stayed in the Horde."

"And what is that reason?" Ataru asks.

"Yeah, what is it?" Lum adds.

"It's none of your business!" Catra shouts angrily. Then, after a hesitant pause, she adds almost in a whisper: "Why do you even care?"

"Because you used to be friends!" Lum says. "And Adora... she still cares for you very much. It's obvious how her face lights up every time she mentions your name."

"We're curious!" Ataru says.

"I often argue with Lum myself," Ran adds. "But then we always make up. Isn't that right, Lum-chan?"

"Of course, Ran-chan," the alien in the tiger-striped bikini answers with a smile. And then, turning back to Catra, Lum asks her: "So, can you tell us why you're so angry with her?"

Catra is speechless. How could these strangers understand her frustration? But then she thinks about it and realizes that's the point. They are strangers, from another world. They have no baggage, no prejudices... Maybe it would be useful for her too to talk to them, to find out things for herself. And so she decides to answer them.

"Adora always thinks that wanting something is enough to make it happen. But that is to be expected. She always gets everything. After all, she grew up hearing that if you do better, you will succeed. Me, I'm different. I grew up with someone telling me: your best will never be good enough."

"But that's terrible!" says Lum. "Who told you that?"

"Everyone!" Catra replies. "But... especially Shadow Weaver."

“That scary lady with the red mask?” Ataru asks. Catra grunts.

“I don’t understand, Catra-chan,” Ran says. “You’re a powerful Horde commander. You have charisma, you have followers, everyone respects you. How can you believe what that woman told you? It almost seems like you’re the one for whom these things are not sufficient. You’re the one who convinces yourself that nothing will be enough.”

“And isn’t that right?” Catra exclaims angrily. “Even when I win, I actually lose. I used to think that if I gained strength, power, control, I would be... I don’t know... happier? But nothing really satisfies me.”

“I’m only happy when I’m with my darling!” Lum says smiling and hugs Ataru.

“Get lost, you pest!” Ataru shouts and pushes her away, but not too hard. Lum sticks out her tongue.

“I’m also happy when I’m with my Rei,” Ran adds. “Maybe you should follow your heart more. Is there someone you love?”

Catra freezes instantly. Her face turns red.

Ran watches her closely. “A-ha!” she says, pointing at her. “I knew it. There *is* someone! Who’s he? Tell us!”

Extremely embarrassed, Catra tries to regain a dignified expression. “N-no! There is no one. Nobody likes me... or wants me. And I don’t like anyone. And definitely not Adora!” she says.

“Oh,” Lum laughs. “You remind me so much of my darling when he talks about me!”

“I’m not like that!” Ataru protests. “I don’t like you, Lum!”

“Darling, there’s no point in lying,” Ran says to Ataru. Then she turns back to Catra. “But then, you... how do you really feel about Adora?”

“I...” Catra stutters. She doesn’t go on. She raises her eyes and meets the gazes of Lum, Ataru and Ran, who stare at her curiously. With an enormous effort, she continues to speak. “I... I lo...”

“Is this where the grape harvest is being held?” Cherry asks, suddenly appearing among them.

Three big wooden hammers, materialized in the hands of Ataru, Lum and Ran, fall on the monk’s head. Catra, though relieved by the interruption of such an embarrassing discussion, looks on in bewilderment, her eyes wide open. How can such bizarre things happen with these people?

“Damn you, Cherry, what are you doing here?” Ataru asks.

“I have something to give to Adora,” the monk answers. “A strange old lady, perhaps a bit crazy, gave it to me. She said it was a message from... Mara, I think?”

“Adora is in the spaceship, with Bow,” Lum says. “Go in there and bring it to her.”

The monk complies.

“Look out, Megane!” shouts Perm, warning his companion that a robot is targeting him.

Megane turns and somersaults away at the last moment, dodging the shot fired by the robot that is projecting the hologram of a diabolical princess. However, the blow hits Chibi behind him. The small boy falls to the ground and a red “X” lights up on his bodice.

“Damn!” Chibi says.

“Seriously, Chibi?” Kakugari exclaims. “You haven’t passed this simulation once!”

“That’s enough,” Lonnie says. The holograms turn off and the room returns to its original appearance.

The boys are in the training arena for Horde recruits. “This is not good,” Lonnie says, noting something on her pad. “You suck. You need to try again.”

“But why do we have to go through this torture?” Perm protests. “And where are Mendo, Shinobu, and Ryunosuke? Why aren’t they training with us?”

“Your three buddies have been deemed fit to move on to advanced training,” Lonnie answers. “The two girls showed remarkable strength, while the arrogant boy proved to be particularly skilled in swordplay. They’re currently training under the direct supervision of a Force Captain, and I wouldn’t be surprised if they're cleared for active duty soon. You, on the other hand...”

“Stop it!” Chibi whines. “I don’t want to fight!”

“We are students, not soldiers!” Perm adds. “You can’t force us!”

“That’s right,” Kakugari says. “We didn’t ask to be enlisted.”

“Calm down,” Megane says to his companions, getting up from the floor. “Remember, we are from Earth, and we have to make a very good impression on these aliens. Also, we’re Japanese! We are the flower of Tomobiki’s youth. The courage that resides in our hearts must not be dampened by the fear of cowardice. We all swore to chase a dream, to protect Miss Lum, and we will do it! She is now a prisoner of dark, rival forces, the evil princesses, enemies of the Horde. Only by giving the best of ourselves, by offering our breasts to the enemy fire, can we save her! Believe, obey, fight! We will fight! And we will win!” he shouts in an increasingly exalted tone.

Lonnie looks at him in bewilderment. Then she turns to Perm and asks: “Is he often like this, your friend?”

“Unfortunately, yes...” Perm replies.

“Either way, you failed the test,” says Lonnie. “Let’s turn the simulation back on. Start over!”

“Ugh! But when do we depart for the Fright Zone?” Mermista asks boredly. She and the other princesses, as well as Benten, Oyuki and little Ten, are sitting around the table in Bright Moon’s war room, studying a holographic map of enemy territory.

“My mom won’t give us the green light until we have a plan, you know that as well as I do,” Glimmer says. “This time I promised her we won’t improvise like we usually do. The plan has to be more than perfect if we’re going to... Ugh, I’m starting to sound like Adora!”

“At least she’s not here,” says Mermista, “and neither is Bow, with his dolls... sorry, his war-table battle figures, turning a challenging tactical planning session into a role-playing game.”

“Too bad,” says Perfuma, “I had so much fun last time!”

“Me too!” Frosta exclaims enthusiastically. “We should do it again, once in a while... for fun, I mean. Not that I like children’s games, it’s just to encourage socialization between the princesses...”

“I really like games!”, Ten says. Oyuki pats his head. Benten, sitting next to her, smiles.

“And where is Shadow Weaver?” asks Perfuma. “Shouldn’t she be here to help us? Not that I miss her presence, but after all, she will have to come with us to the Fright Zone...”

“She’s still with aunt Casta. They’re trying to contact someone from the other universe, but they don’t seem to be making much progress.”

“I believe they are quarreling,” Frosta says. “I don’t think they get along very well...”

“You’re right,” Glimmer says. “My aunt still resents her for the way she treated her brother... that is, my dad...”

“Your dad?” Oyuki asks.

“Yes,” Glimmer answers. “King Micah. He was one of the first casualties of the Rebellion’s war against the Horde. I hardly remember him, I was only a child when he died. As a boy, he studied magic in Mystacor, where he was a pupil of Light Spinner, as Shadow Weaver was then known. Even then, she was a treacherous manipulator. She sensed great power in him and sought to mold it to her own purposes, but...”

A knock on the door interrupts her. “Who is it?” Glimmer asks.

“Commander Glimmer,” a Bright Moon guard says, entering the room. “One of the aliens has returned from the Crimson Waste, and she wishes to speak with you.”

Behind her comes Lum at a brisk pace. “Good morning, everyone,” she greets.

“Lum-chan!” Ten exclaims, flying towards the girl in the tiger-striped bikini.

Lum looks surprised. “Um... hello, flying kiddo. How are you?” she says.

“But Lum, why do you call me that? Don’t you recognize me? I’m your little cousin, Ten!” replies the little alien, confused.

“Oh... Ten, sure! My little cousin! Ten!” Lum exclaims in embarrassment. And lowering her voice: “That doll girl forgot to

tell me that you would also be there... I hate working with amateurs!... I mean, good to see you again."

"Why are you back so soon, Lum?" Benten asks her. "Were there any problems in the Crimson Waste?"

"No, not at all!" Lum replies, sitting down at the table. "Everything went as planned. We recovered the ship. Bow is repairing it and will soon leave for Beast Island with She-Ra and the others aboard. I came to tell you."

"And why didn't your husband come with you?" Oyuki asks. "Normally, you never part ways."

"Uh... You see, he decided to go with the others. And I thought it would be good for once to put some distance between us. To improve our relationship, I mean."

"Uh, strange, that's not like you, Lum," Benten comments. "Usually, you're always glued to him. But maybe you're right. That idiot Ataru might miss you and realize how much he can't do without you. Especially if the mission turns out to be dangerous..."

"Dangerous?" Glimmer says. "Why does everyone always think the worst? I'm sure the rumors about Beast Island are exaggerated. Our friends will go there, find Entrapta and bring her back. No surprises or unexpected encounters at all."

"So boring!" says Frosta. "Let's hope we get to fight in the Fright Zone instead! I can't wait to punch Hordak!"

"As long as you don't make me go back into these sewers," Mermista says. "Last time it took me two days to get rid of the stench."

"I'm sure Glimmer will come up with a perfect plan," Lum says. "And you will all obey her without question. How noble of you to accept her as the undisputed leader of the Princess Alliance!"

“Um... this is indeed an alliance,” says Mermista. “That means we are all equal here. No one obeys anyone.”

“Yes, but she’s the leader, right?” Lum asks. “I mean, none of you would have any hope of fighting the Horde alone... would you?”

“With my plants, I can defeat as many soldiers as I want!” says Perfuma, offended. “Not even Hordak can withstand the universal power of nature!”

“I’m going to punch Hordak in the face!” Frosta exclaims. “And I will freeze the entire Fright Zone myself if I have to!”

“Freeze...?” Oyuki comments in a calm tone. “Interesting. Child, we need to talk later.”

“Child?” Frosta protests. “I am the ruler of my own kingdom, got it, lady?”

“So am I,” Oyuki replies, smiling at her. Frosta’s frown softens.

“No one here has to fight alone!” Glimmer shouts. “Lum is right. No one can hope to win on their own. We must fight together... as soon as I think of a plan.”

“Yes... you will think of a plan and we will obey, right?” says Mermista, crossing her arms.

“Or worse... we’ll obey Shadow Weaver,” Perfuma adds. “Like the last time we went to the Fright Zone.”

“You know too well she knows that place better than anyone!” Glimmer protests.

“Which makes her even more dangerous,” Perfuma says.

“We’re rambling and wasting our time!” Glimmer says. “We’re a little too nervous. Let’s take a break, maybe it will help us relax. There are some snacks in the fireplace chamber. See you in an hour.”

The princesses get up from their chairs and leave the war room. Some of them go out into the garden, others stay in the large hall near the council chamber, dominated by a large hearth and high windows, where huge sofas with cushions and tables with trays of biscuits and cups of tea have been arranged.

Lum goes out into the garden where she sees Perfuma walking slowly along the cobbled paths between the rows of roses. She approaches her and smiles. "Hi!"

"Hi, Lum," Perfuma says. "Sorry if we were a little nervous before."

"Don't worry, Perfuma, I understand perfectly. I would be nervous too if someone told me what Mermista said."

"Excuse me? What did Mermista say?"

"Oh, I thought you heard. And that you had already responded in kind. She said that she should be the one to lead the Alliance... that she is an awesome leader, since her magic is the best of all. Knowing how to control water gives her tremendous power, much more than controlling plants, which is useless in the Fright Zone where everything is cold and metallic. She also added that if it wasn't for her protecting you during the previous battles, you would have been the first to be captured..."

"W-what?" Perfuma stammers. Her face begins to change color. Lum smirks.

But then Perfuma's expression calms down again. "Mermista sometimes tries to appear cool and cynical," she says, smiling. "That way she hides her true feelings. Like when she's with Sea Hawk. But I know she's a true friend. The universe wants us to fight together, so there must be harmony between us."

What the hell, Lum thinks.

"You know," Perfuma goes on, "Mermista once told me that sometimes it is helpful to shift perspectives. She was right. When

we princesses worked together during the Battle of Bright Moon, our powers grew. That is our secret: harmony!”

“Ugh!” Lum says to herself, turning around and heading back to the palace. “I must’ve lost my touch.”

Before leaving the garden, she catches a glimpse of Benten walking down another path, stopping to smell the cherry blossoms. Instinctively, Lum’s appearance changes to that of the alien biker. And so it’s Benten who enters the hall where the other princesses are.

At a small table, she notices Oyuki and Frosta sitting and chatting. *Let’s see if the other information that doll girl gave me is of any use*, she thinks, approaching and greeting them. “Hey,” she says.

“Hey, Benten!” Oyuki replies. “It’s really interesting to talk to young Frosta here. You see, her realm is called the Kingdom of Snows! I’d be curious to visit it.”

“Oyuki told me that she has a Yeti on her planet!” Frosta exclaims enthusiastically. “A real abominable snowman! How I wish I had one too!”

“B-bo is like a little brother to me,” Oyuki smiles. “And he loves me like a big sister.”

“Cool!” Frosta says. “It must be nice to have such a little brother!”

“You know,” Benten says. “B-bo isn’t Oyuki’s only pet on Neptune. She also has a colony of silly Neptunian lemmings. I bet you would like them.”

“That’s true,” Oyuki says. “Too bad they always get into trouble. Especially their leader. He has a bad habit of going around and eating whatever he can find. I don’t know how many times he’s raided my kitchens.”

“Not to mention the time Ran kidnapped him and then blamed him for all the damage he had done to her spaceship. Remember,

Oyuki, how angry you got?”

“Blamed him? What do you mean?” Oyuki asks. “Wasn’t that his fault?”

“Oops!” Benten says. “I promised Ran that I wouldn’t tell you... Not bad, it was a long time ago. Surely, you won’t mind that she lied to you.”

Oyuki doesn’t answer. Her face becomes serious, her expression indecipherable.

“It wasn’t the first time either,” Benten continues. “Ever since we went to school together, Ran has lied to you many times. Like the time she destroyed half of your room with a bomb when we were playing at your house... And of course, as her friend, I felt compelled to confirm her accounts of what happened, to make you believe that she was an innocent victim of our games... when in fact it was she who often caused the havoc, and you never found the culprit. But I fully understand her: she was afraid that you would make her pay for the damage!”

“And you...” Oyuki says coldly. “...you have always covered her up? Did you never tell me the truth?”

“Like I said, she’s my friend too...”, Benten says smiling. “Well, girls, see you later.”

And as Benten walks away, she feels the temperature behind her drop rapidly. She smirks.

“Sakura!” says Ozuno Tsubame. “I finally perceive something!”

The nurse dressed as a *miko* waves her wand. “You’re right, Tsubame. This time, we’re not imagining it. Someone is trying to

contact us!”

The two of them are sitting in the middle of the Tomobiki High School gym, facing each other. Around them, arranged in a circle on the floor, are burning candles and various kinds of talismans, related to both Eastern and Western magic. The air between them is vibrating. Then the vibration changes frequency, slowly approaching the sound of a female voice.

“...mmunicate,” the voice says. “...inhabitants of Tomobiki... ...another universe. If you can hear me, please answer. I’m Castaspella, head sorceress of Mystacor, from the planet Etheria. I’m trying to communicate with the inhabitants of Tomobiki, from another universe. If you can hear me, please answer. I’m Castaspella, head sorceress of Mystacor...”

“We did it!” Tsubame says. “We opened a contact. And on the other side is someone with enough spiritual energy to reach out to us. Quick, Sakura, answer!”

The woman concentrates. She waves her wand again, then lowers it and begins to speak. “I’m Sakura, Shinto priestess of Tomobiki, from the planet Earth. It’s good to hear from you, Castaspella. It means we have finally made contact. Are my uncle and the boys and girls with you?”

After a pause, the response comes, “...that some of them are here, but others need to be recovered. They have fallen into the hands of our enemies. A mission has already been planned to bring them back to safety. Within a few days, they will all be ready to return to your world.”

“That’s great news,” Sakura answers. “But as you probably know, in order to bring them back, it will be necessary to open a portal on both sides. Are you able to do that?”

“We’re working on it,” Castaspella says. “Portals are opened by a combination of magic and technology. And they must be anchored to something or someone that can provide them with a great deal

of physical and spiritual energy at the same time. We should have everything we need. And you?”

“We have no lack of magical abilities,” Sakura says. “My fiancé and I are very familiar with this kind of ritual. As for technology, we have the alien machinery left on Lum’s UFO. We are in contact with someone on her home planet who should come here to Earth to help us put it into operation... In short, on our side, too, we will be ready within a few days.”

“Excellent!” Castaspella replies. “Then I will contact you again when the time is right. Take care. It was a pleasure talking to you, Sakura!”

“You too, Castaspella!” Sakura says. “Hear you soon!”

The air stops vibrating. The connection is broken.

“Well done, Sakura,” Tsubame says. “We finally succeeded. And from the planet Oniboshi, they informed us that Lum’s ex-boyfriend, the Oni named Rei, should arrive on Earth in a few hours. But there’s another problem...”

“And what is that?” asks the nurse.

“Have you heard Castaspella? We need someone to act as a spiritual anchor to keep the portal open for as long as it takes to get the students through. You and I can’t do that, because we’ll be busy casting the ritual. We need a person with enough supernatural energy and physical strength to keep the gate open. Who can we turn to?”

Sakura thinks for a moment. Then she looks out of the window of the gym, which overlooks the central building of the school and specifically the principal’s office. “A person? Not necessarily. I know who is best suited for that!”

“Glimmer! Emergency!” yells Mermista, running towards the princess of Bright Moon, who is sitting in front of the hearth with a plate of cookies in her hand.

“What’s going on?” Glimmer asks.

“The communication panel in the war room has been severed! It was the only way we had to contact Bow and Adora’s group or the other kingdoms.”

“What? When did this happen?” asks Glimmer as she stands up. The other princesses gather around her.

“I don’t know. Benten and I were passing by the room when we saw it...”

“Wait,” Frosta says accusingly. “We saw Benten run out of there two minutes ago.”

Benten scoffs. “Uh, what are you talking about?” she says. “I was with Perfuma, out in the garden.”

“But you came to talk to Frosta and me...” Oyuki says.

“Are you imagining things?” Benten asks. “I always stayed outside.”

“It’s true,” Perfuma says. “Benten was with me. I was showing her the new variety of roses that I grafted here at Bright Moon...”

“Maybe the panel just broke down,” Lum says. “Nothing serious: it must have been an accident...”

“It wasn’t an accident,” Glimmer says. And after a pause, she adds: “It was sabotage.”

When Adora and Bow, followed by Cherry, descend from the spacecraft, they have grim expressions on their faces. Adora even looks shocked. Her walk is stiff, and tears run down her cheeks as if she's been crying.

Ataru, Lum, Ran and Catra look at them puzzled. "What... what happened?" Catra asks worriedly, feeling her heart fill with fear when she sees the blonde's teary eyes.

It's not Adora who answers, but Bow. "The disk that Cherry brought," the boy says, "was the piece we needed to make the ship function. Now the commands work. The craft is ready to fly."

"Great!" says Lum. "But why the long faces?"

Seeing that there is no answer, Catra stands up and walks directly in front of Adora. "Adora... What's wrong?"

"M-Mara...", Adora says with a trembling voice and a downcast look. "Mara left me a message. Now I finally know what really happened a thousand years ago."

"And what did happen?" asks Catra.

"There's a great evil at the heart of Etheria. And it's awakening again," Adora says.

"The… heart of Etheria?"

"Oh, Catra!" Adora exclaims, this time looking directly into her eyes. The catgirl's heart skips a beat. "It's terrible! Light Hope lied to me. She has always deceived me!"

"What the hell are you talking about?"

"The First Ones have been siphoning off the magic of Etheria, collecting it in the planet's core... They turned Etheria into a deadly weapon to bring death and destruction to the universe.

This is why Mara put us in Despondos, isolating us from other worlds. And she sacrificed her life because She-Ra herself is the key to activating the weapon."

"A planet turned into a weapon?" exclaims Ataru. "Cool! It's like 'Star Wars'!".

"Darling, you don't understand anything!" Lum scolds him.

Catra is silent for a moment. Then she moves even closer to Adora and says: "I don't know if it's true or if it's the usual bullshit your holograms tell you to manipulate you every time you question them. You're always so gullible! But even if it's true... then stop transforming. Don't worry, I... we of the Horde won't miss She-Ra, I assure you!"

"It's not that simple, Catra," Adora says. "Mara said the Heart is unstable. It almost destroyed everyone in her time. And it's gotten stronger and more volatile over the centuries. If it goes off now, it could tear Etheria apart."

"So?"

"Don't you understand? Light Hope will do anything to activate it. She was programmed for this, and she won't stop trying. And even Hordak might be tempted to use the weapon. Even if I don't transform anymore, like he brought me here from who knows where, he could bring someone else. There could be another She-Ra in the future..."

"Let's destroy the sword, then!" says Catra. "No sword, no She-Ra."

"Destroy... the sword?" Adora says. She pauses for a moment to consider the suggestion seriously.

Catra smirks.

"No!" Adora says finally. "Or at least not yet. Remember that we still have to stop reality from collapsing in on itself. We have to

rescue Entrapta from Beast Island, and we may need She-Ra's power to do that."

"Not to mention, if we wanna safely disable this weapon, Entrapta is our best bet," Bow adds. "She'd know more about that than anyone."

Another pause. Catra seems to think long and hard. Then she puts her hand on Adora's shoulder, who flinches at her touch.

"Okay," the catgirl says. "Let's think about rescuing Entrapta first. Let's send those idiots back to their universe and save reality. We'll worry about your stupid hologram and its stupid superweapon later."

In the meantime, she thinks, *if Double Trouble does their duty, the Rebellion will be defeated. And if big brother Prime comes to the planet, She-Ra or no She-Ra, I still win.*

"General Juliet is working on restoring communication with the other kingdoms," Glimmer says. The other princesses sit around her in the hearth chamber. "In the meantime, there's a backup device in the dining room, should we need it."

"You said earlier it was sabotage," Perfuma comments. "How can you be sure?"

"I'm not, but there's no other explanation," Glimmer says. "The panel was clearly tampered with, taking advantage of the fact that the room was empty."

"But that means that..." Frosta says.

"... that there's a Horde spy here in Bright Moon!" exclaims Mermista, rising to her feet in excitement. "And no one is going

anywhere until we figure out who it is."

"What?" says Perfuma.

"We need to investigate!" says Mermista. "Obviously, I'll be the lead detective, since I've read every single Mer-Mystery book."

"Mer-what?" asks Benten.

"Mer-Mystery!" Mermista says, still enthusiastic. "It's only the best undersea novel series ever, there's like 18 of them, it taught me everything I need to know about solving mysteries... Murder mysteries!"

"M-murder?" Perfuma says nervously. "But no one's been murdered..."

"Yet!" shouts Mermista.

"That's enough, Mermista, don't be silly," says Glimmer. "Surely the saboteur can't be one of us. While we were here or in the garden, anyone could have entered the war room. One of the guards, for example, or the kitchen staff..."

"Ugh. The servants? What a cliché!" says the sea princess. "And then, the culprit can't be a character we've never seen before. That goes against the rules of every mystery novel!"

"But you can't possibly think that it could be a princess of the Alliance!" says Perfuma. "Why would one of us do that?"

"There are not only princesses here," Mermista points out. "There are also some strangers... what do we know about them?" she says, pointing to Lum, Benten, Oyuki and Ten.

"Are you suggesting that we did it?" Benten shouts angrily, standing up and approaching Mermista. "How dare you, girl? Look, I'm not afraid of you. We are innocent!"

“And how do we know you’re telling the truth?” Mermista replies, challenging the biker with her gaze. “Earlier, Frosta said she saw you leaving the war room!”

“I always tell the truth!” Benten cries.

“That’s not exactly what you told me earlier...”, Oyuki says, her voice calm but cold.

“And what does that mean?” Benten says, still enraged and turning to her friend.

“You just confessed that you lied to me. That you covered up Ran’s misdeeds more than once,” Oyuki says. “And who knows what else you’ve been hiding from me all these years.”

“I’ve never hidden anything from you!” Benten says furiously. “But maybe I should have... Ran is right when she says that you’re a snob, the stingiest person she knows, a cold-hearted businesswoman.”

“Ah, is that so?” says Oyuki. “Is that what you think of me? You have disappointed me greatly, Benten. If you do not apologize... I will be angry.” Her voice becomes even colder. Snowflakes begin to form in the air around her.

“Brr...”, says Perfuma. “Doesn’t the temperature seem to be dropping?”

“Lum-chan!” Ten exclaims shivering. “Oyuki’s going to get angry... I’m scared... Lum-chan!”. But then he suddenly notices that his cousin is no longer close to him. “Lum-chan?”

In fact, Lum is no longer in the hearth room. Unseen, taking advantage of the fact that everyone’s eyes were focused on her alien friends, the girl in the tiger-striped bikini has entered the nearby war room, which remained empty. The lights are off, and she doesn’t bother to turn them on.

Looking around and under the table, Lum calls out: “Come on, backup communicator, where are youuu?”

The lights flick on. “Hey, Lum. Looking for something?” Benten says smiling. At her side, Oyuki stands.

“Oh... Um...”, Lum stutters nervously. “Benten? Oyuki. Hi... Hi. Uh, just looking for the bathroom...” She turns around and grunts as she bumps into Glimmer. She looks up and sees Perfuma, Mermista and Frosta behind her, watching her with crossed arms.

“Okay...” Lum says. “Okay, this looks bad, but I assure you it isn’t what it looks like, so let’s all just...”

Benten yelps as Lum kicks her in the ankle, pushing her to the ground. Lum runs past her and tries to reach the door of the room, but then hits a magical force field.

“Oh!” Lum says, touching the force field. “I see... Magic. How very clever.”

“Give it up, spy,” Glimmer says, approaching her. “We know you’re not Lum.”

“Well, yes,” Lum says. Her shape changes. She turns back into a humanoid reptilian form.

Everyone jumps. “You’re a shapeshifter...!” says Benten.

“Please... Call me Double Trouble,” they say. Then, addressing Benten and Oyuki, they add: “May I say, as one actor to another, that was truly a masterful performance. I really bought that you two were furious at each other. But now I would like to know: how did you suspect me?”

“The reveal of how they caught the murderer is my favorite part!” giggles Mermista.

“It’s very simple,” says Glimmer. “While you were out in the garden talking to Perfuma, some people came to Bright Moon and

immediately asked to speak to me. And from what they told me, I knew right away that you weren't who you said you were."

"Who are these people?" Double Trouble asks.

"We are!" say Netossa and Spinnerella, entering the room, followed by Swift Wind.

"Ah!" Double Trouble says, recognizing the two princesses they had already seen in the Crimson Waste. "Now I understand."

"You and Catra never thought we'd return to Bright Moon so soon," Netossa says. "And thanks to Swift Wind's wings, it took us very little time. When Glimmer told us Lum was here, we knew it couldn't be her. And since we saw a shapeshifter working for the Horde, we quickly figured out who she might be."

"To be sure, we set a trap anyway," Glimmer adds. "We knew a backup communication device would be irresistible to whoever destroyed the original."

"And I really enjoyed pretending to be angry," Oyuki says. "It doesn't happen to me very often, to be honest."

"So it's over, Double Trouble," Glimmer says. "Now tell us what the Horde is up to."

"And why would I do that?" the shapeshifter grins. "I'm loyal to those who pay me. Any good performer knows better than to upset their employer if they hope to work in the same venue again."

The princesses remain silent, perplexed. Then, after a pause, Oyuki speaks again.

"What if someone pays you more?"

Double Trouble stares at her curiously. "How much more?" they ask.

“Enough to convince you to switch sides,” the queen of Neptune replies. “Money is no object here.” And then she turns to Glimmer: “Of course, since the kingdom is yours, you will be the one to come up with the necessary sum, won’t you?”

“Uh... um, of course!” Glimmer says. “I’ll ask my mom.” Then back to Double Trouble: “If you really are not a member of the Horde and are only working for them for the money, I suggest you go over to the Rebellion. You will be well rewarded.”

“Can I trust you?” Double Trouble asks.

“A princess does not go back on her word,” Glimmer says.

The shapeshifter thinks for a moment. Then they say: “Okay. I will talk. I just needed to keep you isolated and at each other’s throats for a while... The Horde is going to launch a surprise attack on Salineas. They want to destroy the Sea Gate. If the Horde controls the seas, they control Etheria.”

“Salineas!” Mermista exclaims. “My kingdom!”

“Mermista, don’t worry,” Perfuma says. “We’ll help you. We will protect the Sea Gate. If the Horde attacks, they will find us waiting for them.”

“No,” Mermista says. “The Fright Zone mission is waiting for you. We cannot waste any more time: remember that reality itself is in danger, for these disturbing flashes show no signs of ceasing. But Sea Hawk and I will go to Salineas immediately to bolster its defenses. If the Horde thinks they can surprise us, they are sorely mistaken!”

“We will go with you!” Spinnerella says. “Netossa and I will help you defend your kingdom.”

“I wouldn’t do that if I were you,” says Double Trouble.

Everyone turns to them. “And why?” Netossa asks.

“The attack on Salineas is not the only move the Horde is planning. Kitten also told me that a giant mega-robot is about to be launched against Bright Moon. I don’t know much about it, but from what she said, it seems to be a very powerful machine. If you all split up, some going to the Fright Zone and some to Salineas, Bright Moon will be left defenseless.”

“My mom will stay here to protect the kingdom and the runestone!” Glimmer says indignantly.

“Alone? With a handful of powerless guards?” Double Trouble asks. Then they laugh. “Go ahead. But I warned you.”

Glimmer groans. After a while, she says: “That’s fine. I don’t know if we can trust you, but we don’t have much choice. Nor time. Here's what we'll do: Shadow Weaver and I will teleport to the Fright Zone to rescue the captured earthlings. Perfuma, Frosta, Benten and Oyuki will come with us. Mermista and Sea Hawk will go to Salineas instead. And Netossa, Spinnerella and Swift Wind will stay here in Bright Moon to help my mom defend the kingdom, while aunt Casta will continue to communicate with the other universe. All clear?”

“And me?” asks Ten. “I want to go on a mission too!”

“Lum recommended that you stay here, safe and out of trouble,” says Glimmer.

“Do not underestimate this child,” says Benten. “He’s an Oni, and that means he’s not to be taken lightly. He can fly and breathe fire. He could be useful to us in the Fright Zone.”

Glimmer ponders for a moment, then says, “Ugh... all right. You can come with us. But be careful not to get into trouble. I hope I won’t regret it!”

“Yes!” Ten exults, circling in the air above the others’ heads.

“What about the plan we were supposed to come up with?” Frosta asks.

“I’ll tell my mom we’ll do what we do best,” Glimmer says. Everyone looks at her anxiously. The pink-haired princess continues: “We’ll improvise.”

Chapter End Notes

The title of this chapter is a fusion between the titles of Urusei Yatsura’s first movie, “Only You” (1983), and She-Ra (2018) season 3 episode 4, “Moment of Truth”.

I Love the Sea Gate!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Getting Mara's spaceship off the ground turns out to be easier than expected. Although the technology is different from what Lum and Ran are used to, the two alien girls manage to activate the ship's computer, which immediately recognizes She-Ra as its administrator. After a few seconds, the craft leaves the Crimson Waste and heads for Beast Island (or "Hazardous Materials Disposal Site," as the autopilot identifies the island when Adora asks it to set the coordinates).

Shortly after takeoff, while Bow and Ran remain at the console, Lum and Adora join Ataru, Cherry and Catra at the rear of the bridge, their backs to the metal wall.

"I can't believe that after all this time we're on a mission together," Adora says, smiling at Catra and sitting shyly next to her. Catra looks back at the blonde, but doesn't answer, in fact she moves away slightly to keep some distance. Adora's smile begins to fade.

"Don't fool yourself," the feline says coldly. "Remember that this truce is only temporary."

"I know. But I'm still happy," Adora says. And surprising Catra, she approaches her again and rests her head on her shoulder.

Catra doesn't answer and turns her head away. But this time she shows no signs of moving any further. After a few seconds of silence, a low, fluttering sound can be heard on the bridge.

Adora's eyes go wide.

"Are... are you purring?" Ataru asks.

“What? NO!” Catra replies with a scowl and abruptly pushes Adora away. “I don’t purr!”

“Yes, you are!” Lum laughs. “We all heard you!”

“Wow, I can’t believe you still like me,” Adora says, a blush coloring her face. “That is so embarrassing for you.”

“Ugh! Get off me, idiot!” growls Catra, also blushing and wagging her tail. “I don’t like you!”

And with that she gets up and walks away. The others follow her with their eyes until she reaches the door and leaves the bridge.

“You know, that catgirl really loves you,” Lum says to Adora.

“W-what?” Adora replies. “No, I was just messing with her... Actually, I think she hates me.”

“Trust me,” Lum says. “That expression is unmistakable. Come on, go after her. Whatever problem there is between the two of you, you need to talk and try to resolve it.”

Adora’s expression becomes sad. “No, it’s useless... She doesn’t want me. Not like I want her. And even if there had been a chance, I’m afraid it’s too late now. I have tried many times, but there’s an insurmountable rift between us. I have accepted it. We’ll never be as close as we used to be.”

“You’re surely cursed by fate...”, says Cherry.

“Shut up, you jinx!” Ataru shouts. “Lum, I cannot tolerate such a situation. True love must win. Let’s do something.”

“What do you mean, darling?”

“If Adora doesn’t want to talk to Catra, you and I will go. Maybe she will listen to us!” and he stands up, extending his hand to the alien girl.

Smiling, she takes it and stands up as well. “I’m proud of you, darling,” she says. Adora looks confused.

“W-what do you want to do?” the blonde asks worriedly.

“Let’s knock some sense in this cat’s head!” says Ataru.

“Exactly!” Lum adds. The two of them start walking towards the door through which Catra had gone out.

“No! Stop!” says Adora. “You will make things worse! You don’t know her... She’s stubborn, mean, resentful... and she never listens to anyone!”

“If that’s true, then it won’t hurt to try!” says Lum. And together with Ataru, they walk out the door.

The back room of the bridge is dark and bare. At first glance, it seems completely empty, but as Ataru and Lum get used to the darkness, they see Catra sitting in a corner, her knees pulled up to her chest, her arms curled around her legs and her tail wrapped around her body.

“Leave me alone,” the feline says in a low voice.

“No!” Ataru says, sitting down beside her. Lum does the same.

“Why are you acting like this?” the horned alien asks. “You can lie to Adora and the other princesses, but you obviously have feelings for her. You’re just being terribly stubborn. You don’t want to admit your love... You’re just like my darling.”

“How is she like me?” Ataru protests. “I don’t love you.” Lum and Catra roll their eyes.

Then Lum continues: “Adora told us that when she found her magic sword, you decided not to follow her. Why didn’t you? I

can’t believe you’d rather stay in her Horde than stand by her side.”

Catra opens her eyes wide. “Don’t talk to me like you know me!” she says angrily. “You don’t know anything about me!”

Lum doesn’t reply, but continues to stare at her. This sincere and innocent look has a strange effect on Catra. Once again, the catgirl feels the words fall out of her mouth almost unintentionally.

“Don’t tell Adora or anyone else, or I’ll kill you,” she says in a low whisper.

“Don’t worry,” Lum says.

“You know...” Catra says. “When Adora left me, I felt it as a betrayal. Yet for a moment I thought of following her. I was hurt, hurt that she chose to leave with strangers without me, that it took so little to abandon all the plans we’d made in a lifetime together... but deep down I knew she was right, that it was best to leave the Fright Zone. I had even begun to think about leaving myself. But then Hordak made me Force Captain. It was a real surprise. I didn’t expect it... No one expected it, to tell the truth. I don’t know what he saw in me. But suddenly I felt appreciated, validated. Suddenly there was someone who believed in me, who seemed to recognize my value, my abilities. Not even Adora had ever really believed in me: she always thought I needed protection... And Shadow Weaver certainly never believed in me...”

Catra pauses for a moment. She sobs. Then she continues.

“Suddenly, I finally had the chance to prove them, all of them, wrong. I remember it as if it was yesterday: I looked at the Force Captain badge that Hordak had given me, in my hand, and that’s when I decided to stay in the Horde. I knew the Horde was evil, but I didn’t care. I would use it to prove myself. To Adora, to Shadow Weaver, to everyone. With Adora, we had always

dreamed of rising through the ranks, of taking the lead. She was gone, but I could do it alone. Without... without her.”

After a few seconds of pause, Lum replies: “Are you only interested in power and leadership? What about... friendship? Or... love?”

Catra laughs. But it’s a bitter laugh. “Those things are not for me. They are good for the stupid princesses, who think that the power of love and friendship can always save them. But they are idiots. Weak and pathetic.”

Then she gets up and goes back to the door.

“Why do people have to love people, anyway?” she says in a broken voice, before opening the door and returning to the bridge.

Lum and Ataru look at each other silently. Then they stand up and follow her.

“Soldiers, get ready to depart,” Sergeant Cobalt says to the three recruits waiting for him in the Fright Zone briefing room. “A transport is waiting to take you to the coast, where you will set sail for Salineas at dawn. You will be part of the platoon led by Force Captain Octavia. This will be your first chance to prove yourself worthy of fighting for the Horde. Do not fail me, and do not fail Lord Hordak.”

Shinobu, Mendo, and Ryunosuke exchange glances. Then Shinobu speaks: “What? Are we going to fight?”

“That’s right, soldier,” Cobalt answers. “You have shown many qualities during your training. You have been deemed ready for the battlefield.”

“What if we don’t want to?” Ryunosuke says.

“Exactly. What if we aren’t interested in fighting for you?” Mendo says.

“You’d be charged with insubordination,” Cobalt replies deadpan.

“Then do it!” Shinobu says with a defiant look. “Put us back in jail, with our other friends. We don’t want to fight.”

“We have no intention of taking part in your war!” Ryunosuke says.

“No one gives orders to the heir of the Mendo conglomerate!” Mendo adds.

Just then, footsteps are heard from the corridor outside the room. The door opens and a woman in uniform enters. The three earthlings immediately notice that she’s not quite fully human. She is some kind of sea creature, with green skin and four tentacles behind her back, in addition to legs and arms. She wears her officer’s badge as a patch over her left eye.

“What are we waiting for, Sergeant?” she asks. “Why the delay?”

“Sorry, Force Captain Octavia,” Cobalt replies, standing at attention. “I’m afraid there are some problems. The three new soldiers seem reluctant to be deployed.”

“What do you mean?” Octavia says. And addressing the three earthlings, she adds: “I will not tolerate insubordination. Put on your battle uniforms and join the others. Right now!”

“We have no uniforms, lady,” Ryunosuke replies. “And we don’t intend to fight.”

“That’s right!” Shinobu adds. “Tell her you too, Mendo.”

But the boy doesn’t open his mouth. Shinobu turns to him. “Mendo...?”

Her friend seems paralyzed, his eyes wide open. His gaze is on the Force Captain.

“Mendo... What’s wrong with you?” Shinobu asks.

The boy suddenly jumps forward, kneels down in front of Octavia, grabs one of her tentacles with his hand, brings it to his lips and gives it a quick kiss. The Force Captain looks at him startled.

“Miss... Miss Octavia!” Mendo says. “I have long dreamed of meeting a woman like you. The personification of the Mendo family crest... An octopus woman! Let me worship you, follow you everywhere. I will serve you faithfully!”

“Mendo!”, Shinobu shouts angrily. How could her friend fall in love with that... that dumb face?

Octavia is stunned and doesn’t know how to react.

“I, Mendo Shutaro, swear eternal loyalty to you,” the boy continues. “My sword is at your disposal. I will protect you as the sacred thing that you are! Long live the octopuses!”

“Um...” Octavia says, regaining her voice. “Okay... I guess? Are you ready to come with me to conquer Salineas, soldier?”

“Please, call me Shutaro,” Mendo answers.

“That’s fine,” says Octavia. “Then you and your friends will be given your uniforms and weapons, and get ready to board the transport.”

“We’re not coming!” Shinobu shouts.

“Wait a minute...” Ryunosuke interjects. “These uniforms you’re talking about... are they the same for everyone, like the training uniforms?”

“Not really,” Cobalt answers. “To help you fight more comfortably, we also have uniforms tailored to the specifics of each soldier’s

build. You can choose the one that best suits your body type."

"Does that mean I can wear a woman's uniform?" Ryunosuke asks with twinkling eyes.

"If you wish...", Cobalt replies.

"Consider me drafted!" Ryunosuke exclaims enthusiastically.

"But Ryu!" Shinobu yells. "You too?"

"Don't you understand, Shinobu? I will be able to wear a female uniform!" Ryunosuke shouts in joy with tears in her eyes. "My dream is finally coming true! I can dress like a woman!"

And like Mendo, Ryunosuke steps forward. Only Shinobu stays behind.

"Earthling," Octavia says, addressing the bob-haired girl. "Your two companions have made their choice. And what will you do? Will you persist in disregarding orders?"

Shinobu crosses her arms and stares at her defiantly. "Of course!" she replies. "I will not fight your war."

"Then you will pay for it," says Octavia. And turning to Cobalt, she adds: "Sergeant, put this dodger in a cell. And you two, get ready. We leave in a few minutes."

The door to the Bright Moon war room opens. Benten enters and sits down at the table next to Oyuki, who asks her: "So, how's it going?"

"Glimmer is talking to her mother right now," the biker answers. "I think she's convincing her to let us go to the Fright Zone even

without a specific plan. That girl knows how to be resolute when she wants to be."

"She reminds me of someone...," Oyuki says with a smile. Benten sticks out her tongue.

"And Double Trouble?" Netossa asks. She and Spinnerella are the only other two people in the room and they have been watching the exchange of sentences and looks between the two aliens.

"The queen paid them as agreed," Benten says. "Apparently, they decided to stay in Bright Moon for a while. Glimmer seems to trust them. I just hope they don't have any nasty surprises for us."

"Don't worry," Oyuki says. "I'm sure they told us the truth."

After that, the queen of Neptune gets up and goes out the door to join the other princesses in the hearth chamber. Only Benten, Netossa and Spinnerella remain in the war room.

Clearing her throat, Spinnerella turns curiously to the alien. "Um, Benten, we wanted to ask you something..."

"Go ahead," the space biker says.

"Not to mind your business," Netossa continues, smiling, "but... are you and Oyuki together? We noticed that you are almost never apart."

"Together... in what sense?" Benten says puzzled.

"Um, well... Are you engaged?", Spinnerella asks.

"Or even married?" Netossa asks.

"What!?", Benten says, her cheeks suddenly turning red. "What are you talking about? She's just my friend. I'm not a lesbian!"

"Huh?" Spinnerella replies, confused. "What do you mean?"

"What do you mean, 'what do you mean'?" asks Benten.

“What is that word you used? ‘Lesbian’?”

“You don't know what lesbian means?”

“Actually... no,” says Netossa.

“Lesbian... lesbian... that’s like... gay,” Benten says embarrassed.

“You mean happy?” Spinnerella asks.

“No!” says Benten. “Gay... lesbian... you really don’t know what that means? I can’t believe it... You all seem to be lesbians to me!”

“Then explain!” Netossa says. “What means lesbian?”

“It’s when... when a girl loves another girl...” Benten says, blushing more and more.

“Oh... You have a special word for that? That’s strange...”, Spinnerella says.

“Strange?” Benten says. “Why? You don’t have one?”

“No, we speak of love and that’s it. It’s a normal thing, no other words are needed.”

“Hmmm,” Benten says. “It’s strange...”

“Do you also have a special word for when a person with long hair loves another person with long hair?” asks Netossa curiously.

“Of course not!” Benten replies.

“And for when a tall person loves another tall person?”

“No...” replies Benten, who is starting to feel a little stupid. “You know, now that you made me think about it, you’re right... it’s strange...”

“It’s strange, yes...” says Spinnerella.

And the three girls remain silent, arms crossed and heads bowed, lost in their thoughts for a while longer.

Many flying boats are moored outside the large port of Seaworthy, the last coastal stronghold between Bright Moon and Salineas, when Mermista and Sea Hawk enter the imposing building on the cliff.

“Why did you want us to stop here, my dearest Mermista?” asks Sea Hawk. “Not that I’m complaining. I never say no to a romantic rendezvous with you, but I thought the circumstances demanded urgency...”

“It’s not a date!” shouts the sea princess. “Don’t get any funny ideas in your head.”

“Then what are we doing here?”

“Ugh! As you well know, my kingdom is currently... understaffed. Ever since She-Ra repaired the Sea Gate, it has protected Salineas from outside attack. But the kingdom’s army consists of few ships and even fewer sailors. If we are to withstand the attack that the Horde troops will launch against us, we must get reinforcements.”

“Oh!” says Sea Hawk, realizing the girl’s intentions. “Say no more, my dearest. I have understood everything. You intend to hire mercenaries and seafarers here in Seaworthy.”

“Exactly,” says Mermista. “I know it’s a den of pirates, the very scum of the sea... But they have men and ships. If we could convince some of them to follow us and fight for us, we could win the battle more easily.”

“Excellent!” exclaims the man. “You should know that this port is one of my favorite hideaways. And the Seaworthy Inn is my

second home, the place where I hang out with my dearest friends. It will be easy for me to convince them to take up the cause of the Rebellion."

"Ugh..." says Mermista. "Why do I get the impression that it won't be that easy?"

"Nonsense!" says Sea Hawk, pulling aside the curtain that serves as the door to the inn and entering, followed by Mermista. "Friends!" he shouts. "Sea Hawk is back!"

Inside the bar, the music ceases abruptly. The patrons at the tables stop drinking, talking, playing cards, making deals. They all look at the newcomers.

"Um... thanks for the nice welcome!" says Sea Hawk.

After a long moment of silence, the low hum of conversation resumes. The patrons look away. Sea Hawk gives Mermista an embarrassed smile, then heads for the counter, where the bartender, a muscular woman with short hair and an anchor tattoo on her arm, is busy cleaning the cups.

"Two pints of rum for my partner and me, my good lady!" Sea Hark orders.

"Ew, I don't drink that crap!" Mermista says. "Is there a soda?"

"I'll drink them both myself," Sea Hawk replies. Then he turns around, leans on the counter with his elbows, and looks around the place. His eyes light up when he notices someone sitting at a side table in the shadows.

"We are in luck, my dearest," says Sea Hawk. "Over there is a very close friend of mine. Let's go to him, I'm sure he'll be happy to help us!" he says, heading for the table. Mermista follows, soda bottle in hand.

"Hey, Scurvy! My old friend!" says Sea Hawk.

The man, a well-built person with tan skin, a short beard, and a mustache, looks at him sideways. “Sea Hawk?” he says. “How dare you show yourself before me? Have you forgotten that I have sworn to make you pay for what you have done?”

“Pay?” asks Sea Hawk. “And for what, my friend?”

“Do you not remember? I’ve had to rebuild my last three ships because you set them on fire!” replies Scurvy angrily. “Honestly, who does that?!”

Mermista rolls her eyes.

“Oh, that?” Sea Hawk laughs, sheepishly. “That was just a pet project. Now I’m busy with something much bigger. I work for the Great Rebellion. And it just so happens that we are in great need of ships and men.”

“Forget it,” Scurvy says.

“My friend here, Princess Mermista of Salineas, will pay you well!”

Scurvy’s gaze shifts from Sea Hawk to the girl at her side, looking her up and down. “A princess, huh?”

“That’s right!” says Sea Hawk. “She’s my fiancée!”

“I’m not your fiancée!” Mermista replies. And then, turning to Scurvy, “But this idiot is right: we need ships and men. The Horde is about to attack Salineas. I need someone to help us withstand their assault.”

Scurvy pauses to consider.

“Do it for our friendship!” says Sea Hawk.

Scurvy laughs. “Friendship?” he says. “Listen. Friendship is overrated. There’s only one thing that matters in this world... money.”

“And money you will have,” Mermista says. “You will be well paid.”

“In that case...” Scurvy says, getting up. “Give me a few minutes to gather my crew, and I’ll be ready to go. But... I want that arsonist to stay away from my ship!”

“Don’t worry,” Mermista says. “I will keep a close eye on him.”

Sea Hawk whines sadly.

“Good,” Scurvy says. “Then we have a deal.”

“Adventure!” shouts Sea Hawk. And then, after gesturing to a group of musicians in the inn to start playing, he launches into a sea shanty:

To Salineas, we set our sails,
A band of friends, through stormy gales,
Bound by trust, we’ll face the fight,
Together as one, we’ll brave the night.

Cannons will roar, the waves run high,
But friendship’s strength will never die,
In the very heart of war’s dark art,
United we... uh... *we’ll never part.*

Through crashing waves, we’ll hold our ground,
In waters deep, where fate is found,
With valor true, our bond held tight,
Through friendship’s might, we’ll see the light.

“Force Captain, the Sea Gate is in sight!” a soldier shouts as they stand at attention.

Octavia leans over the railing of the big flagship, which sails on the calm sea at the head of a fleet of vessels whose massive black sails bear the red symbol of the Horde. “Very well,” she says, looking through her telescope at the magical barrier on the horizon that serves as the entrance and protection to the kingdom of Salineas. “All troops prepare for attack. And as soon as we are in range, fire a warning shot.”

“How do you intend to proceed, my lady?” Mendo asks, standing next to Octavia.

“The Sea Gate is powered by the runestone of the Salinean princess,” the Force Captain answers. “As long as it operates, it’s an impenetrable barrier. But we have an ace up our sleeve that will allow us to overcome that barrier.”

“And what would that be?” Mendo asks.

Octavia winces. “It’s a secret. But all will be revealed in time. In the meantime, we’ll fight the rebel ships in the waters off the harbor. They’re so sure that their city is impenetrable that they will leave its interior completely unguarded. When the Sea Gate falls, we will abruptly change course and raid the port. Salineas will be ours.”

The Sea Gate is now in full view. In the waters ahead are several rebel ships, apparently awaiting the arrival of their enemies. A few pirate boats can also be seen among them.

“Everyone to their posts!” an officer shouts. The soldiers on the Horde flagship and the other vessels in the fleet prepare for battle.

“Princess!” announces a Salinean guard, panting as he enters the throne room. “The Horde fleet has arrived!”

Mermista stands. “Come,” she says to Sea Hawk, holding out her hand, “it’s time to fight.”

“Um, dearest,” the man says, reaching for her. “Are you sure you want to leave the palace unattended?”

“Don’t worry,” Mermista replies. “The Sea Gate is impenetrable. The battle will be fought in the waters off the harbor. And thanks to the ships we’ve hired from Seaworthy, we have a numerical advantage over Hordak’s forces. We can’t lose!”

“I hope you’re right,” Sea Hawk says. He takes a step forward. And drawing his sword, he shouts: “Adventure!”

The first cannon shot fired by the Horde flagship bounces off the Sea Gate barrier, causing no damage. It was apparently a warning shot. The following ones, however, are aimed at the Salineas ships, which respond in kind. In a sequence of fire and flames, thunderous explosions are heard, and many of the ships on both sides are damaged. On board, the men and soldiers rush to plug the leaks. Fortunately, the sea is calm and the waves crashing against the hulls don’t pose an additional problem.

At one point, one of the Horde ships falters, its structure now compromised by the blows of the enemy cannons. The hull gives way, and the soldiers aboard throw themselves into the water, trying to cling to the floating debris to keep from being dragged to the bottom.

“We’re in trouble, Force Captain!” a soldier shouts to Octavia on the flagship. “The enemy forces are more numerous than expected. And the Sea Gate shows no signs of yielding!”

“Don’t worry!” Octavia replies. “We have an ace up our sleeve.”

And just then, as if in response to her words, the magical barrier loses much of its brightness and suddenly disappears, leaving the passageway to the inside of the harbor clear.

“This is the moment we’ve been waiting for,” Octavia exclaims. “Change course and let’s go into the bay. Let’s set fire to the city!”

“What’s going on?” cries Mermista, aboard the Salinean flagship. “Why have the enemy ships changed direction?”

“Look, my dearest!” says Sea Hawk. “The gate is open. The city is no longer protected!”

“How is that possible? Someone must have turned it off!”

The princess grabs the telescope and points it toward the harbor. To her shock, she sees Scurvy’s pirate ship maneuvering inside the bay. Shouldn’t he be in the middle of the battle?

“That scoundrel has betrayed us!” Mermista exclaims. “We shouldn’t have trusted him. He must have deactivated the Sea Gate.”

“Why would he do that?” Sea Hawk says. “He’s a friend of mine! Friends don’t betray!”

“A friend, sure!” says the princess. “He only thinks about money. Someone in the Horde must have offered him more than we did.” And then, addressing her crew: “Let’s change course! We must return to the port immediately!”

And while some ships continue to fight in the open waters, the princess’s ship, followed by several others, quickly heads back toward the city, where the Horde’s flagship has already reached shore. Mermista watches in horror as scores of armed Horde

soldiers disembark at the dock and begin scattering through the streets. Civilians flee in terror.

“You will not plunder my kingdom! I won’t let you!” she says. And she dives over the railing, transforming her lower body into that of a mermaid in order to swim faster to shore.

“Forward!” says Sea Hawk, who has stayed on board the ship. As soon as it lands in port, he jumps off, ready to plunge into the battle that is already raging on the docks and in the streets of the city. Horde and Salinean soldiers are fighting hand to hand, some to conquer land, others to defend it.

“Fear not, my friends... for Sea Hawk is here!” the man shouts, drawing his lightsaber. But in front of him stands an enemy who is also armed with a sword.

“Your weapon is no match for mine, you fool!” says the opponent, little more than a boy, holding a long, curved and sharp blade.

Sea Hawk watches him curiously. “Who are you, young one? How dare you challenge the one and only Sea Hawk? Can’t you see that my mustache is... naturally shiny? You have no chance against me!”

“You poor, deluded idiot! My name is Mendo Shutaro,” the boy affirms. “I come from a family of noble samurai. Swordfighting is my specialty!”

“I’m not afraid of you,” Sea Hawk replies. “Word of my exploits has reached every corner of Etheria. My reputation would crumble if I were afraid of a brat like you. Come on and taste your defeat!”

The two swords collide with a resounding crash. Mendo attacks, but Sea Hawk parries the blow with agility. After that, they switch positions. The duel continues, neither giving way to the other. Around them, more soldiers clash amid shouts and chaos. Smoke rises from some of the buildings near the port: they have been set on fire.

Not far away, Mermista is also fighting. With quick hand movements, she produces heavy sprays of water that knock down enemy soldiers and send them flying away. Eventually, however, the princess finds herself facing a particular enemy: the Force Captain leading the Horde's assault.

"You!" shouts Mermista. "You will pay for what you've done!"

And with that, she summons a gigantic wave that rises into the air and is about to crash down on the enemy when...

...another Horde soldier suddenly appears, standing between the princess and Octavia. The soldier raises their fist and strikes with a punch the wave that was about to fall on the Force Captain, shattering it.

"W-what?" Mermista exclaims astonished. "How is that possible?"

"The ocean wave that can defeat me has not yet been born!" shouts the soldier. "The sea is my friend... and it cannot hurt me!"

Mermista takes a closer look. The androgynous features deceived her for a moment, but the opponent is undoubtedly a girl, as even her uniform suggests. And definitely a pretty one, albeit with a tough and masculine appearance. The princess blushes, but she doesn't hesitate to attack her directly.

The soldier parries Mermista's blow with ease. And just as easily, she throws her away with an arm lever. Mermista rolls to the ground and gets up almost immediately. *This enemy is a tough one*, she thinks.

But she doesn't have time to react before the soldier attacks her again. Mermista dodges her punch at the last moment.

The physical confrontation continues, strike after strike. In trouble, Mermista is forced to step back. Soon she finds herself with her back against the walls of the royal palace.

“Who are you?” the princess asks, taking advantage of a momentary lull. “You’re no ordinary Horde girl soldier.”

The soldier pauses for a moment. “Wow,” she says. “It’s the first time someone who doesn’t know me understands that I’m a girl. Maybe it’s true what they say... that clothes do make the man.”

Mermista stares at her in confusion.

“My name is Fujinami Ryunosuke,” the soldier adds. “I love to fight and I love the sea. That’s all you need to know.”

“You love the sea?” says Mermista. “Then look at this: you will definitely like it.”

And she turns to the wall and picks up a trident hanging on it. Then she lifts it with one arm and exclaims: “For the honor of... gray whales!”

Ryunosuke almost has the impression that the stone set in the trident is glowing. A flash blinds her. In the glow, between one sparkle and another, she thinks she sees... a dolphin passing in front of her, leaving a rainbow trail?!

When she opens her eyes again, Mermista is still in front of her, but... dressed differently. She has a tiara, a cape, shoulder pads, a giant starfish on her chest, and shoes that are slightly better than her normal shoes.

“W-what the...?” Ryunosuke says.

“Now you’re facing Sea-Ra, Princess of the Oceans. Beware, Horde scum!”

“Hey, who did you call Horde scum?” Ryunosuke protests, shaking her head. “You can’t insult me like that!”

“And why shouldn’t I? After all, you and your companions invaded my kingdom, threatened my people, and spread terror among them. You will pay for that!”

“Terror?” Ryunosuke hesitates. And as if only now she realizes, she turns around and notices the smoke, the screams and the battle around her. In the distance, she even seems to hear the cry of a little girl. And in the water of the harbor, on the surface, she sees an abandoned doll floating. “W-What am I doing?”

Mermista looks at her curiously. “You’re part of an invasion force that has attacked a peaceful kingdom. You threaten an innocent population.”

Ryunosuke lowers her arms and leaves the attack stance. “I...” she says. “I... I don’t want to hurt anyone. Well, I mean, my dad, yes, but no one else. I’m not bad.”

“Then why are you part of the Horde?” asks Mermista.

“They made me!” Ryunosuke protests. “I didn’t want to... I was blinded by the allure of this uniform, but... I realize now that wearing a woman’s uniform cannot justify invading a kingdom and harming its people.” She barely holds back a sob.

Mermista takes a step forward, looks at her tenderly, and gently places a hand on her shoulder.

“Where are you from, girl? You’re tough, but war is not for you. Go home, listen to me.”

“I can’t...”, Ryunosuke sobs. “I have no home here. I come from another world. I arrived on this planet through a dimensional portal.”

“What?” Mermista says in astonishment. “So you’re one of the strangers from Earth? A companion of Lum and Ataru?”

Hearing these names, Ryunosuke lights up. “Lum? Ataru? Yes!”, she exclaims. “Do you know them?”

“Of course!”, Mermista laughs.

“Where are they? Are they okay?”

“They are with the Rebellion,” Mermista replies. “The Princess Alliance is trying to find a way to get them back home. And some of my friends were planning a raid into the Fright Zone to free you and your other imprisoned friends. But we didn’t expect them to enlist you and send you into battle... Damn it! I must warn Glimmer about this!”

“My other friends are still in the Fright Zone,” Ryunosuke says. “There are only two of us fighting here... me and a classmate of mine, Mendo.”

“Where is he?” says Mermista. “We have to find him, too. We can’t miss him. It’s imperative that you all return to your world.”

“He’s fighting at the port! Don’t worry, I know how to stop him. I’ve seen Ataru do it many times...” Ryunosuke says. And she runs towards the docks. The princess follows her.

Mendo and Sea Hawk are still engaged in their duel, sword against sword. Ryunosuke and Mermista see them. “There he is,” says the Earth girl.

“He’s fighting my... uh, I mean, Sea Hawk,” says Mermista.

“Sea Hawk?” Ryunosuke says. “Wow! That’s the coolest name I’ve ever heard!”

“Whatever,” Mermista says with a groan. “The problem is, he’s holding up against him! How can we separate them?”

Ryunosuke looks around. Her gaze rests on a large metal bell leaning against the pier. “This is what I need!” she says. She approaches the bell and lifts it with a superhuman strength that amazes Mermista. Then she leaps into the air and swoops down on Mendo with the bell, trapping him underneath.

Sea Hawk freezes, astonished.

After a few seconds, a scream of terror comes from under the bell: “It’s dark, it’s cramped, I’m scared!”

“Mendo has a strong fear of the dark and confined spaces,” Ryunosuke explains to Sea Hawk and Mermista. Then she turns to the boy trapped in the bell and says: “Mendo, if I let you out, will you promise not to fight anymore?”

“Yes!” the boy shouts. “Let me out! I promise! I promise! Ahhh! It’s dark, I’m scared!”

Ryunosuke punches the bell. A vertical crack forms. And Mendo himself, pushing from the inside, does the rest: the bell breaks in two, and the two pieces fall to the ground on opposite sides.

“Uh...”, Mendo says panting on his knees. He looks up at Ryunosuke and utters, “Why did you do that?”

“I had to get your attention somehow,” the girl answers. Then she continues: “Mendo, we must stop fighting. They’re not our enemies. In fact, they want to help us get home. Ataru and Lum are with them.”

“That idiot Moroboshi? And the sweet Miss Lum?” Mendo says. “Where are they?”

“We will take you to them,” Mermista answers. “But first we must end this battle! I have to protect my kingdom.”

“We will help you!” Ryunosuke says. “Mendo, do you agree? Nothing forces us to remain loyal to the Horde.”

“But I...” Mendo says. His gaze sweeps across the dock, where other soldiers are fighting, and rests on Octavia, who is fighting near the moored ships. “I cannot raise my sword against this octopus woman. I cannot harm the living symbol of the Mendo family!”

“Ugh!” Ryunosuke says. “Then I will take care of her.” And with a leap, she hurls herself into the fray. Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Mendo watch amazed as she pushes through the soldiers and comes within a few feet of Octavia.

“What the hell are you doing, soldier?” the Force Captain asks. “Get back to the fight.”

In response, Ryunosuke hits her with a powerful uppercut. Octavia flies through the air and then falls to the ground, crashing loudly on the dock.

Horde soldiers all around stare in astonishment at their unconscious commander. Some instinctively stop fighting, lowering their weapons or dropping them to the ground. Confusion and uncertainty spread through the enemy ranks.

“Let’s go!” Mermista shouts, exhorting the soldiers of Salineas. “Drive out the invader! Victory is ours!”

Within moments, all the Horde soldiers are on the run. They dive into the harbor waters, swim out to sea, and board their ships, which waste no time in fleeing.

The Salineans cheer. Shouting fills the air. “The battle is won!” Sea Hawk shouts, raising his fist to the sky. Octavia, still unconscious, is tied up. As she is taken into custody, Mendo looks at her thoughtfully and worriedly.

Mermista approaches Ryunosuke and embraces her. “Thank you,” the sea princess says. “Thank you very much. You have done Salineas a great service today. I won’t forget it. If you wish, you’ll be always welcome here as an honorary citizen of the kingdom. May the sea always protect you!”

“I love the sea!” Ryunosuke says laughing.

“Where are our children? We want to know it!”

“You can’t keep us in the dark!”

“This damn school is always a source of trouble! It’s not possible!”

The principal’s office at Tomobiki High School is packed. Dozens of people are crowded around his desk. They are the parents of the boys and girls who have been missing for days, transported away by the portal that mysteriously opened in the gym.

“I assure you that we’re doing everything we can to get them back,” the principal says. “Please forgive us for the inconvenience,” he adds, bowing ceremoniously. Standing next to him, one to the right and the other to the left, Onsenmark and Kotatsu-neko also bow.

“My son is a wild good-for-nothing,” mourns Mrs. Moroboshi, Ataru’s mother. “But he doesn’t deserve to die in another dimension. You must bring him back here!”

“Shutaro is the legitimate heir of the great Mendo conglomerate,” declares a mustachioed man, the father of the aforementioned boy. “If he doesn’t come back soon, we will sue you. This school will fail!”

“You don’t have to worry about that!” says the principal, sweating profusely. “At this very moment, our school nurse, Sakura-sensei, is working hard to remedy the situation. I’m sure she’ll...”

Suddenly, the office door opens. Sakura appears at the door. All eyes turn to her.

“Nurse!” the principal asks. “Is there any news?”

“We were able to contact the other universe,” the woman answers. Breaths of relief fill the room.

“So can you open another portal and bring the students back here?” Onsenmark asks.

“We can try,” Sakura replies. “But I need someone,” she says.

“Who?” the principal asks.

“Him!” Sakura answers. And raising her hand, she points at the imposing figure of the Kotatsu cat.

Chapter End Notes

The title of this chapter is a fusion between the titles of She-Ra (2018) season 1 episode 5, “The Sea Gate”, and Urusei Yatsura (1981) episode 63, “Ryunosuke Arrives! I Love the Sea!”.

Save the Cat with a Grudge on the Stairs

Chapter Notes

This is the big one, guys.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The speed of the spaceship gradually decreases as the craft descends until it lands in the water in front of Beast Island. The screens on the bridge of the ship show the panorama outside: an ominous and dark landmass rising out of the ocean, surrounded by other small islands. Everything seems artificial and lifeless, and only a few tiny lights scattered along the rugged coastline hint at the possibility of life.

"Well, we made it this far," Ataru says. "There ain't no stopping us now."

"The sight of this island gives me goose bumps," says Lum. "It doesn't even feel natural. Look at those spikes. It seems like a mechanical... or synthetic settlement."

"It reminds me of planet Urchin," says Ran. "The one where we left CAO-2, Lum-chan. Do you remember?"

"The ship's computer labeled it 'Hazardous Materials Disposal Site,'" Bow says. "Apparently, the island must have been some kind of First Ones dumping ground for equipment that was corrupted, melted down, or no longer needed... which is not reassuring news, I have to admit."

"It's a cursed place," Cherry says. "Fate is against us." Everyone shivers.

"Don't be afraid," Adora says, trying to reassure the others. Which she doesn't do very well, since she's the first one to look worried and upset. "If we stick together and act in concert, nothing will

happen to us. We will find Entrapta and leave immediately. No problem at all."

Bow, however, notices that the girl is shaking. "Are you okay, Adora?" he asks, taking her aside and putting his hand on her shoulder.

"Yes, Bow. It's just that..." she hesitates. Then she continues: "Mara's message really shook me up. She said that She-Ra could destroy the universe. And Light Hope lied to me! I'm not sure I want to be She-Ra anymore. Using the sword may be dangerous..."

"You've used it many times," Bow says. "And nothing bad ever happened. I'm sure everything will be fine."

"I hope you're right..."

Bow hugs Adora, who hugs him back. At the rear of the bridge, closed in an indecipherable silence, Catra watches thoughtfully.

The ship's door opens with a hiss. The seven passengers walk down the ramp to the shore.

"Waah!" Ran cries, looking around. "What an ugly place!" Strange metallic-looking insects move across the sand. Ran jumps aside to avoid one.

"Don't be afraid, Ran-chan!" Ataru says, running towards her with outstretched arms. "I'm here to protect you!"

"Darling!" Lum scolds, grabbing his neck and holding him close. "I'm scared too! Stay close to me!"

"I sense something out there." Cherry says in a low voice. "Something big, and it's not good."

"As kids, we were warned of the dangers of Beast Island," Adora says. "Remember, Catra? There were the Chibbits with razor-sharp teeth, Scruffers with razor-sharp horns, Razorfins with..."

"...razor-sharp fins?!" Bow asks.

"Razor-sharp teeth, actually," Adora replies. "I don't know why it had that name."

"I have razor-sharp teeth too!" says Lum.

"Look!" says Catra. Everyone turns to the catgirl. She is pointing to an object on the shore, half hidden by some metallic debris.

Bow approaches and picks it up. "It's Entrapta's mask!"

"No doubt about it," Adora says. "She must have been here."

"Where do you think she went?" Bow asks.

Eerie metallic sounds come from inside the island.

"We should get moving while we still have light," Adora says. "Entrapta's here somewhere."

The party of seven sets off, entering the seemingly artificial forest, made up of strange ancient tech. Adora leads the way, sword in hand, but not transformed into She-Ra. Ataru, Lum and Bow follow. Then Cherry, and finally Ran and Catra to complete the group. As they move inland with extreme caution, they occasionally hear creatures roaring in the distance.

"This Entrapta we're looking for...", Lum asks. "...what kind of person is she?"

"She's a princess," Bow answers. "And a brilliant inventor. She makes robots and rehabs old tech left behind by the First Ones. She's a pretty big deal in the Etherian makers community! Which I am a part of, because I dabble in gadgetry myself."

"And why is she stranded on this hideous island again?" asks Ataru. "How did she get here?"

Bow hesitates to answer. Catra, unseen, frowns, feelings of guilt making their way back into her heart.

“Ask Catra,” Adora says without turning around. Ataru and Lum stop and glance at the catgirl. They don’t say a word, but Catra can feel their curious gaze.

“I have nothing to say,” the feline grumbles. And she accelerates her pace, overtaking the entire group and taking the lead, walking a few steps ahead of the others.

All around them, some creatures are chittering. “Waah,” Ran whines. “I wanna go home.”

“I’ll protect you, Ran-chan!” Ataru calls.

“Darling!” Lum yells. “How many times must I remind you? You’re married to me! You’re not free to flirt with other girls!”

“Phooey!” Ataru says. “I was born to be free!”

“Don’t you dare contradict me, darling!” Lum shouts, taking off and zapping him with an electric shock.

Ataru falls to the ground, half burned. But almost immediately, as if nothing had happened, he gets up and starts walking again, his hands in his pockets. Lum flies down to him and takes his arm. This time, Ataru does nothing to push her away.

Bow watches their behavior in in bewilderment and then, as if struck by a sudden realization, says with heart-shaped eyes: “Awww! Now I understand. Your relationship is one of love and hate. Deep down, you really like each other, even if you don’t show it in a conventional way. You’re just like... Catra and Adora.”

Both Ataru and Lum, as well as Adora and Catra, suddenly stop. Lum smiles. Adora is confused. Ataru and Catra, flustered deeply, shout in unison: “I don’t like her!”

Bow chuckles. The group starts walking again.

Suddenly, the chittering around them stops. The seven people halt in complete silence.

“Maybe...” Ataru says. “Maybe everything went quiet... for a good reason.”

A loud growl is heard, and a huge metallic creature with glowing eyes appears in front of them, gaping its mouth full of sharp teeth.

“Nope, a bad reason,” Ataru says.

“Run!” Bow shouts, pulling an arrow from the quiver he carries on his shoulders and aiming it at the creature.

“For the honor of Grayskull!” says Adora, raising her sword. But nothing happens. The transformation into She-Ra does not take place.

“W-what?” Adora exclaims. The girl is paralyzed. The enemy is about to pounce on her when Catra leaps over her head and sinks her sharp claws into it. Sparks fly. Electrical wires protrude from the creature’s eyes. The giant beast takes another hesitant step forward, then falls motionless on the ground.

“Catra!” says Bow. “Well done!”

But the catgirl doesn’t react to him, jumping down to stand beside Adora. Shaking her violently, she shouts at her angrily: “What’s wrong with you, idiot? Why didn’t you transform? That monster could have killed you!”

“I... I...”, Adora stammers.

“When did you get so weak?” Catra asks. Her tone is not arrogant, but truly angry.

“Another one is coming! Watch out!” Ataru yells. And indeed, another creature the size of the previous one gallops towards them, its mouth full of sharp teeth wide open.

“I’ll take care of it,” Lum says, throwing an electric shock from her hands, which fully penetrates the creature. The monster stops and falls down. Black smoke billows from its body.

“Zapped!” Lum smiles.

“Wow,” says Bow.

But from the depths of the island, the footsteps of many other creatures can be heard. “More are coming!” Ran says. “There are at least three or four of them!”

“No!” Adora cries, trying to raise her sword again. “Come on, come on. For the honor of Grayskull!” Nothing happens, She-Ra does not appear.

Bow shoots a few arrows at the monsters, but can’t stop their advance. “There are too many!”

“Adora!” cries Catra, her hair standing on end as she sees one of the creatures about to pounce on the blonde girl.

Suddenly, a purple barrier materializes between the monster and Adora. The creature bumps into it and rebounds. Energy projectiles, also purple, come from one side and hit the other monsters, sending them scurrying.

Slowly, a man approaches from the shadows. He wears a cloak, holds a cane, and has long, gray-brown hair with a beard.

“Who’s this guy now?” says Ataru.

“Thank you, you saved us,” Bow says, walking towards him. “Who are you...?”

The man lowers his hood. Adora and Bow gasp as they recognize his face.

“King Micah!?” they exclaim.

“Sakura,” says Tsubame. “The emissary from the planet Oniboshi is here.”

The nurse and Kotatsu-neko look up and see a gigantic tiger-striped ox entering the Tomobiki High School gym by breaking down the doors. After a few steps, he shrinks and takes the form of a beautiful boy with green hair.

“Lum?” he says.

“Welcome, Rei,” Sakura addresses him. “Yes, Lum and her friends are in serious need of rescue. You must help us to get the space equipment that is left on her UFO working again.”

“Lum?” Rei says.

“Exactly. We need this technology to open a portal and bring them back here. Tsubame and I, together with this cat, will contribute with a magical ritual.”

“Lum,” Rei says.

“I’m glad you understand,” Sakura says. “Let’s get to work.”

“Your Majesty...” Adora utters, surprised to see Micah, Glimmer’s dad, standing before her, whose features she recognizes from the murals on the walls of Bright Moon Castle.

“Huh? You know who I am?” the man says. Bow and Adora both begin to bow. “Please don’t kneel,” Micah tells them. “I’m not king

here.”

“Of course we know you,” the blonde says. “Oh, uh, I’m Adora, this is Ataru and Lum, this is Bow...”

“King Micah, it’s so great to...” Bow says, breaking off when the man suddenly grabs his face. “...to meet you...”

“Huh. Apologies,” Micah says, letting go of Bow’s face. “It’s been... quite some time since I’ve talked to anyone else. Anyone real, that is. And you are real, right?” He glances at Lum and adds, whispering to himself: “A girl in a tiger-striped bikini is exactly the kind of unreal image I would expect to see on this island...”

“Huh, yeah,” Bow says. “We are very real. Uh... And you, are you real? I mean, we kinda thought you were dead.”

“If the Horde had their way, I would be,” says the man. “They exiled me here, but I survived!”

But as soon as he finishes the sentence and starts to look at the other people in the group, he notices the uniforms of Catra and Ran.

“Horde soldiers!” he yells, taking an attack stance and raising his staff. “So you *are* enemies! You tried to deceive me!”

Catra perks her ears, takes a step back and pulls out her claws. But Adora comes between her and the man.

“No, King Micah! Wait!” says the girl. “We are not enemies. We are from Bright Moon. We know your daughter, Glimmer.”

“My sweet Glimmer?” Micah says, immediately calming down and lowering the staff.

“Yes, and also your wife, Queen Angella,” Adora adds.

“My Angella...?” Micah’s gaze softens, tears forming at the corners of his eyes. “How are they...?”

Suddenly, the sounds of the creatures can be heard again. “You’ll tell me later!” Micah shouts. “There’s no time for pleasantries! We have to move quick, follow me!” He casts spells in the direction the sounds came from and starts running in the opposite direction. The entire group hurries after him.

As she runs with the others, Catra feels a strange uneasiness rising in her. Even though she doesn’t know this man (she really shouldn’t have skipped Force Captain orientation!), she understands that Micah is someone important to the Rebellion. And therefore the fact that he is alive is not good news for the Horde. But for some strange reason, it doesn’t bother or upset her. How is that possible? Is she not interested in winning anymore? Was it enough for her to find herself on the same side as Adora, even if only temporarily, to forget what her real goals are?

The catgirl tries not to think about it. She has to focus on what’s important. Finding Entrapta and leaving this cursed island. Then she will take care of the rest, which is to destroy the Princess Alliance once and for all.

When they reach a clearing, Micah waves for the others to stop.

“We should be able to rest here for a moment,” he says. “A safe, quiet mo...”

Suddenly, the man dives to the ground. Everyone screams, then calms down when they see that he has picked up an insect. A big, disgusting insect.

“Gotcha!” Micah says. And he’s about to put it in his mouth when he hesitates. “Oh...” he says. “I’m so sorry. Where are my manners?” And he offers his prey to Adora. “Bug?”

“Uh, mmh,” Adora says. “N-no, thank you.”

Micah passes it to the others in the group. They all back away in dismay.

All except Cherry.

“I’ll have a taste, thank you,” the old monk says. And he steps forward, swallowing the bug in one bite.

Ataru, Bow and Adora look at him in disgust.

“Is it good?” Lum asks curiously.

“It tastes like chicken,” says Cherry. “Is there any more?”

“Enough of your gluttony, you stupid idiot!” shouts Ataru, pulling out a huge wooden hammer and hitting him on the head.

“How... how do you do that?” Catra asks in astonishment.

“How do we do what?” Lum asks.

“Where do you get those big hammers that come out of nowhere? And where do they go afterwards?”

“And how come you don’t get hurt when they hit you in the head?” adds Bow. “It makes no sense! They’re so huge...”

Ataru, Lum and Ran look at them uncertainly, as if they don’t understand what they are talking about.

“So!” Micah resumes abruptly, startling the others. “What brings you to Beast Island?”

“Uh...”, Adora says. “Actually, we came here looking for our friend, Princess Entrapta. Any chance you’ve seen her? She’s got purple hair and she really likes robots. She really, *really* likes robots.”

Micah thinks for a moment and then answers: “Yeah, I know her. She stole my rations. Only the tiny ones, for some reason.”

“That’s great!” says Adora. “I mean, not the food part, but the other part...”

“She’s okay! Or she was not long ago!” Bow says happily. “Do you know where she is?”

“Yes,” Micah answers. “Your friend headed straight for the center of the island before I could stop her.”

“Sounds like Entrapta,” Bow says. “Could you point us in the direction...”

“You can’t go there! You’d never come back. That’s where the signal is strongest.”

“What signal? We don’t hear anything,” Adora says.

“This place is a mass of ancient tech,” Micah explains, “mostly degraded, but some of it still works. There are machines that project strange visions, designed to deceive those who approach them. They draw them from your memories, or from your deepest fears...”

“I understand,” Adora says. “Me and Catra... we’ve dealt with something like this before.”

Catra looks away, remembering with discomfort the visions projected to them in the temple of the First Ones.

“Living here alone,” Micah says, “I’ve never had to worry too much about it. But at the center of this island, there is also a great stairway structure that never stops signaling. The signal dulls your resolve, exposes your vulnerabilities, it pulls you in. Everything that stays on Beast Island eventually becomes a part of it.”

“Why can’t we hear it?” asks Catra, raising her eyebrow.

Micah glances at her suspiciously, then replies: “Stay here long enough, and you will. I’ve heard it every day for months, years. I have no sense of time here. But I fight it! Nothing will stop me from getting off this island and reuniting with my family. But enough about me. Tell me news of the Rebellion and Bright Moon. Of my family.” Then, still looking questioningly at Catra, he asks

Adora and Bow: “Is the war still going on? Or is it over? You haven’t come to terms with the Horde, have you?”

“Relax, old man,” Catra says. “This truce is only temporary. The war still goes on.”

“I don’t trust them,” Micah whispers to Bow, gesturing toward Catra and Ran. “Why did you bring them?”

“Reality itself is in danger,” the boy answers. “We’re looking for Entrapta to help us set things right. We will think about the war against the Horde later. Right now we have to save the whole world.”

Inwardly, Catra decides she’s had enough. What if she uses this moment to return to the ship, unseen, and take off, leaving everyone else here on the island? In one move, she would be rid of many of the Horde’s enemies, including She-Ra. But then she looks at Adora, her face so sad, and thinks about the fact that she seems to be having trouble transforming with her stupid sword. If she left her on the island, she would have no chance to survive. And she also thinks about Entrapta and the nightmares that have been plaguing her for several nights. And she decides to stay.

New sounds are heard in the distance.

“What’s that?” Ran shouts, worried.

“We should keep moving,” Micah says. “I’ll help you find your friend, and then can you help me escape this place?”

“Of course!” replies Adora. “We’ll all get out of here together.” Catra frowns.

“Then what are we waiting for?” Micah says. “Follow me!”

As they walk, Catra decides to pluck up courage and steps to Adora’s side. The blonde sees her coming out of the corner of her

eye and matches her pace.

“Hey, Adora,” the catgirl says.

“Catra,” Adora replies, giving her a shy smile.

They walk in silence for a few minutes. Then Adora resolves to start a conversation.

“I can’t believe Glimmer’s dad has been alive this whole time,” she says, glancing at Catra. “And he’s so cool. A little weird, but I guess that’s to be expected after all this time alone...”

Catra doesn’t know how to reply. Hell, she doesn’t know if she should reply at all. But then she says: “Sparkles will be happy to see her dad again.”

Adora seems almost surprised to hear those words. Since when does Catra care about other people’s happiness? And Glimmer’s of all people?

After a few more steps, Catra speaks again. “Adora... what happened before? Why didn’t you turn into She-Ra?”

“I don’t know...” Adora hesitates. “Maybe something’s stopping me. Maybe something on this island infected the sword. It’s full of strange First Ones machinery, after all...”

“And couldn’t it be that you were shocked by whatever that stupid hologram told you on the ship?” Catra says. “You know, about that stupid superweapon that She-Ra would be the key to and all that?”

Adora is silent for a few seconds. Then she whispers, “Maybe... It’s just that... I... I just feel useless.”

Catra is tempted to reply with “You’re not useless.” But then she decides to use her usual sarcasm. “Well, like I said,” she utters, “if you never become She-Ra again, I’ll be nothing but happy.”

“I don’t doubt that,” Adora says. Her gaze turns cold. “You just think it will be easier for you to win the war without She-Ra.”

Catra feels a strong anger building in her chest. Technically, what Adora said is true. Not having She-Ra on the battlefield would be a huge boon to the Horde. Then why does she feel like that’s not the point? That the real reason she wants She-Ra out of the way, and the simple, kind Adora back, is entirely personal and has nothing to do with the war?

As usual, instead of facing her feelings and trying to understand them, Catra chooses to bust them. “You’re such an idiot!” she snaps.

“You’re the idiot!” Adora retorts. Catra is almost surprised to hear her answer like that. “I didn’t expect you to say sorry, but...”

“I’ll never say sorry to anybody, ever!” says Catra.

“...but know that I will never stop fighting the Horde. It’s my destiny. I promised to protect my friends, and that’s what I’m going to do.”

“Well, keeping promises has never been your strong suit,” Catra says icily.

Adora stops suddenly. Catra continues walking, head down, but after a few steps she feels Adora’s hand grab her wrist. And she stops as well. When she looks up, her eyes meet Adora’s, beautiful, sparkling blue like the sea, but they seem to be on the verge of tears.

“W-what... what do you mean?” the blonde girl asks.

“You know very well,” Catra says.

“No, I don’t,” Adora says. “Catra, explain it to me. What do you mean?”

Catra takes a deep breath. *It's now or never*, she thinks. And then she looks down again and begins to speak.

"Do you remember when we were little, in the Fright Zone? We were... four, five years old? Maybe even younger. You made me a promise that I have never forgotten. I remember your words as if they were spoken today."

Adora looks at her, eyes wide open and filled with terror.

Catra continues: "You said, 'It doesn't matter what they do to us. You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.' Do you remember those words?"

Adora is shocked. "C-Catra... Catra, I... I don't remember," she says with tears in her eyes.

"Of course," Catra says. "Why should you? For you, it was just a promise you made as a child. But for me, that promise became everything. It was the thing that kept me alive, that kept me going all these years, that made me endure the humiliations, the tortures that Shadow Weaver put me through every day..."

"C-Catra..." says Adora, now crying profusely.

Catra is crying too, even if she doesn't realize it. Her voice is full of rage. "And do you remember in Thaymor when... when we parted? When you decided it was better to protect strangers you'd known for a couple of hours than me, someone you'd known your whole life? I tried to remind you of the promise you made. I almost used your exact words: 'It doesn't matter what they do. The two of us look out for each other.' But of course you didn't even notice. You were so wrapped up in yourself, in your new mission as the hero of Etheria, that you didn't had the time or the heart to keep your old promise..."

"Catra, forgive me...", Adora cries. "I didn't... I couldn't... I had no choice..."

“Yes, you did,” Catra says. “You could have stayed with me. You could have looked out for me, like you promised.”

“Etheria is more important than you, than me... than both of us,” Adora says. “I’ve been given the power to save it. It is my task... my destiny...”

“Your destiny...”, Catra sobs. Her voice gets even angrier. “Your destiny? You always think you’re special, but you’re just an idiot! D-do you really think you need to be the one to save the world? Let the world save itself! Or let it burn, I don’t care! To hell with She-Ra! She did nothing but harm! She took you away from me! But thankfully, it finally seems that you no longer have the ability to transform.”

“You don’t understand,” Adora says. “Everyone’s fate depends on She-Ra. Mara understood that too... It was a trauma for me to find out...”

Through tears, Catra bursts into laughter. “A trauma?” she says. “Was it a trauma for you? And the traumas I have suffered, they don't count? Shadow Weaver tortured me for years! She abused me, and you never noticed! Or maybe you just didn’t care. You even justified her, saying it was because I was disrespectful to her...”

Impulsively, Adora hugs Catra. Feeling the blonde’s strong arms around her, the catgirl has the urge to reject her, but then decides not to. She lets Adora hold her, flooding her neck with her own tears.

“Forgive me,” Adora says, holding Catra tightly. “I should have realized. I knew that Shadow Weaver punished you, but until I left, I never realized how evil she was. I thought she was just a strict instructor... Worse, I thought her strictness was *right*. That it was necessary. To get the best out of us. Out of you. Out of me.”

“What an idiot you are...”, Catra says, making no move to release her embrace. On the contrary, she hugs her back, and even

tighter. Adora feels warm, safe.

“Everyone was counting on me. They said I would be the perfect Force Captain. It was my dream,” Adora says. “But I also felt the pressure, the expectations. I knew I had to be perfect. And seeing you like you didn’t have a care in the world, didn’t give a damn about anything... it fascinated me. You were yourself, you were just Catra... I’ve always admired you. I’ll never be like Catra, I told myself. To be as good as her, I have to train twice as hard, to try twice as hard. Everything comes so naturally to her...”

“For me, it was the opposite!” says Catra. “I thought that no matter the effort I put in, I would never be appreciated. So there was no point in even trying. While you were always successful at everything, you were everyone’s favorite without even wanting it, or realizing it...”

“You’re right, I was an idiot,” Adora says. “We were both idiots.”

“Yes,” Catra says. “And we still are...”

With great effort, the two girls separate. They look at each other, their cheeks streaked with tears. And they burst out laughing.

After a moment of silence, Catra smirks. “And so you always admired me, huh?” she says.

“Oh, don’t let it go to your head,” Adora replies, nudging her, as they start walking again. “I admired your agility in battle, that’s all. You’re a hybrid, after all, so you have a physical advantage over us ordinary humans.”

“Not to mention my claws,” Catra says, pulling them out and inspecting her hand. “But to be honest, you weren’t bad either. You always knew how to find a weakness in any opponent. Your strategic skills were extraordinary.”

“And they still are,” Adora says with a smug smile on her face. “And I’ve always been the strongest.”

“Pffft!” Catra laughs. “Don’t brag too much. Just because nature wanted to give you such extraordinary muscles!”

“Well, she gave you great reflexes. And sharp claws! And really beautiful eyes, if I have to be honest…” Adora says. As soon as she finishes the sentence and realizes what she just said, she blushes.

“If we’re talking about eyes, yours need not fear comparison…” says Catra. And she twitches as well, a flush on her face.

For a few minutes, with their gazes downcast, they say nothing more. Then they look up and stare into each other.

Suddenly, many episodes from the past return to Catra’s mind. Adora’s face is the same as it was when she comforted her as a child after a particularly miserable day, or when she helped her to put on bandages after a very hard training session, or when she smuggled some rations stolen from the mess hall when Shadow Weaver sent her to bed without dinner. And one image in particular comes to her mind: a very young Adora, arms wide open, standing between her and Shadow Weaver in the Black Garnet chamber, screaming “Please stop! It wasn’t her fault, it was my idea too!”

It’s not true that she didn’t notice, Catra thinks. *It’s not true that she didn’t care about me. How could I have thought that?*

The catgirl suddenly wants to talk again. She wants to express her feelings. She wants to shout to Adora that she loves her. But she can’t. She has no right to do so. And so she remains silent... a silence that is broken by a soft, unmistakable, low sound. Her purring.

And as always, this sound, coming from Catra, fills Adora with... something. Her chest suddenly becomes very warm.

The group wanders through the artificial tech jungle. Holding an ear and wincing, Micah says, "We're getting closer to the center of the island. Be careful. Even if you can't hear it, the signal is getting louder. And if you have any strange visions, don't let them distract you. Remember, they're illusions, fished out of your subconscious. They're not real!"

Lum swats away vines, and more fall to hang over their heads, making Ataru duck.

Catra stops, listening as animals make chittering noises in the jungle. "What's that?" she whispers.

"It's the pookas," Micah says in a low tone, squatting with the rest of them.

"Pookas?" Ran giggles. "That sounds adorable!"

Adora and Catra glance back at her and shake their heads vehemently and negatively.

"Let me guess, more razor-sharp scary things?" Ataru asks.

Adora and Catra shake their heads yes. Bow nervously pulls his arms in a defensive pose.

"Pookas travel in packs," Micah explains, "hunting their prey across the island, luring them in and surrounding them until it's too late. And right now... they're hunting us."

Micah stands and grunts as he summons a burst of magic from his hand and fires it across the path; the blast lingers for a moment as it illuminates several silhouetted figures with glowing eyes.

"Run!" Micah yells.

All around them, creatures skitter and shriek. Everyone scrambles in different directions.

Adora runs as fast as she can. But suddenly a pooka lands in front of her, blinking its large eye, then coming forward out of the darkness, chittering and looking at her. It's followed by many others, surrounding them.

Adora turns to see Catra, Lum and Ran behind her. No sign of the others.

The pookas approach, then suddenly look off into the distance. A stomping creature makes the pookas chitter and flee into the trees.

"They're running away!" Ran says.

"I'm afraid that's not a good sign," Adora says.

And indeed, another creature emerges from the forest, much larger, with big red eyes, sharp teeth and huge claws.

"Stand back!" shouts Catra, jumping forward and pulling out her own claws, placing herself between Adora and the creature.

"No, Catra!" cries Adora.

Too late. The catgirl leaps at the monster, but it dodges her attack and smacks her side with its paw. Adora is horrified to see blood spraying into the air. Catra falls lifeless to the ground.

Seeing her friend's wounded body, Adora feels the ground crumbling beneath her feet. On impulse, she transforms her bracelet into the sword, grabs it, and raises it to the sky.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" she says.

And this time, the transformation into She-Ra is effortless. Indeed, the Princess of Power emits a light so powerful that it illuminates the entire clearing. Blinded, the creature turns around and runs back into the forest to hide.

"Wow...!" says Ran.

“Catra!” cries She-Ra, rushing over to the feline lying on the ground. “No! No!” she sobs.

“How is she?” Lum asks.

“Lum-chan!” Ran says, “I’m afraid she’s dead!”

“Maybe she’s just pretending,” Lum says, “like that idiot Ginger.”

“Catra! No!” She-Ra cries, changing back into Adora.

But as soon as they get close to Catra’s helpless body, she starts to... flicker? And slowly she disappears into thin air, as if she was never there.

“What’s going on?” Adora asks.

“It was an illusion,” Ran says. “That man, Micah, told us that the machines here project strange images. That wasn’t Catra!”

“But then...” Adora says, feeling the blood rush back into her. “...then where is she?”

“She must have run off in another direction, together with the others,” Ran says.

“Along with my darling!” says Lum. “We have to find them!”

“Let’s go back where we came from,” Adora says. “They can’t be far away.”

Catra stops in her tracks. She turns around and sees that only Ataru has followed her. “Where are Adora and the others?” she asks him.

“I don’t know,” Ataru answers. “I was just thinking about running away from those monsters!”

“Well, what are we waiting for? Let’s go find them,” Catra says abruptly. And she goes back into the forest. A bit scared, Ataru follows her.

While they walk side by side, looking around and listening for any animals approaching, Ataru asks her: “Listen... After we leave this island, how about a romantic date with me?”

Catra halts and raises her eyebrows in dismay. “Are you serious?”

“Of course, yes! I love wild beauties like you! C’mon, how about a kiss?”

“Stay away from me! Or I’ll claw your eyes out!”

“Don’t be so grumpy! What would it cost you to try?”

“Just so you know, I wouldn’t want to be with you even if we were the only two people left on Etheria!”

“Oh, come on! I bet if you got to know me better, you would change your mind!”

“I don’t think so!” laughs Catra. “Besides, aren’t you already taken? Aren’t you with that girl in the tiger-striped bikini?”

“Who, Lum?” Ataru frowns. “If I could get rid of that pain in my ass, I would do it in a heartbeat. She didn’t...”

But his sentence stops abruptly. “Quiet! Get down!” Ataru says, grabbing Catra and throwing her to the ground with him.

“What the hell are you doing?” the catgirl protests.

“Look over there!” Ataru whispers, pointing in one direction.

Catra’s powerful hearing picks up nothing unusual, but she looks in that direction anyway. And she sees something she never

thought she'd see in her life.

Hidden in the shadows, between the artificial branches of the forest of Beast Island, two figures are embracing each other. As soon as a little light shines on them, they become visible and recognizable. They are Adora and Lum!

"What the...", Catra says.

"Sssht!", Ataru silences her.

Adora and Lum are looking into each other's eyes. Adora has her hands on Lum's back, who at the same time runs her own through the blonde's hair. The two girls get closer and closer. The space between their lips narrows and they share a passionate kiss.

Catra feels her heart stop.

"Damn Lum," Ataru says. "She always claims to love me, assures me over and over again, and then... at the first opportunity, she cheats on me! And with a girl, no less!"

Catra stands up, staggering. Her head is spinning. In a whirlwind of emotions, she does the only thing that makes sense to her: run away. She starts sprinting, not caring where she goes.

The two kissing girls disappear into the shadows. A few moments later, Ataru hears a voice calling out to him: "Darling!" He turns to see Lum flying towards him, followed closely by Ran and Adora.

"Darling, I found you!" Lum says happily.

"Cheater! Stay away from me!" Ataru yells and pushes her away.

"But darling... what's wrong?" says Lum.

"I saw you, just now. You were kissing that girl!" he answers, pointing to Adora.

"Huh?" says Lum in surprise. "Kissing? Adora? But when?"

“What are you talking about?” Adora asks him in turn, reddening. “We didn’t kiss!”

“Don’t play dumb, Lum!” Ataru is furious. “I saw you, I repeat! And I trusted you! I thought you only loved me...”

“But darling,” Ran interjects, “Lum-chan and Adora were with me all the time. Can it be that... an illusion appeared to you too, caused by these machines?”

Ataru stops to think. An illusion? Of course it is! He knows that Lum would never betray him. Suddenly, he understands that there is no other explanation.

“Darling, I’m so happy!” Lum says and runs to hug him. “You were jealous! That means you love me too!”

Realizing his misstep, Ataru blushes and tries to correct it by pulling away from her. “D-don’t be silly! I do not love you!”

“You do!” Lum laughs. “And sooner or later I’ll make you admit it.”

“I’ll only do that on my deathbed!” Ataru says.

Hearing more footsteps behind them, the four turn to see Bow, Cherry and Micah running up.

“You didn’t have to run in different directions,” Micah says. “It’s dangerous. Luckily we met again.”

“It was fate!” Cherry says.

“Wait... where is Catra?” asks Adora.

Everyone looks around. Indeed, Catra isn’t there.

Suddenly, Ataru realizes what has happened. “She ran away...”, he says. “She went towards the center of the island. She was shocked by the vision!”

“Over there is the large stairway structure...” Micah says. “The signal gets so loud you can’t think straight. We have to save her!”

Without a moment’s thought, Adora runs in that direction. Flying, Lum follows her. The others, while running themselves, lag behind, unable to keep up with the speed of the two girls.

Step by step, Adora begins to see the structure Micah was talking about. A huge spiral staircase, hundreds of feet high, made of First Ones tech and surrounded by strange equipment with screens and flashing lights. And at its bottom, Catra. The catgirl has stopped and is putting her hands to her ears. Perhaps her feline senses, so refined and more sensitive than those of a normal human, made her pick up the signal.

“Catra!” Adora calls.

Catra lifts her head and sees the blonde. “No! Stay away from me!” she screams.

“Catra, please come back! It’s dangerous.”

“Adora is right!” Lum yells, flying. “Come back!”

Catra watches them, does not answer, and begins to climb the first steps of the stairs.

Adora, running, and Lum, flying, chase after her. But as soon as they reach the bottom of the stairs, they too are hit by the signal, a piercing high-pitched frequency that seems to penetrate to the very core of their souls. The sound makes them wince, cover their ears, and grunt in pain.

“Aaagh!” shouts Adora. Hoping that She-Ra is immune, she tries to pull the sword from the bracelet and transform again, but it’s no use. The sword does not materialize.

Lum also falls to the ground, unable to fly. “This sound is interfering with my powers... It inhibits the energy flowing from my horns...!” the alien cries.

Suddenly, from the ground, black vines crawl up their legs and twine around their bodies. Adora and Lum feel their strength ebbing away. They find it hard to think and stay awake.

Catra, a few steps above, watches in horror as Adora and Lum sink to the ground, the vines wrapping around them.

“C-Catra...”, Adora murmurs before closing her eyes.

“D-darling...” Lum says, next to her. “In the end, you never told me that... you... love me...”

Eyes widening in realization, Catra goes back down the stairs, trying to tear off the vines that now encircle Adora. “No, Adora!” she cries.

Meanwhile, a dozen feet away, Bow and the others are arriving.

“Stop, Horde soldier!” Micah shouts. “It’s too late!”

“What the hell are you talking about?” cries Catra. “We must free them!”

“When the dark vines get you, there’s nothing left to do,” Micah says with a sad expression on his face. “I warned you. Beast Island is dangerous. Those two girls are lost now. The pookas lured us right into a trap.”

“No! Adora! Don’t give up!” cries Catra. And turns to Micah: “There must be a way!”

“Lum!” shouts Ataru, who also approaches the alien and tries in vain to eradicate the vines, which continue to grow. “Come back to me!”

“This island puts you to sleep...” Micah explains. “The signal weakens your will, and the vines do the rest, making you succumb. They prey on your fears, your insecurities.”

“What can we do?” Bow asks. The bodies of the two girls are now completely covered by the vines.

“They should find within themselves the strength to resurface,” Micah says. “They have to convince themselves that it’s worth fighting, worth living. But it’s hard now... We can’t help them.”

“No!” Ataru cries, “Lum! Lum! Come back to me! You’re right... I love you!”

As soon as the boy has uttered these words, a glow begins to radiate from the vines covering the alien. Some of the vines themselves begin to disintegrate, drying up and falling to the ground.

“What the...?” Ataru says.

“Of course!” Micah says, regaining enthusiasm. “Boy, you did it! You’ve shaken her up, giving her confidence and hope. She’s prisoner of an illusion, but you’re giving her something more enticing. You’re giving her a reason to come back to reality! Keep it up!”

“I never thought I’d have to say this, but...” Ataru mutters. And then he shouts with all the strength he’s capable of: “Stupid Lum... I LOVE YOU!”

The dark vines covering Lum dry up completely and fall to the ground. Bathed in a luminous glow, the girl reappears and rises to her feet. Her eyes are shining.

“D-darling!” she says.

“L-Lum!” Ataru cries. “Y-you stupid Lum!”

“Darling!” Lum shouts. And she runs to hug him.

“His fate is sealed,” Cherry comments.

Catra has observed everything without saying a word. Bow runs to her side. “Catra! Now it’s your turn!” he tells her. “You too can save Adora! Quickly!”

“W-w-what?” the catgirl stammers. “H-how?”

“Uff! Don’t you get it?” Bow tells her. “You have to declare your love to Adora too!”

“But I...” Catra says, blushing. Her ears perk up. Her tail wags nervously. “I don’t...”

“Oh, for fuck’s sake!” Ran shouts. “Just do it!” she says, pushing her towards the vines covering the blonde’s body.

Catra swallows. She closes her eyes. She concentrates. Then she opens them again and says in a weak voice: “A-Adora, I... I love you...”

“Louder!” Ran says.

“I love you, Adora!” shouts Catra, crying. “I always have!”

Slowly, the vines that covered Adora begin to dry out and fall off too.

“It’s working!” Bow says. “Keep it up!”

“Growing up with you has given my life its meaning!” says Catra. “I can’t lose you. I don’t want to. Come back to me, please!”

The vines all fall out. Wrapped in a glow, Adora opens her eyes. “C-Catra...”, she says.

“You, dummy...”, Catra cries and runs to hug her. “You’re back... You came back to me!”

“You... love me?” Adora asks with a gaze full of disbelief.

“You’re such an idiot...”, Catra smiles at her.

“I love you too,” Adora says.

Catra is taken aback. *What did she say?*, she thinks. *I must have misunderstood, she can’t have said that.*

But one look into the blonde’s eyes and her smile is enough for her to understand that this is not the case. Adora is telling the truth. She loves her. Adora wants her, exactly like she wants her.

On impulse, Catra moves her face closer to Adora’s and places her hands on her cheeks. A moment of hesitation, then their eyes meet and they give each other the go ahead. Catra and Adora kiss.

Bow, Ran, Micah and Cherry watch in amazement. Ataru and Lum, on the other hand, are busy kissing themselves.

“Adora... I’m sorry... for everything,” Catra says, melting into her friend’s arms.

“Catra...” Adora replies. “I’m sorry too... for leaving you... for being an idiot...”

“No... I was wrong. You’re not an idiot...” Catra counters. “I’m the one...”

“Uh...” Bow says, cutting them off. “I don’t want to be a spoilsport, but... maybe we should get out of here. I hear those creatures approaching again.”

“He’s right!” Micah says. “The pookas are coming back!”

“Let’s run!” Ran says.

But they don’t have time. Groups of pookas come out from all directions and surround them. Their eyes glow with an evil light.

Still weak, Adora manages to draw her sword and recite the formula that transforms her into She-Ra. Ready to protect her friends, and especially Catra, she prepares to fight.

Before the beasts can attack, however, a loud noise is heard. The pookas suddenly look off into the distance. A stomping creature makes them chitter and flee into the trees.

“What happens now?” Bow asks. “Who else is coming?”

A dark figure stomps down behind him, shaking the ground and sending dust flying. Bow whines nervously and slowly turns his head to glance at the newcomer.

It’s some kind of giant robot, with a stocky and round body, imposing arms and legs, and almost animal-like features. It doesn’t look friendly at all.

She-Ra points her sword at it. “Get behind me!” she shouts. Everyone follows her command.

The robot’s mouth opens slowly. Inside are two bright eyes, bathed in darkness. Then a mask is lifted, and everyone gasps.

A smiling Entrapta peers down from the robot’s mouth and greets them happily: “Princesses! I saved you!”

Chapter End Notes

> The title of this chapter is a fusion between the titles of She-Ra (2018) season 5 episode 5, “Save the Cat”, and Urusei Yatsura (1981) episode 51, “A Cat with a Grudge on the Stairs”.

After You've Gone to the Fright Zone

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Is there any news?" asks Queen Angella, sitting on her throne in the Bright Moon palace.

"Things are going well," Castaspella replies as she approaches. "Sakura, the priestess from the planet Earth I contacted, assured me that they will have no problem opening a portal on their side. They have both the technology and the magic. They were missing one component, the spiritual anchor to keep the passage open, which for us will be She-Ra. But it looks like they're going to fix that by using, if I didn't misunderstand... some kind of giant ghost cat." Angella looks at her with a bemused expression. "Yes, I probably misunderstood," Castaspella adds.

"Let's hope this all works out," Angella sighs. "We cannot afford to fail."

"Mom!" Glimmer yells as she also enters the throne room. "I mean... Your Majesty!" The princess is followed by Benten and Oyuki. "We're ready to go on our mission."

Angella shivers. "Glimmer, promise me again that you'll be careful. The Fright Zone is a dangerous place."

"Don't worry, mom," Glimmer replies. "We've been there before, remember?"

"Yes, and you almost didn't come back," Angella replies. "But unfortunately, we have no choice. We need to rescue the other captured earthlings, and we don't have much time."

"The mission will run smoothly, Your Majesty," Benten says smugly. "Oyuki and I are not afraid of anyone. And we will take care of your daughter."

“Shadow Weaver is waiting for us near the Moonstone, along with Perfuma and Frosta,” Glimmer says, not mentioning that little Ten will be there as well. “They’re all ready to fight. We’ll make it!”

“I’m not happy about allowing that sorceress to access your connection to the Moonstone again, Glimmer,” Angella says. “I know she can boost your powers and teleport your party all the way there. But that doesn’t make me feel any better.”

“Come on, mom... We already did it once and nothing bad happened.”

“Ever since she lost her own connection to the Black Garnet, this woman has been desperate to reconnect with another runestone, either temporarily or permanently,” Castaspella adds. “She’s power hungry... and dangerous!”

“I’ll keep an eye on her!” Glimmer says. “If she tries any dirty tricks, she’ll regret it. Trust me.”

Angella hesitates. She glances at Castaspella, who nods. Then she says: “All right, Glimmer. I trust you. Go and come back soon.”

“Thanks, mom!” Glimmer replies, hugging her.

Angella returns the hug. “Don’t take any unnecessary risks,” she advises again.

“Fear not,” Glimmer says. After that, she, Benten and Oyuki leave the throne room and head for the pillar that holds up the Moonstone.

On the platform at the top, Perfuma, Frosta, Ten and Shadow Weaver are waiting for them. Without saying a word, the masked sorceress holds out her hand to Glimmer.

The princess takes it. The whole group joins hands. And a magical, ominous, purple light envelops them. With a buzz, they vanish and teleport away.

The big robot strides briskly through the artificial forest that covers Beast Island. Inside, Entrapta nimbly operates the controls with her prehensile purple pigtails. Behind her, eight people are squeezed into the cramped cockpit.

“Wow,” Entrapta says. “I can’t believe we’re all here on Beast Island at the same time. What an incredible coincidence.”

“Uh... It’s not a coincidence,” Bow comments. “We came to find you.”

Ignoring him, Entrapta pulls out her recorder, presses a button, and begins speaking. “Beast Island log, tide cycle 37,” she says. “I have confirmed that the outside world still exists. I found princesses! Well, one princess, or maybe three, not sure, plus Catra, Bow, another boy, a strange old man and...”

Pausing for a moment, Entrapta sniffs a squished Micah.

“Do I know you?” she asks.

“Yes, you do!” Micah protests. “You stole my food.”

“Oh yeah! It was delicious!”

“Entrapta...” Adora interrupts. “We have been looking all over this island for you. Are you okay?”

“Of course I’m okay!” she answers. “Have you seen this place? An island full of technological monstrosities, each more deadly than the next? It’s a paradise!”

“Yeah, um, glad you’re having fun,” Bow says, “but we’re kind of going to need your help. You must return with us to Bright Moon immediately.”

“Bright Moon?” Entrapta asks, puzzled. Her gaze moves to Catra, who shyly lowers her eyes.

“That’s right, Entrapta,” Adora says. “We need you to help us open another portal!”

Entrapta continues to glance at Catra, confused. “Another portal?” she asks. “But Catra...”

The feline feels the tension boiling inside her. And she can’t keep quiet anymore. “Entrapta, listen...” she says. “I know I messed up before. You warned me not to open the portal and I didn’t listen. I need to say sorry to you, for everything.”

Entrapta looks at her bewildered. Even Adora is astonished. It is the second time in a short period that she hears Catra apologize, the same Catra who swore that she would never say sorry to anyone, ever. It almost seems that once she starts, she cannot stop, as if every barrier she has built around herself has finally crumbled.

“I’m sorry for treating you badly,” Catra continues, “for sending you here to Beast Island, for stealing your work, for using it to rip a hole in the fabric of space and time, and for... being a bad friend.” Catra keeps her head bowed, ears pointed down, and tears in her eyes. Her expression clearly shows her sincere remorse.

Entrapta stands still for a moment. Then her prehensile hair moves toward the catgirl and pats her on the head.

“I forgive you,” she says.

Catra can’t hide a shy smile. Her tail wags in the air.

“So!” Entrapta exclaims. “Despite my calculations, the portal Catra opened did not cause the end of the world. Something must have interfered and balanced it on the other side. But if you’re asking me to open another one, I suspect it has to do with the

increasingly frequent and mysterious phenomena that threaten to slowly consume and warp our reality. Am I right?”

“H-how do you know?” Bow asks.

“Oh, I figured it out a while ago,” the tech princess answers, still smiling. “An imbalance between dimensions is the only thing that would account for all the anomalies I’ve been picking up lately, even on this island. Something from the other world has come here to ours, and if it’s not brought back soon, it’s gonna keep destabilizing reality and eventually make everything disappear! Bwahahahaha!”, she laughs, but then stops, gets serious and adds: “...which is a bad thing.”

“Wow,” Ran comments fascinated. “You really are a genius, as we were told.”

“Thanks, pink Horde princess!” Entrapta says.

“I’m not a princess...” Ran says, pouting.

“Oh, and you can fly?” Entrapta turns to Lum abruptly, changing the subject. “How do you do that?”

“Entrapta, she and these other people came here from the other universe,” Adora says, pointing at Ran, Lum, Ataru and Cherry. “And there are others as well. That's why we have to go back to Bright Moon right now, open a new portal and send them back!”

“But it’s not that simple!” Entrapta replies. “Even if we use the First Ones’ tech and the magic of your sword to reopen a portal, we need someone in the other dimension to open another one at the same time!”

“We already know that,” Adora says. For once, it’s Entrapta who looks surprised. “Mystacor’s head sorceress, Castaspella, is in contact with someone from the other world, and they will open a portal on the other side as well. We can do it!”

Entrapta ponders for a moment, then says: “And how can we leave this island? My robot can’t swim across the ocean. The salt water would seep into her joints and cause an overflow.”

“We have a spaceship,” says Lum.

“A... a spaceship?” Entrapta asks. Her eyes suddenly light up.

“Yes, we flew here on an ancient First Ones ship...” Adora confirms.

“A ship?” Entrapta shouts excitedly, her voice a few pitches higher. “You have a First Ones spacecraft? A First Ones spacecraft that works? I WANNA SEE IT!”

Guided by Glimmer’s magic, enhanced by Shadow Weaver, seven people materialize in the corridors of the Fright Zone. The area is deserted, despite the lights illuminating the metal walls and the loud, incessant hum of the machines.

“We did it!” says Glimmer. “I’m thrilled! I can’t believe I was able to teleport so many people this far!”

“Brrr... this place always creeps me out,” says Frosta.

“It really sucks!” says Ten.

“Be quiet,” Shadow Weaver admonishes. “After last time, the Horde surely has increased its surveillance. We must not be discovered. Stay behind me. I will lead you to the cells where the prisoners are being held. We’re not far. I know this area well, for I myself was a prisoner in these cells for a long time.”

“But our friends are not in the cells,” Oyuki says.

“What?” asks Shadow Weaver. “That’s not possible.”

“It’s the truth,” Benten says. “Only Ran, Oyuki and me were locked up. Then Ran was let out by the catgirl, after they seemed to bond somehow. And that scorpion lady told us that everyone else had been drafted into their army... and had begun training.”

“That’s really unfortunate!” Shadow Weaver says. “And will complicate our plans!”

“So where can they be?” Perfuma asks.

“If they were conscripted into the army, they could be in the cadet barracks,” Shadow Weaver replies. “Or they’re training in the gym or in one of the simulation rooms. Let’s hope they haven’t been sent into battle yet. Normally, a new recruit requires years of training before they can be deemed fit for combat, but with the war in its late stages, Hordak and Catra may have decided to cut corners and use even inexperienced soldiers. When I was in charge of everything, these things didn’t happen...”

“Don’t regret those times too much!” Glimmer tells her. “Remember, you’re with us now.”

“So what do we do?” asks Ten.

Shadow Weaver thinks for a moment. Then she says: “Let’s look in the barracks. And if we don’t find them there, we’ll go to the gym.”

Suddenly a side door opens. Two armored Horde guards enter the corridor and stop when they see the intruders.

“Alert!” they yell, turning and preparing to run in the opposite direction. But green vines generated by Perfuma immobilize one of them.

“Great, how did you do that?” Benten asks.

“It’s plant magic!” Perfuma answers.

The other soldier also tries to escape. But after a few steps he finds himself completely frozen in an ice block made by Oyuki.

“Wow!” exclaims Frosta, standing next to the queen of Neptune. “That was really cool! I never thought to freeze an enemy so quickly. Can you teach me how?”

“Of course!”, Oyuki smiles at her. “But later. Right now, we have to find our friends.”

“Let’s hope that no other guard finds us first. Let’s go...”, Glimmer says.

But her sentence is interrupted by a screech coming from above. Everyone looks to the ceiling and sees a tiny greenish creature fluttering above them. It has the appearance of a newborn, with teal skin, yellow eyes, and gray bat wings. “Alert! Alert! Alert!” it repeats in a tinny voice.

“It’s Hordak’s little spy!” says Shadow Weaver. “We must stop him, or we are doomed!”

“I’ll take care of him!” says Ten, and takes off.

The princesses watch in bewilderment as the two flying children circle each other. As the Imp is about to enter an air vent, Ten opens his mouth and spits out a flame that burns him.

Hordak’s spy, half roasted, falls unconscious to the ground.

“That’s it!” says Ten, descending slowly.

“Is... he dead?” Glimmer asks.

“He’s an artificial creature,” Shadow Weaver says. “A clone. I don’t think he can die, or at least not so easily. He’ll recover, but we don’t have to worry about that for now.”

“Too bad, he seemed nice,” Ten says.

“This is no time to make friends,” Shadow Weaver says. “Let's stop wasting time and get moving. Follow me!”

Holograms that resemble diabolical and distorted princesses swoop down on the recruits from all sides in the large simulation room.

“Be careful, Chibi!” Lonnie yells. “You’ve got one behind you!”

The small boy turns around, but can’t dodge the blow that hits him from above. A red “X” lights up on his bodice.

“Oh, no! Again!” Chibi exclaims and stays lying down.

“Don’t worry,” Kyle shouts at him. “You’ll get used to it after a while.” He, too, lies on the ground, hit by a virtual enemy shot. And next to him is Kakugari, who has suffered the same fate.

“Rogelio, let’s attack from the right!” Lonnie orders. “Perm and Megane, from the left!”

“I don’t understand why we have to fight like this, like common foot soldiers,” Megane complains as he dodges a blow from the side. “I saw that you have powerful armored vehicles in your arsenal. Why don’t you let us drive a tank? Leopards are my passion!”

“Those aren’t meant for common soldiers, let alone cadets like you,” Lonnie replies. “Consider yourself lucky if they give you an armor.”

“If they won’t give one to me, I’ll make one myself! I already did it on Earth...!”

“Watch out, Megane!” shouts Perm to warn his friend. Too late: a shot fired by a “princess” hits him from behind and puts him out of action.

Lonnie and Rogelio, meanwhile, have reached the “Queen of the Princesses,” a hologram-projecting robot much larger than the others. With a move honed by years of training, Rogelio lifts Lonnie and hurls her at the enemy. Lonnie grabs her staff and strikes the eye in the center of the robot. Sparks fly. The hologram disappears.

The landscape of the simulation dissolves and the room returns to its original appearance.

“We did it!” shouts Perm.

“Training exercise successfully completed,” says a tinny voice over the loudspeaker.

“We finally did it,” says Lonnie. “But we only had three survivors out of seven. This is not good... We need to improve. Let’s try again!”

“Again?” protests Kakugari. “I’m tired!”

“No excuses! This time we have to...”

Lonnie’s sentence is cut short when a green vine hits her in the side, slamming her into the wall behind her. The girl bounces off the surface in pain, but somersaults back to her feet.

“What the hell?” she says.

“Princesses!” Kyle shouts, pointing to the front door. On the threshold is Perfuma, followed by her companions.

“Stop them!” Lonnie urges, rushing to attack the enemy. But she can’t get more than a few steps before Benten appears in front of her, knocking her down with an uppercut.

Megane, Perm, Kakugari and Chibi stand still. “B-Benten?” says Perm.

“Aaah!” Kyle yells, lunging at the intruders. A flame from above fully engulfs him. Ten cheers as the boy falls down, burned.

Rogelio pulls a stun baton from behind his belt and positions himself between his fallen comrade and the enemies, ready to fight. But a cold wind hits him. And within moments, he finds himself frozen inside a block of ice.

“Yas!” Frosta shouts. “Did you see, Oyuki? I did it!”

“Very good!” Oyuki replies as she stands next to her, smiling.

Seeing the three Horde soldiers defeated, the four Lum’s Stormtroopers look around, uncertain and worried.

“Earthlings!” Glimmer says, stepping forward. “Don’t be afraid. We are not enemies. We’re here to rescue you.”

“Listen to her, you idiots!” Benten says. “You know Oyuki and me, right? These princesses are our friends. We will take you to safety. Ataru and Lum are waiting for you.”

“Lum?” Megane says. His eyes light up. “Is Lum all right? Can we meet her?”

“Of course!” Ten says, flying down. “And then we can all go home!”

The four Earth boys cheer. “Finally! I couldn’t stand this place anymore!” says Perm.

“Let’s go home!” Kakugari rejoices.

“Yes, let’s go...” says Chibi. But he stops short, turns around and sees Kyle on the ground behind him, unconscious and with a scorched face. Hesitating, he takes a few steps towards the

scrawny boy and kneels down beside him, supporting his head and resting it on his knees.

“Chibi, what are you doing?” Kakugari asks.

“Kyle... Kyle is my friend,” the small boy answers. “He doesn’t like this place either. We... we could take him with us.”

“What?” Glimmer exclaims. “No way! He’s a Horde soldier!”

“But he’s not evil!”, Chibi says. “He grew up here, he didn’t choose a side. He never had a choice. Is that true, dude?” he asks Kyle, who is slowly opening his eyes.

“W-what... Where am I?” Kyle asks.

“Are you okay?” Chibi says.

“Y-yeah...” Kyle answers. “I’m used to being beaten... But what’s going on?” He looks around. “Princesses? Have we been attacked?”

“They came to rescue me and my friends,” Chibi says. “To take us away. Would you like to come with us?”

“Me?” Kyle exclaims astonished. “Come with you? Away from the Horde?”

“Yes! You told me that you don’t like this place, that everyone treats you badly. You could leave it forever... And start a new life away from here.”

Kyle frowns. Then he says: “But I... my friends... I can’t leave them here...”

“Then bring them too!” Chibi says. “They can all come with us!”

Behind him, Lonnie slowly comes to her senses. Perfuma hurries to tie her up with a vine. And she does the same with Rogelio, as the ice that held him captive begins to melt.

“Ugh...” Lonnie says, opening her eyes again. “W-what’s going on?”

“Lonnie!” Kyle tells her. “They’re suggesting that we escape with them... That we defect...”

“D-defect?” says Lonnie. “Going with the princesses? That’s absurd! What’s on your mind, Kyle?”

“But we could...” Kyle hesitates.

“Whoa, whoa, whoa!” shouts Glimmer, interrupting them. “Wait a minute! First of all, I have no intention of adopting all those Horde soldiers! Second...”

“Don’t worry, princess,” Lonnie tells her with a challenging look. “We’re the ones who don’t want to go with you!”

“As I was saying...” Glimmer continues, looking at her sourly. “Second, I don’t even know if I could teleport all these people at once, even with my Shadow Weaver-enhanced powers...”

As soon as she says the name, a realization hits her. “Uh, Shadow Weaver! That’s right! Where did she go?”

Everyone turns and looks around. There is no sign of the dark sorceress in the room.

“She’s not here!” says Perfuma.

“How long has she been missing?” Frosta says.

“She was with us in the corridor earlier,” says Benten. “But after the barracks I didn’t saw her again!”

“She told us to go this way,” Oyuki says, “but she didn’t follow us. She must have gone somewhere else.”

“But it doesn’t make sense,” Glimmer says. “Why did she leave alone? Where would she ever go...”

A shiver runs through her, just as she realizes what's happening.

"The Black Garnet!" Glimmer exclaims. "She's gone to the Black Garnet chamber! She wants to reconnect with her former runestone!"

"What?" Perfuma says. "That can't be!"

"This is bad!" Frosta says.

"Uh... what are you talking about?" Megane asks.

Glimmer sighs and begins to explain. "The Black Garnet is an elemental runestone that is kept here in the Fright Zone. The Horde took it many years ago, and Shadow Weaver used to absorb its energy and grow more powerful. If she can reconnect with it, she will be a threat to us once again. We must stop her!"

"And where is this stone?" asks Benten. She turns to Lonnie: "Do you know?"

"We'll never tell you, princess!" Lonnie says. But her voice is shaking, and her eyes are filled with hesitation.

"I know where it is," says Glimmer. "I've already had the pleasure of being a guest of Shadow Weaver in her lair. I still remember how to get there. Let's go now!"

"Just a second!" Oyuki says. "And the other Earth people? We have to find them too!"

"Mendo, Shinobu and Ryunosuke no longer train with us," Perm says. "They were... promoted, I think. We were told that they have been placed under the supervision of a Force Captain."

"Ugh, that complicates things..." Glimmer says. "But we'll think about that later. We have to stop Shadow Weaver first!" Then, looking at Megane and his companions, she adds: "You four wait here for us, and keep an eye on those three Horde soldiers."

“You’re not going to make it,” Lonnie says.

“Oh yeah?” Glimmer replies. “And why is that?”

“If the witch has already regained possession of the Black Garnet, she has become too strong for you. And she won’t be caught off guard!”

“We’ll see!” says Glimmer. “I’ve beaten her before.”

“That was before Entrapta tinkered with the runestone and increased its power.”

“It doesn’t matter. She’s alone, we are six!”

“Three princesses who are very far from their kingdoms and therefore from the source of their powers?” Lonnie replies. “Plus a child and... two aliens out of their comfort zone? Against a witch burning with resentment and desire for revenge, ready to unleash all her power against those who banished and humiliated her? Good luck with that!”

“Do not underestimate us, Horde scum!”

“I’m not underestimating you... I’m just warning you.”

“Whatever,” Glimmer says. “I’m not afraid of her.” And turning to the others, “Come on, let’s go!”

“It’s the most beautiful thing I’ve ever seen!” Entrapta exclaims as she steps aboard Mara’s ship, her moving hair exploring the dashboard and the instrument panel. “How does it work? What does this button do? I’m going to push it and find out!”

“No... stop. This isn’t the time. Stop, I said!” Bow shouts, blocking Entrapta from pressing a random button.

“Sorry! Sorry!” laughs Entrapta. “But you must understand that this is all incredibly exciting. A spaceship... A real spaceship... to go into space!”

“Yes, well... no space for now, Entrapta. Let’s just go back to Bright Moon.”

“Wow, how excited you are,” Ran comments. “Have you never seen a spaceship before?”

Entrapta takes out her recorder, presses the button and says, “Darla log, day one,” she says. “The pink Horde princess seems to think that it’s not normal for a person to never have seen a spaceship. This means one of two things. Either she’s nuts, or...” Entrapta pauses for a moment, then her eyes open wide. “...or she comes from a place where spaceships are common!”

“Uh... yes?” Ran says. “I’m an alien, remember? Spaceships and robots are my bread and butter.”

“Robots?” Entrapta asks enthusiastically. “Do you like robots? This is the first time I know someone who likes robots!... Except for my former lab partner, of course...” And as she says these last words, she pulls the mask down over her eyes, covering her face. Then, after a pause, she adds, talking to herself: “I wonder how much he would have liked to see Darla.”

“Darla?” Adora whispers into Catra’s ear, who sits purring in her lap.

“Entrapta has a habit of giving names to robots and machines,” the catgirl explains. “For some reason, only female names...”

“Speaking of robots,” Ran continues, addressing the tech princess. “That one from before... did you build it? Did you do it all by yourself, here on the island? Without tools?”

“Are you talking about Betty? I just retrofitted some of the machines the First Ones dumped on the island. Why?”

“I thought it was impressive,” Ran answers with a smile. “Building robots is my passion, too. Especially mini explosive dolls that I use as messengers.”

“Um, that’s an interesting idea...”, Entrapta comments. And then, speaking into her recorder: “Darla log, day one continued. Reminder to myself: be sure to check out the exploding mini dolls with the pink Horde princess when we return to the Fright Zone.”

“We’re not going back to the Fright Zone, Entrapta!” says Bow. “We’re going to Bright Moon, remember?”

Entrapta stares at him blankly for a moment. Then, after a few seconds, she says: “Ooooh. Yes, it’s true. What are we waiting for? And can we take Betty with us?”

Catra groans. Entrapta takes that as a yes. She claps her hands and the big robot enters the ship, taking up most of the space on the bridge.

Micah meanwhile is busy talking to himself: “I still can’t believe it. Is it all true? Are we really going home? Will I see my Angella and my baby Glimmer again?”

Bow smiles at him, then approaches the ship’s control panel and gives the order. “Um. Take us home to Bright Moon.”

The ramp to the ship rises. The door closes. The engines fire and the craft lifts off.

Dark, purple lightning bolts shoot out of Shadow Weaver’s hands, striking Benten and Perfuma and sending them crashing to the

ground. Behind them, Oyuki and Frosta lie unconscious as well. Huge gloomy shadows spread behind the masked sorceress, engulfing the entire room.

“D-damn traitor!” Glimmer yells, dodging Shadow Weaver’s attack. “I should have known you were going for this. You just wanted to get your magic back!”

“Can you blame me?” the sorceress laughs. “Catra had broken my connection to the Black Garnet, and Hordak had banished me. I came to you because it was my only hope of survival. But I have always harbored revenge... and a desire to regain my power!”

“And what will you do now?” Glimmer asks.

“Overthrow Hordak!” Shadow Weaver shouts, hurling another purple bolt at the princess. “Take command of the Horde. Reshape it, twist it to my liking and whim. And then... crush the Bright Moon Rebellion! All of Etheria must bow to me!”

“You’re delusional... I’ll stop you!”

The dark sorceress laughs again. “Do you really think that your weak power, without my amplification, will be able to defeat the Black Garnet?”

And the shadows that now cover the entire room reach Glimmer, who feels her strength failing her.

“It’s over for you, princess!” says Shadow Weaver. “It’s over for all of you!”

Glimmer falls on the ground, unconscious. The sorceress turns and walks back to the reddish runestone, placing her hands on it to recharge herself.

Just then, little Ten, who had been hiding behind a piece of machinery, takes the opportunity to flee the room. Flying through the corridor, he returns to the simulation room, where Lum’s Stormtroopers are waiting.

“Ten!” Megane says as he sees him arrive. “What happened? Did you make it?”

“No!” the child cries. “It’s a disaster! The witch defeated them all!”

“What?” Perm asks. “Even Benten and Oyuki? That can’t be!”

“I told you it wouldn’t be easy!” says Lonnie.

“Things are bad!” says Ten. “The witch wants to conquer the Horde and then the Rebellion. She wants to rule over everyone! What can we do?”

“If not even the princesses could defeat her... how can we?” says Kakugari.

Everyone remains silent for a moment. Then, surprisingly, it’s Kyle who speaks.

“I-if Shadow Weaver draws her power from the Black Garnet...” he says. “If she taps into the energy of the runestone... then maybe...”

“Maybe what, Kyle?” Lonnie interrupts. “Don’t start with your usual nonsense!”

“Shh!” Chibi says. “Let him talk!”

“...then maybe we can stop her siphoning the energy...”

“How, Kyle?” Lonnie says.

“...by reconnecting the runestone to the princess it originally belonged to!” Kyle says.

Lonnie’s eyes widen. Behind her, Rogelio makes some noises. After a moment, Lonnie exclaims, “Kyle, you’re a genius!”

“What’s he talking about?” Megane says. “Which princess?”

“Scorpia!” Lonnie replies. “The Black Garnet was the stone of Scorpia’s family! But when the Horde landed here, they gave it to Hordak, who in turn handed it over to Shadow Weaver.”

“And could Scorpia reclaim her powers? Take them out of Shadow Weaver’s control?” Perm asks.

“I don’t know, but it’s the only hope we have,” Lonnie says. “Come on, we have to find her!”

While Adora and Catra continue to cuddle in each other’s arms, oblivious to the other people on the bridge, the ship continues its flight towards Bright Moon. After a quick check at the command console, Entrapta approaches Lum.

“So,” the princess of Dryl asks. “You aliens, do you really travel between stars and planets? Are you always moving through space? Tell me! I want to know everything. What is space like? I would give *anything* to go there!”

“Um... how can I put it?” Lum replies. “Space is... super weird! Nonsensical things happen on an everyday basis. If you put weird and weird together, and make it even weirder, then you can start to understand how weird space is!”

“Fascinating!” Entrapta replies. “You know, you’re the second person I know who has traveled in space.”

“The second?” Lum asks. “And who’s the first?”

“Hordak! He told me many stories about... wars and battles and conquests of other planets!”

“Speaking of which...” Bow interjects. “Shouldn’t we also be worried about the imminent arrival of the Galactic Horde? Mara’s

hologram said that she placed Etheria in Despondos, a completely empty dimension, to protect it from outside dangers. She also said that if we opened a portal, death and destruction would follow. She was probably referring to the Horde's Space Army."

"Oh, that's right!" Entrapta says, smiling. "Hordak was going to open a portal just to send a signal to his big brother to come up here."

"S-so are we in danger?" Bow asks, his voice cracking.

"I don't think he succeeded," Entrapta says. "If the portal we built brought these aliens here, that means its target was diverted. And therefore, it's unlikely that the signal reached Horde Prime. Sure, I can't guarantee it one hundred percent... But let's say I'm 96.7% sure, if that makes you feel better."

"I would say yes," Bow says with a sigh of relief.

The small spherical robot beeps and whirs as she rolls to get upright, bumping into Scorpia's dresser.

"Whoa, hey, Emily! Careful there!" says the scorpion princess, placing a metal bowl with various nuts and bolts on the floor. "I'm still not sure if you eat, but anyway... here's your food."

Emily continues beeping and spinning around.

Scorpia sighs, then sits down on the edge of the bed. She looks around.

"You know, Emily... I miss Entrapta too. And not only that... I miss Catra. Even though it seems like she doesn't want to be my friend anymore. First she surrounded herself with those Crimson Waste goons, and then that new Force Captain, the pink-haired alien. If I

didn’t know her well, I’d say she’s found herself a new best friend... and I’m not happy about it...”

Emily stops spinning.

“How I wish things would go back to the way they used to be. When it was just me, Catra and Entrapta... the Super Pal Trio! Ah, the fun we had then!”

Emily whirrs and emits a new series of beeps.

“Yes, you’re right, Emily!” Scorpia says. “You were there too! You were our sidekick. Man, those were good times, huh? But I promise you, sooner or later they will be back. I’ll get Catra to bring Entrapta back from Beast Island, and we’ll be best friends again. I will be the best friend I can be! After all, I’m brave, strong, loyal, and give great hugs.”

Footsteps are heard from outside the room. Scorpia looks up curiously at the door, which suddenly opens.

“Lonnie!” she exclaims. “What’s going on?”

“Emergency!” Lonnie says. She is joined by Kyle, Rogelio, the four new recruits from Earth and... a flying baby with green hair and a horn?

“Who is this brat?” Scorpia asks.

“Don’t mind him,” Lonnie says. “We need to get to the Black Garnet chamber right away. We have to stop Shadow Weaver!”

“W-what? Shadow Weaver?” Scorpia asks, confused.

“The sorcerer is back and wants to destroy the Horde. The only one who can take the power of the runestone from her is you... by claiming it for yourself!”

Scorpia gasps.

“But I... I can’t...” she says. “I’m not...”

“You’re a princess, Scorpia!” Lonnie tells her. “And it’s time to prove it. We need you to reconnect with the Black Garnet.”

Scorpia is speechless. She lowers her head.

“You can do it, Scorpia!” Kyle says.

“What if the Black Garnet doesn’t want me?” she asks. “It never worked for me... And I just... kind of get rejected a lot.”

“Tell me about it,” Kyle says. “I get harassed by everyone all the time. My training results suck. But I don’t give up. If we fight together with our friends, we can be stronger than anyone might think. We can do this. We can save everyone!”

“Everyone?” Scorpia asks, looking up.

“You’re not hopeless,” Lonnie says. “You were born for this. And we’ll help you. We’re in this together. You’re going to make a great princess!”

A smile creeps across the Force Captain’s face. And with it, the first signs of a newfound confidence. Standing up, Scorpia hugs Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio and lifts them off the ground.

“Ugh!” Lonnie exclaims, half crushed.

“Sorry, that was probably too much,” Scorpia says, setting them down. “All right then. I’m in. Let’s go to the Black Garnet. And let’s save the world!”

Even from the corridor, she can feel the enormous amount of energy emanating from the runestone. Peering through the doorway, Scorpia watches as Shadow Weaver places her hands on the Black Garnet, siphoning off its power, surrounded by dark shadows and purple flashes radiating in all directions. On the

ground around her lie the helpless bodies of Glimmer, the other princesses, and the two aliens.

Scorpia pulls her head back and turns to her friends in the hallway. “Ugh! How do I get to the runestone? Shadow Weaver is right next to it. If I enter the chamber, she will notice and knock me out!”

“We need a diversion,” Lonnie suggests.

“I-I’ll take care of it!” says Ten. And without waiting for a counter, the child flies into the room. From above, he breathes fire and shoots flames at the dark sorceress.

When Shadow Weaver notices him, she removes her hands from the runestone and points them upward, hurling purple lightning bolts at Ten. The child barely dodges them, flying in circles and higher and higher, toward the ceiling. The witch follows him with her gaze, continuing to attack him, moving a few feet away from the Black Garnet.

And just at that moment, Scorpia takes the opportunity to quickly enter the room and run towards the stone.

Out of the corner of her eye, Shadow Weaver notices her and rushes back to the Black Garnet to regain control of it.

But it’s too late. Scorpia reaches the runestone first. She places one of her pincers on it and concentrates, telling herself, “You can do this. You can do this.”

In an instant, the Force Captain feels the magical power flowing through her. She moans. “Wow. It’s like...”

“Connection!” Lonnie cheers from outside the room.

“No!” Shadow Weaver screams, rushing towards Scorpia. “No! What did you do, you useless idiot?”

Scorpia turns to her. She raises her other pincer. A burst of red electricity comes out of it, hitting the sorceress and slamming her against the wall behind her.

“Wow.” Scorpia says, laughing. “Oh, sorry. Boy, that sure has a kick, doesn’t it?”

The ship that set sail from Salineas plows through the sea on its route to the port of Seaworthy. On the bridge, Mendo and Sea Hawk practice their swordplay. Ryunosuke leans against the rail and scans the horizon. Mermista sits beside her.

Suddenly, the sea princess feels a shock pierce her soul. Her body begins to glow. “Aaargh! W-what’s happening to me?” she says.

“Mermista! Dearest!” exclaims Sea Hawk, interrupting the duel and running to her side. “Are you all right?” he asks, putting his hands on her shoulders.

“Y-yes!” she replies. “I’m fine... In fact, I feel stronger, more powerful... Something has resonated with the Pearl and it’s amplifying my magic.”

“What can that mean?” asks Sea Hawk. “Is it a good thing... or a bad thing?”

Mermista pauses for a moment to think. “I don’t know,” she says. “I’m afraid we’re about to find out.”

“Aargh!” Adora screams.

Catra, half asleep in the blonde's arms, wakes up abruptly and starts to panic. "Adora! Adora!" she cries, hugging her tighter. "Help! Something is happening to her," she says, drawing the attention of the others.

"Adora!" Bow exclaims, running to her side. "Are you hurt?"

"N-no," Adora says. "I-I'm fine... It's the power... I suddenly felt a force flowing through me."

"Oh, it's probably the Heart of Etheria activating," Entrapta says.

Everyone turns to her. "W-what did you say?" Bow says.

Entrapta lifts her mask with her hair, her eyes sparkling with excitement. "My theories were correct," she explains. "I knew the First Ones had retrofitted the planet with tech, I just didn't know why. But it all makes sense now! They were mining the planet's magic and using it to power their weapon, the Heart of Etheria!"

"Their... weapon?" Ataru says.

"But of course you know all about the Heart of Etheria already," Entrapta tells Adora, "seeing as you're a part of it."

"Wait, wait. Hang on," Adora says. "What?"

"All the princesses are," Entrapta explains. "The Heart draws its power from the magic of the princesses. It needs all of their runestones to work. And She-Ra is the most important piece, the key! She channels the weapon's power and focuses it, because she is the only being strong enough to withstand the destructive energy of the Heart."

"And why is this happening now, all of a sudden?" Catra asks, worried.

"The planet was not yet balanced," Entrapta answers. "There was an offline runestone. But not anymore. Look!"

Entrapta operates the controls, and an image of Etheria and all its runestones appears on the ship's screen. All are lit and connected to the center of the planet.

"The Black Garnet. Scorpia," Bow says. His voice shakes.

"When the Heart is deployed, She-Ra will raise her sword and fire it!" Entrapta says.

"So She-Ra is the key, like Mara said too," Adora says frantically. "That means I can stop it, right? If She-Ra fires the weapon, then I just won't do it... Please, Entrapta, tell me I can stop it!"

"Once the planet is balanced, no one can stop it," Entrapta replies. "Not even the First Ones could control it. That's why they left. When the weapon is activated, it will channel all its power into you. You don't get to refuse."

Adora begins to pant. Catra hugs her even harder.

"But don't worry," Entrapta says. "After all, Etheria doesn't seem to be fully balanced yet. Look! One of the runestones is only half connected. We might still have a chance."

"How is that possible?" asks Lum. "Which runestone is it?"

"It's the Moonstone. The Bright Moon stone," says Entrapta.

"Of course!" exclaims Adora. "Glimmer doesn't have full access to the Moonstone. She shares it with her mom, Queen Angella. Because of this, her powers are weak and she must constantly recharge them."

"That's right!" says Entrapta. "Until Glimmer has made a full connection to her runestone and has full access to her powers, the Heart of Etheria will not be entirely activated. We have time!"

"And in the meantime..." Adora says, looking at the Sword of Protection that rests beside her. "...to be on the safe side, it would be better not to use She-Ra's power again. At least for a while."

The girl is silent for a moment. Then her expression hardens. “And I can’t wait to have a little chat with Light Hope later,” she adds.

An unconscious Shadow Weaver is tied to a post on the wall of the Black Garnet chamber by Perfuma’s vines. The princesses, the earthlings, and the Horde soldiers watch her and consider what to do.

“She won’t give us any more trouble,” Glimmer says. “She’s completely incapacitated. Now that Scorpia has taken control of her runestone, the witch cannot access the power of the Black Garnet anymore.”

“Wow!” Scorpia exclaims, smiling. “That was terrifying. And fun. It was terrifun-fying!”

“I knew you could do it!” Lonnie tells her.

But Scorpia’s smile suddenly disappears as she looks around. “Um...” she says. “But all these princesses... what are they doing here? Are they invading us again? Shouldn’t we warn Hordak?”

“No, apparently we had a common enemy,” Lonnie says.

“We’re not here to fight you or the Horde,” Glimmer adds. “We just wanted to free our friends.”

“Your... friends?” Scorpia asks.

“Of course!” says Benten. “You didn’t think we’d leave them behind!”

“You...” Scorpia says. “You... all seem really good at friendship. How I wish things worked that way here...”

“Oh,” Perfuma says, her eyes brightening. “You want to learn how to be a good friend?”

“Yes!” Scorpia replies determinedly. “See, I thought I was being a good friend to Catra, but it turns out she wasn’t really interested, and maybe I don’t know what friendship is either. Man, I think Entrapta is the only real friend I’ve ever had. And now she’s on Beast Island...”

“Don’t worry about that,” Frosta says. “Adora and Bow, along with some Earth people, went to rescue her and bring her back!”

“Really?” Scorpia asks in amazement.

“Yes, and Catra is with them, as strange as that may sound,” Glimmer adds. “Double Trouble, a spy who had infiltrated Bright Moon, revealed it to us. I just hope that damn Horde scum has no ill intentions.”

“Catra?” Scorpia says. “Catra is with Adora? And she went to rescue Entrapta?” A broad smile spreads across her face. “I knew that she would regret what she had done. After all, she’s not mean... She’s just misunderstood! The Super Pal Trio can form again. I’ll come with you!”

Perfuma giggles.

“Are you sure, Scorpia?” Lonnie asks.

“Of course!” she answers. “Friendship above all! To hell with Hordak and the Horde. Let’s go to Bright Moon!”

Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio hesitate, unsure of what to do. Kyle also glances at Chibi, who smiles at him.

“Scorpia’s right!” Kyle tells his two friends. “The Fright Zone has been so stressful lately. In fact, let’s face it, it’s a horrible place. Maybe it’s time to leave for good!”

“I don’t know, Kyle...” Lonnie says. “The Horde is our family...”

“Bullshit!” Kyle says. Putting his hands on Lonnie and Rogelio’s shoulders, he adds: “You guys are my family. The only family I ever had. Even Catra and Adora are part of it. Let’s go join them.”

Lonnie thinks for a moment, then nods with a smile. Rogelio smiles, too, and utters a series of verses that no one seems to fully understand.

“Okay,” Lonnie says to Glimmer. “We’ll go with you.”

“Can Emily come, too?” Scorpia asks. The robot comes forward and makes a few beeps.

“Um, sure,” Glimmer says. “But we have a problem, more than one actually. First, we have to rescue the other three earthlings.”

“Yes,” Oyuki says. “Mendo, Shinobu and Ryunosuke are still missing.”

“Oh, two of them were sent with Octavia’s assault troops to fight in Salineas,” Scorpia says. “While the girl... I mean the girl who looks like a girl, not the girl who looks like a boy... she was locked up for insubordination.”

“It must be Shinobu,” Benten says.

“Ugh, another hassle,” Glimmer says. “Okay, we need at least to free her before we go back. And that’s the second problem: without Shadow Weaver to help me, I don’t think my powers can teleport that many people... fifteen, if I’m not mistaken, plus a robot... and certainly not all the way to Bright Moon!”

“Oh boy, for that matter, I can take care of the escape!” Scorpia says. “As the Fright Zone’s resident princess, I have my own airship in the hangar... shaped like a scorpion, no less! Fifteen of us will fit a little tight, but it will still manage to get us out of here!”

“Scorpia, you’re awesome!” says Perfuma.

“Oh, um,” Scorpia says, blushing. “No one ever told me that! Do you... do you really think so?”

“Of course!” laughs Perfuma. “And I’ll be glad to be your friend.”

Scorpia’s smile broadens.

“Let’s not waste any more time!” Glimmer says, getting their attention. “Let’s go free Shinobu and then get out of here!”

Force Captain Grizzlor, just out of his quarters, is walking lazily towards the mess hall when he sees some figures at the end of the corridor running towards him. The one at the head of the group, a petite girl with bobbed hair, is undoubtedly the Earth prisoner recently imprisoned for insubordination. Someone must have let her out of her cell. She is followed by some princesses, no less! How the hell did they break into the Fright Zone?

With a smirk on his face, the burly Force Captain decides to stop them. And he starts running in their direction, ready to use all his strength and body mass to stop their advance. *This will be a piece of cake*, he thinks.

Now that he is close enough, Grizzlor sees the girl stop, clench her fist, and prepare for the impact.

A moment later, he realizes he’s flying through the air. Out of the corner of his eye, just before he hits the ceiling, he sees Shinobu with her fist raised after she threw him up and yelled “MEN BE DAMNED!”

Chapter End Notes

> The title of this chapter is a fusion between the titles of Urusei Yatsura (1981) episode 44, “After You’ve Gone”, and

She-Ra (2018) season 5 episode 10, “Return to the Fright Zone”.

Ties That Bind Forever

Chapter Notes

CW for alcohol consumption and drunkenness.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mara's spaceship slowly descends into the large garden in front of Bright Moon Castle. The engines stop and the ramp lowers. Waiting outside for the travelers are Queen Angella, her sister-in-law Castaspella, and She-Ra's steed, Swift Wind, as well as two of the kingdom's honor guards.

When the ship's hatch opens, Ataru and Lum get out first, the girl smiling and embracing the boy, who instead walks sulkily. Ran and Bow follow, and then Entrapta, flanked by the large robot Betty. At the sight of the princess of Dryl, a smile of relief spreads across the queen's face. Castaspella's, on the other hand, takes on an impenetrable expression.

"How good to be here again!" Entrapta exclaims. "I was sad to leave that island full of technological wonders, but sometimes it's nice to be in a place... not so dangerous." And then, turning to Angella. "Oh, hey... hello!" she adds.

"Welcome back, Princess Entrapta," Angella replies. "I hope you had a safe trip. We've been looking forward to seeing you. We're in desperate need of your... technological skills."

"Yes, hoping that this time they will remain in the service of the Rebellion," Castaspella adds sourly. "And not of the Horde, as has been the case lately."

"I'm only in the service of science!" Entrapta shouts enthusiastically. "But Bow and Adora have already explained everything to me. I'll get to work right away. Thanks to the experiments I was able to conduct on Beast Island and with the

help of She-Ra's Sword of Protection, opening a new portal will be child's play!"

"Let's also hope there are no side effects..." Bow says, standing next to her, a bead of sweat running down his forehead.

"Oh, don't worry," Entrapta says. "The only challenge will be directing the passage towards the correct dimension... if we don't want to return our friends to somewhere other than their homeworld."

"That would be the last straw," Ataru says. "After so much effort, we certainly don't want to end up who knows where, maybe in a place even worse than this!"

"I'll take care of that," Castaspella says. "My magic, combined with the ritual performed by Sakura in the other world, should allow for the proper alignment of the two portals and keep them in sync for as long as necessary."

"Did you say Sakura?" Lum asks in surprise.

"Yes," Castaspella replies. "That's the name of the person I made transdimensional contact with. Do you know her?"

"Of course we do!" Ataru replies, his mouth watering. "She has Tomobiki's biggest..."

"...appetite!" Cherry says, appearing behind him and finishing his sentence. "She's not my niece for nothing!"

Angella, Castaspella, Lum and Ataru jump back, startled by Cherry's sudden appearance.

"That's where the monk went!" says the queen.

"Damn, I was hoping we'd gotten rid of him for good," Castaspella comments.

At that moment, more people begin to emerge from the ship.

“Adora!” Swift Wind shouts, happy to see the girl. Everyone’s eyes turn to her as she comes down the ramp.

But the queen, the unicorn, and Castaspella frown when they see who’s walking beside her: none other than Force Captain Catra, general of the Horde army and Hordak’s second-in-command!

“Catra!” Angella exclaims. “Why is she here?”

“Horde soldier!” the two Bright Moon guards yell, raising their halberds and rushing to protect the queen, positioning themselves between her and the newcomer.

“Stop!” says Adora, standing between Catra and the guards. “It’s all right. Catra... she’s with us now.”

The queen looks suspiciously at Catra and Adora herself, then nods to the guards, who lower their halberds and step aside. “What does that mean, Adora?” she asks.

“Your Majesty...” Adora begins, trying to find the right words. Next to her, Catra makes herself small, her ears lowered and her gaze shy. “Catra... Catra and I are friends again.” The blonde gives the catgirl a tender glance and continues. “She has decided to defect from the Horde. And I vouch for her. As you welcomed me, I ask you to welcome her. I know it’s not that easy, as she has launched numerous attacks against us and even besieged Bright Moon once, but I assure you that she... she’s not evil. I know her well!”

Angella is speechless. She pauses for a moment to think. Then she says: “Adora... what you’re asking me is a lot. Perhaps too much. I honestly don’t know if we can trust her... She’s a Force Captain.”

“I was a Force Captain, too,” Adora says. “And yet you welcomed me here.”

“Your case was different!” Angella protests.

“Yes, I forgot,” Adora says with a stern look. “I was She-Ra. Well, Your Majesty, know this: if you do not accept Catra here in Bright Moon, I will leave with her. I already abandoned her once... and I don’t regret it, mind you. I know I made the right choice back then. But I’ll make another one this time. Once the portal is reopened and the earthlings are sent back to their world, I will destroy She-Ra’s sword and leave with Catra... Away from the Rebellion, away from the Horde, and away from this war!”

Catra’s mismatched eyes widen. “No, Adora!” the catgirl cries, almost in unison with the queen. But Adora’s gaze doesn’t waver, it remains strong and determined.

Before Angella can argue, it’s Bow who speaks. “Your Majesty,” he says. “Don’t make any hasty decisions. Please reflect. And maybe... there’s something, or rather someone, here that you should meet. After that, I’m sure you’ll look at the situation from a completely different perspective.”

Angella’s curious gaze returns to the ship’s ramp, where someone else is disembarking.

“It... it can’t be!” the queen exclaims, recognizing the man as he steps out of the craft.

He, too, as soon as he reaches the ground, freezes as if paralyzed.

“M-M...,” the queen stammers. Tears form at the corners of her eyes.

“M-my brother!” Castaspella exclaims, astonished herself.

“Angie! My love!” the man exclaims. “I can finally see you again!”

“M-Micah!” Angella cries. “Is that really you?”

Bow, Adora, Catra, Ataru and Lum step back, move aside and let the queen run to embrace her husband. The hug lasts a long

time, and is only interrupted for a moment to allow Castaspella to join them. Tears stream down the cheeks of all three adults.

“But how?” Angella sobs. “How is this possible? They told me you were dead! It’s a miracle!”

“I was not dead!” Micah says, moved. “The Horde captured me. And they banished me to Beast Island! They hoped I’d die there, but somehow, I survived. And now I’m here!”

“Now you’re here!” Angella repeats. And without hesitation, she turns the hug into a passionate kiss. Micah returns the kiss, while Castaspella takes a step back in embarrassment.

“My love!” Micah says. “Yes, I’m here. And I promise you, I’ll never go away again. I will stay by your side for the rest of my life!”

“Oh, Micah!” Angella says. “I can’t believe it! I still can’t believe it!”

“You have them to thank,” Micah says, nodding at Adora and her friends.

Angella looks up at the group. “Thank you!” the queen says, crying. “Thank you, Bow! Thank you, Adora! And you, Lum and Ataru! And...” The queen hesitates for a moment, then she continues: “...thank you, Catra, you too.”

Catra lowers her eyes again, sheepishly. In a whisper, inaudible to all but Adora, she says: “I don’t deserve stupid thanks... I didn’t do anything.”

Adora runs her hand over her head, through her wild hair, and whispers in her ear, smiling: “For once someone thanks you, take it and shut up!”

Even Castaspella smiles at the catgirl and says: “Welcome to Bright Moon, I guess! I’ll knit you a sweater. What size are you in the shoulders?”

“Um,” says Catra, unsure how to answer. And turning to Adora, she asks in a low voice, “Who is she? Another princess? I’ve never seen her on the battlefield...”

“It’s Castaspella, Glimmer’s aunt,” Adora answers.

“Aunt? What the hell is an aunt?” asks Catra.

“I’ll explain it to you later... I had no idea either, at first.”

After a few more seconds, Micah asks Angella: “What about our Glimmer? Where is my little girl? I want to see her!”

Trying to hold back the tears that are still flowing, Angella answers: “She will be here soon. She and the other princesses are coming back from their mission in the Fright Zone. They should arrive any minute!”

“Did everything go well?” Bow asks. “Did they rescue the other earthlings?”

“We just received a radio message,” Castaspella says. “They are returning here in a Horde ship... They have five earthlings on board, as well as four more Horde soldiers who decided to defect.”

“Four soldiers?” Adora asks curiously. Catra beside her fidgets uncomfortably. “Who can they be?”

“We don’t know,” Castaspella says. “But I think we’ll find out soon.”

“Wait a moment!” Lum says, still at Ataru’s side. “Did you say five earthlings? But that leaves two missing...”

“No,” Angella answers, wiping away her last tears but not letting go of Micah’s embrace. “Just before you came, Princess Mermista and her companion arrived from Salineas, bringing with them two earthlings who were forced to join the Horde army. So everyone should be there.”

“Great!” Bow exclaims. “As soon as Glimmer gets here, we can start opening the portal! Entrapta?” he says, addressing the purple-haired princess.

“It will take some time,” Entrapta replies. “At least a day’s work. Assuming, of course, that everything goes well and nothing explodes, which is not so unlikely when it comes to scientific experiments on space-time...”

“Why does that sentence make my hair stand on end?” asks Swift Wind.

When Scorpia’s ship also lands at Bright Moon a little later, there are many more hugs.

“Mendo!” Shinobu exclaims running to the sword-wielding boy. “I’m so happy to see you! I was afraid something would happen to you in the war!”

“Miss Shinobu!” Mendo exclaims and hugs her. “You needn’t have worried about me! A descendant of the samurai always knows how to cope with any situation!”

“Hello, Lum!” Benten and Oyuki greet as they disembark from the ship. “Hi, Ran! Nice to have you back with us.”

“Hi, girls!”, Lum says. “Finally together again!”

“Lum-chan!” Ten shouts, also getting out of the ship and flying towards his cousin. “I was so scared!”

“Come on, Ten-chan,” Lum says and hugs the little kid. “You’re safe now!”

“Jariten scared?” Ataru says annoyed. “Any excuse is good to get the attention of others!”

“Shut up, you idiot!” Ten says, unleashing a flame on Ataru, who dodges it by bending his body backwards with unexpected agility. The flame hits Cherry instead.

“Oh, Bow!” Glimmer calls, running toward the boy. He hugs her back, a strange smile on his face. “Why are you smiling?” the princess asks him.

“I have a big surprise for you, Glim,” Bow says. Stepping aside, he reveals Micah behind him.

Glimmer is astonished. Though she was very young the last time she saw him, she recognizes the man from the many portraits that adorn the walls of the royal palace. “Da...” she stutters. “Da... da...”

Embarrassed, Micah steps forward and holds out his hand. “I... you... hello. I’m your dad!”

“Oh, dad!” Glimmer exclaims. The two embrace each other and remain so for a long time.

Adora and Catra watch them, smiles on their faces. But the catgirl’s smile fades, giving way to a very uncertain expression as Scorpia gets off the ship, followed by Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio.

Adora puts a hand on her shoulder and gives her an encouraging look. Catra comes forward, reassured.

“Uh, hi, Scorpia,” the feline says.

“Wildcat!” Scorpia exclaims, smiling broadly and running toward her. “They told me you were here!” And she is about to hug her when her gaze shifts to Adora, standing next to Catra and holding her hands, and she frowns. “Oh, um... Adora... Yeah, I get it.”

“Scorpia...”, Catra says, letting go of Adora’s hand and stepping forward. “I’m happy to see you. You did the right thing by leaving the Horde. It wasn’t the place for you.”

And before she can reply, Catra wraps her in a tender but strong embrace. “I’m sorry for being a bad friend,” she tells her.

“Wow,” Scorpia says after the two split. “You’ve really changed, Wildcat. So... it doesn’t have to be ten feet anymore?”

“No, dummy,” Catra says. And then she adds: “You know... for a long time, I was obsessed with wanting to win... to get revenge on Adora, on Shadow Weaver, on everyone... to prove myself. But blinded by that desire, I always chose the wrong priorities. I didn’t listen to Adora or Entrapta, I opened the portal... And I treated you badly. Now is the time to right my wrongs. I want to prove that I can be better... that I’m worthy of Adora’s love... and your friendship.”

Scorpia hugs her again, impulsively. And she says: “You’re a good friend now.”

Catra purrs.

“Hi, Scorpia!” Entrapta exclaims, stepping forward and waving her hair in the shape of a hand. “I’m here too!”

“Entrapta!” Scorpia says. “How wonderful to see you again!” And she hugs her, too. “I always knew that Catra didn’t really want to leave you on Beast Island. The Super Pal Trio is finally reunited!”

“Super Pal Trio?” Adora says with a grin on her face, glancing at Catra.

“That’s not our name!” says Catra, flustered.

“But it is!” says Entrapta. “It was Scorpia’s idea. Should be considered the semi-official nickname of our group.”

Hearing this exchange, Bow intervenes from a few feet away: “I can’t believe it! Even in the Horde you value friendship! We are definitely going to have a sleepover sometime... Best Friend Squad and Super Pal Trio together!”

Catra groans. But then she joins the general laughter.

“Entrapta,” Scorpia says then. “We also brought...”

“Emily!” cries Entrapta, hugging the small round robot that rushes towards her. “I missed you so much!”

The robot chirps and makes noises.

“I have to introduce you to Betty!” the pigtailed girl tells her. “She’s like your big sister!”

Meanwhile, Adora takes a step closer to Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle. “Guys...” she says. “I’m glad to see you here. I also want to apologize for abandoning you. After all, we were friends...”

“Yes, Adora, we were,” Lonnie says. “And I hope we can learn to be again.”

The four embrace. Catra looks at them with a serene smile on her face.

“Lum! Our beloved goddess!” Megane and the other Stormtroopers suddenly shout, running towards the horned alien.

“Hello, boys! Are you okay?” Lum says.

“Ugh, those rascals again!” Ataru mumbles. Mendo, Shinobu and Ryunosuke approach the group as well.

“Shinobu!” Lum exclaims. “And you guys! Do you know that darling has finally admitted that he loves me? I’m so happy!”

“W-what?” the other earthlings exclaim in astonishment.

“I can’t believe it!” Shinobu says. “Ataru, you said it at last?”

“Moroboshi! How dare you?” yells Mendo, drawing his sword and attacking Ataru, who locks the blade between his two hands.

“Ataru!” the four Stormtroopers shout. “Don’t mess with our Lum! Damn you!”

“You’re all boring me!” Ataru complains and stands up, blushing slightly but trying to compose himself, putting his hands in his pockets. “When will you learn to mind your own business?”

“His tragic fate can no longer be escaped,” Cherry comments.

And just then, a rumble shakes the entire building. The surroundings seem to vibrate. For a second, the light disappears, then returns.

“Another flash! Reality shook again!” says Adora.

“It was even worse than the previous ones!” says Bow. “And really frightening!”

“Lum-chan, I’m scared!” cries Ten, flying back into the girl’s arms.

Angella’s voice rises above the others: “Let’s have a meeting, immediately. Everyone go to the council chamber,” she says.

Sitting in the war room, Glimmer is beside herself with happiness. For the first time in ages, both of her parents’ chairs in the council chamber are occupied, and she is overjoyed.

Angella and Micah, sitting side by side, hold hands and look at each other tenderly. Then, as soon as everyone has entered the room, the queen stands up and speaks.

“I know you’re all happy because our missions have been successful,” she begins. “In fact, they went even better than expected, as we not only recovered our friends, but also welcomed some of our former enemies,” she says, nodding to Catra, Scorpia, and the other Horde soldiers. Catra can’t help but notice that not everyone in the room seems to be happy about her presence: the other princesses, especially Mermista, Frosta, and Netossa, glance at her suspiciously.

“However,” Angella continues, “the vibration of reality we just felt reminds us that we can’t celebrate yet. We must hurry to open a new portal and send our friends back to their world. Princess Entrapta, you have the floor.”

As Angella sits down, Entrapta, perched atop the robot Emily, begins to speak. “Oh yes, well...” she says. “As I explained earlier, building a device capable of opening a dimensional portal, even with She-Ra’s sword at hand and counting on the help of the pink Horde princess, here,” she nods at Ran, who smiles, “will take at least twenty-four hours. Hopefully the dimensional anomalies won’t get any worse in the meantime and the distortion of reality won’t tear the space-time fabric completely.”

“Then begin your work,” Castaspella says. “We have set up a laboratory for you in one of the castle halls. In the meantime, I’ll contact Sakura again and make sure they’re ready to open the portal from their side as well.”

“Very good,” says Angella. “If there’s nothing else, let’s adjourn the meeting.”

“And what are we going to do in the meantime?” Ataru says. “Should we just sit here and twiddle our thumbs?”

“Of course not!” Glimmer says. “Since this is probably the last day you Earth people will spend here on Etheria... we’re going to have a big party. With lots and lots of food!”

“Great idea, Glim!” says Bow. “It will be, um, an extended Best Friend Squad party! Very extended!”

“I agree. You deserve to relax and have some fun,” says Angella. “I’ll notify the royal kitchens to prepare something...”

“No, mom!” Glimmer interrupts. “This is a special occasion! We deserve to celebrate in a special way. And our Horde friends may never have eaten real food in their lives... I want to cook myself!”

“You?” Bow says in disbelief. “I’ve never seen you cook before.”

Glimmer giggles in embarrassment. Then she adds: “You know what? Maybe someone can help me...”

“Me! Me!” says Lum. “I love to prepare food for my friends!”

Ataru frowns. “Lum,” he says, “maybe that’s not the best idea...”

“I’ll help you too, daughter!” says Micah. “We will get many beautiful bugs for everyone!”

“Um... dad,” Glimmer mutters, “I appreciate the thought, but... don’t bother. I don’t know if others would like it...”

“I want to help too!” Shinobu says. “I love cooking!”

“Then it’s settled!” says Glimmer. “We’ll make a delicious lunch... And we’ll all eat together! I promise it will be great!”

“Hooray!” says Swift Wind. “I can’t wait!”

“Adventure!” says Sea Hawk.

“Food is good for the spirit,” says Cherry, watering at the mouth. “I just hope there is plenty of it. My spirit is VERY hungry...”

Everyone gets up out of their chairs and begins to leave the council chamber. Glimmer, followed by Lum and Shinobu, heads

for the kitchens, while the earthlings, the aliens and the other princesses move to the large hearth hall nearby. Catra doesn't get up, though: she grabs Adora's arm and holds her back.

"Hey, Adora," she says.

"Catra," Adora replies. "What's up?"

As soon as they are alone in the war room, Catra closes the big door and pushes Adora against the wall.

"I don't want to go with the others. Sparkles and the other princesses obviously don't like me being here. Let's stay here for a moment."

Adora knows that she should say something like "That's not true, you're more than welcome, you'll see that as soon as they get to know you better, they'll love you," but she suddenly finds herself unable to open her mouth. The closeness of Catra, the fact that their bodies are pressed together, and that she can dive into her mismatched eyes, distinguish every beautiful freckle on her face, and even feel her breathing, makes her blush tremendously. "Catra... What are you doing?"

"I have a few things in mind...", the catgirl says with a teasing smirk. She is suddenly very touchy, and her husky voice sends shivers down Adora's spine.

"But we can't stay here," Adora says. "They'll find us..."

"I don't care. I want you all for myself!" And she starts pecking kisses on her neck. Adora is unable to react and lets her do it. Catra's hands dive into her hair, unraveling the ponytail. And as she continues to kiss her, Adora can feel her own breathing getting harder and harder.

But suddenly the door slams open and Swift Wind enters at a gallop. "Adora!" he yells. "Are you in danger? I sensed a strong emotion through our empathic bond!"

Adora and Catra instantly freeze. The unicorn stares at them, eyes wide. Queen Angella rushes up behind him, followed by Netossa and Spinnerella.

“Uh... am I interrupting something?” Swift Wind asks.

“N-no...” Adora says. “We were just...”

“...we were saying that we would also like to help Glimmer in the kitchen!” says Catra, blushing slightly.

“Ah, yes!” says Adora. “Totally! We want to help her!”

Netossa and Spinnerella giggle. Angella, perplexed, says, “Well, if that’s the case... go ahead, girls.”

Holding hands, Adora and Catra leave the room and head hesitantly for the palace kitchens.

“Can you even cook?” Adora whispers to Catra as they walk side by side.

“It can’t be that hard,” Catra answers, still in a low voice. “If Sparkles can manage it...”

When they enter the kitchen, they see Glimmer reading a large cookbook, a bead of sweat rolling down her forehead. Lum and Shinobu are at the stove instead, fiddling with a large pot. Shinobu holds a ladle, Lum a container with a red liquid.

“I told you, you can’t add that much Tabasco, Lum!” Shinobu yells, trying to keep the alien still.

“But it will be tastier this way!” says Lum. “If food isn’t spicy, it’s no good!”

Catra and Adora look puzzled.

Lifting her head from the cookbook, Glimmer exclaims “Ah, there it is! I found it. We need to...” Her sentence stops when she sees

Catra at the door. “Catra!” she says.

“Hey, Sparkles,” Catra replies, smirking.

“Get out of my kitchen, Horde scum!” shouts Glimmer. “My mom may have welcomed you into this castle, but I don’t want you anywhere near me!”

“I can’t ask for anything better,” Catra says, turning and starting to leave. But this time it is Adora who grabs her arm and stops her.

“No, Catra, stay,” she says. And then, addressing the princess: “Glimmer, listen to me. I know Catra was our enemy and she’s done a lot of bad things and hurt a lot of people, but...”

“Stop, Adora,” Catra cuts her off. “I don’t need you to apologize on my behalf.” And then, after a few endless seconds, she lowers her ears and adds: “I have to do it myself. On my own.”

Adora and Glimmer look at her in astonishment. Catra approaches the princess and says in a low voice. “I’m sorry, Sparkles. I know I’ve been a real bitch. I have hurt you, your kingdom and your people. I don’t deserve forgiveness, but please... let me stay close to Adora. Without her, I have no reason to live. I will do anything to undo the damage I have wrought.”

There is a deep silence in the room. Adora looks at Catra stunned. Glimmer’s expression is indecipherable. The catgirl gazes down.

And then, after a few very long minutes, Glimmer says: “Take this book, Horde scum. And help me with this recipe.”

A broad smile spreads across Adora’s face.

About twenty people are crowded in the large hearth room, sitting on sofas or cushions directly on the floor, divided into small groups and intent on chatting, laughing, bonding, waiting for the promised food to arrive from the kitchen. Meanwhile, glasses and bottles of all kinds of drinks keep them company. There is even some Elberon wine that Glimmer has ordered to be brought into the room without asking her mother's permission.

"...and then I bravely faced the terrible serpent of the sea, using the last means at my disposal," says Sea Hawk with great emphasis. "I set fire to my own ship and hurled it in flames at the hideous monster! This bold act earned me the acclaim of the entire village, whose fishermen have since been able to sail these waters without fear!"

"Wow, Inspector Pirate!" Scorpia exclaims. "Very impressive!"

"Please, call me Sea Hawk," he replies. "Last time, in the Northern Reach, we didn't have time to properly introduce ourselves. Nice to see you again."

"Oh boy, cool name. Gosh, yes. Um... I'm Scorpia. The pleasure is mine, really!" says the former Force Captain.

"A ship on fire?" Ten exclaims, his eyes shining. "How I would have loved to witness such a scene... Fire is my passion!"

"Really, my little friend?" says Sea Hawk with enthusiasm. "You should know that this was not the only time I won the love of great crowds by setting fire to my ships." Beside him, Mermista rolls her eyes. "Do you really love fire?" asks the sea captain again.

"Sure!" Ten replies. "I'm an inveterate arsonist! Unfortunately, my mom doesn't condone this passion of mine... You see, she's a space firefighter, and if she catches me setting something on fire, I'm in trouble! But she's almost always away, so I rarely see her... That is why I mostly live with Lum-chan..."

“Oh, poor little one...”, Perfuma says, sitting next to Mermista. “Come, let me pet you.”

Ten wastes no time and, moving extremely slowly, flies to Perfuma’s chest, who hugs and cuddles him.

“How cute, this baby!” says Perfuma.

“Hey child, come to me too!” Spinnerella says. Again, Ten goes to be petted and pampered.

Ataru stares at him. “Look at that brat! How can he always be so successful with girls? Hey, ladies! I’m here, pet me too!”

Suddenly, an electric shock hits him.

“What are you trying to do, darling? I remind you that you said you love me!” Lum shouts. Ataru turns around to see the green-haired alien enter the room, followed by Shinobu, Glimmer, Adora and Catra, all carrying large trays of snacks and food.

“Ugh, you’re not going to forget that, are you?” Ataru says.

“Of course not!” Lum answers smiling. “Now we will be together forever!”

“Hurray! Food is coming!” shouts Swift Wind.

“It looks delicious. What is it?” Perm asks.

“What does it matter?” Kakugari replies. “Let’s enjoy it!”

The trays are placed in the middle of the room and everyone begins to stuff themselves. There are lots of steamed buns, rice and meat rolls, savory pies, taiyaki, cupcakes, and even vegetable platters like potato cookies, carrot sticks, and Alwyn’s famous pickled fruits.

“W-what is that food?” Kyle asks fearfully. “Look at the strange shapes and colors. These are not gray rations... and not brown

either! What are they trying to poison us with?”

“Don’t be silly, Kyle,” Lonnie replies. “It may be princess food, but I don’t think it’s poisonous. After all, Adora’s been eating it for a long time, and she’s not dead!”

“No, but she’s become a princess,” Kyle replies whimpering. “I don’t want to be a princess!”

Rogelio, next to him, runs a paw over his face.

“Hey, man,” Chibi tells him. “Take it easy. I’m sure it’s very good!”

“Everyone eat, eat!” says Glimmer, passing trays and platters filled with delicious food to everyone present and chuckling. “I hope you enjoy these recipes. Lum, Shinobu, Adora, and Catra helped.”

Amidst laughter and chatter, everyone begins to eat slowly. All except Cherry, Swift Wind, Ataru, and Adora, who instead dive into their food with mad voracity, devouring everything at superhuman speed. Some of the princesses look at them in bewilderment.

“Ugh, my darling is a glutton as usual!” Lum snorts. “Fortunately, we prepared enough food to feed an army.”

“He seems to have found someone to stand up to him,” Shinobu laughs, pointing at Adora. “Even on this planet, there are some big eaters.”

“Hey, Lum,” Benten says. “Shouldn’t we save some for Ran? She stayed in the lab to help Entrapta build the portal machine. She’ll be hungry for sure, and if she doesn’t find anything left, she’ll be mad at us as usual.”

“Don’t worry, Benten,” Lum replies. “We have already thought of that. Two Bright Moon guards brought them some food as well.

Strangely enough, that tech princess insisted on eating only tiny meals. Who knows why...”

“Oh, Entrapta is like that,” Scorpia says. Then she takes a plate from the table and pauses to look at the strange food. “Um... what is that? Why is it green?”

“It’s green because it’s a vegetable, silly,” Perfuma tells her with a sweet smile. “Don’t they have those in the Horde? Oh. Well, okay, you should definitely be eating them.”

Scorpia smells the food and tries to taste a small piece. But she spits it out immediately. “Phew! What kind of stuff is that?”

Perfuma looks disappointed.

“I like it,” Shinobu says. Perfuma regains her smile.

“Hey, Scorpia! Try this instead,” Catra says, walking over to her and handing her another plate. This one also contains strange-looking food, not bar-shaped at all, but at least it’s not green. And is smells delicious!

“Oh, uh, Wildcat! Thank you!” Scorpia says, grabbing the plate with her pincers. “What are those?”

“Adora says they’re called savory brioches,” Catra says. And then, lowering her head and blushing, “I... I helped prepare them.”

Scorpia tastes one, hesitating. Her eyes and whole face light up. And she immediately swallows two more. “Wow, Wildcat! They’re very good!”

Catra smiles and puts her hand behind her neck.

Perfuma, who had been watching their whole exchange, turns to them and comments: “I’m so glad you’re repairing your old relationships! It can really be a solid foundation for building new ones.”

Scorpia glances at Perfuma and smiles. Catra looks at her as well, but her expression becomes somber. “I don’t know if I... If I can do it”, she says.

“And why do you say that?” Perfuma asks her. “It seems like you’re doing great!”

“I’m not welcome here,” the catgirl says. “Nobody wants me.”

“Nonsense! Adora wants you, of course. And Glimmer let you cook with her. If they didn’t want you here, you wouldn’t be here now, believe me!”

“But I’m one of the bad guys!” says Catra. “I have done terrible things. I have attacked your kingdoms. It’s not possible for you to pretend that nothing happened...”

“Pretend that nothing happened, no,” says Perfuma. “But forgiveness is always possible. I’m convinced that no one is beyond redemption. It doesn’t matter what you’ve done. Now you’re on the right path.”

Catra pauses to think. Then she says: “Shadow Weaver once told me that I reminded her of herself. If that’s true, how can I be a better person? How can I be... not mean?”

“The very fact that you’re asking yourself that question proves that you are nothing like her,” Perfuma replies. “Shadow Weaver was lying, or maybe it was just a way to justify herself, to absolve herself. You are not like her, believe me. You’re different. And I think you’re better!”

“A-are you sure?”

“You’re trying, Catra. You try to be a good person. She never even thought of trying.”

Catra remains silent. Her hands are shaking. Just then, little Ten, who had been petted (and fed) by the other princesses one after

the other, flies towards her. Instinctively, Catra grabs him and hugs him to her chest.

“Wow!” says Ten. “You’re the softest of all!”

Catra is speechless. Ten is so cute, he looks just like a baby child. She never thought to have maternal instincts, but without thinking she begins to pet his hair.

“A catgirl is cuddling me!” Ten gloats. “When I get home and tell Torajima, he’ll be really jealous! You know, he’s the fiercest alley cat of the neighborhood, a tough guy, but he has a thing for cute catgirls.”

The fact that Catra is holding Ten in her arms, close to her chest, and caressing him, is not lost on the other guests. Looking at her, Adora feels tenderness. And Bow gets heart eyes.

“How... how cute!” the archer cries.

“I’m not... *cute*!”, Catra replies and suddenly leaves Ten, who flutters away a little disappointed.

“You are! You are!”, Ataru adds. “And you’re very pretty, too!”

“I’m not pretty!” Catra shouts. Her tail bristles, she stomps and throws her fists down in annoyance.

“And the angrier you get, the cuter you are!” says Bow.

“That’s enough!” laughs Adora, standing at Catra’s side and isolating her from the others. “Leave my girlfriend alone. She’s overwhelmed by all these changes.”

“G-girlfriend?”, Catra says, suddenly blushing.

Adora blushes, too, and looks at her with an uncertain gaze. “D-don’t you want it?”

Catra hesitates, then holds on to Adora. Tears form at the corners of her eyes. “Y-yes. I want it. Girlfriends! Let’s make it official!” she says, smiling.

“How cute!” says Bow again.

“Hey, Arrow Boy! Now get it over with!” exclaims Catra, turning to him. “You, of all people, have no right to mock me. When will you and Sparkles decide to follow our example?”

Now it’s Bow’s turn to be speechless. He looks down and walks away. Adora and Catra laugh.

With a plate in hand, Lonnie sits down next to Shinobu and says to her: “You know, I was very impressed with how you made Force Captain Grizzlor fly away in the Fright Zone. You look so petite... where do you hide all that strength?”

Shinobu blushes. “I... I don’t know,” she says. “I guess... it comes out when I get angry. I’m usually just a normal girl...”

“Not really normal,” Lonnie laughs. “If only I had your strength! And why were you yelling ‘Men be damned’?”

“Oh, that,” Shinobu replies. “It’s just that that beast man reminded me of a bully I know on Earth. He’s the leader of a gang from Butsumetsu High School, our rival school. He seems to be in love with me, and he’s always after me, but he’s really ugly and horrible, barely human, and I don’t know how to get rid of him. Every time he comes up to me, I have to hit him to send him away. How unlucky I am with men!”

“Unlucky? You?” Lonnie says. “But you’re so pretty!”

“Just think, I used to be Ataru’s girlfriend,” Shinobu says, gesturing to the boy who is still busy clearing away plates of food. “But then Lum came along and... maybe it was for the best. He was completely unreliable. Now there’s Mendo... He’s handsome

and he’s rich, but deep down I feel that he’s not the right person for me either. Who knows if I’ll ever find true love.”

“Don’t worry,” Lonnie tells her. “We all have a soulmate somewhere. And I’m convinced that sooner or later, when you least expect it, they will pop up like a rabbit out of a hat. Maybe even more than one!”

“More than one?” Shinobu says. “But that’s not possible.”

“Why not?” Lonnie tells her, laughing. “Why should the universe put stupid limits on us? As long as there is consensus and agreement... The key is to understand what the right choice is to be happy.”

“How’s your party going, guys?” Queen Angella asks, suddenly entering the room.

“Oh, mom, hello! Very... very well,” Glimmer replies.

“I see you’re enjoying yourself. I’m glad,” Angella says. Her eyes scan the room. Then she walks over to the liquor table and pours herself a glass of wine.

Glimmer’s expression changes. She scowls at Angella, walks up to her and says. “Okay, what’s up?”

“Uh, Glimmer?” she replies. “What do you mean?”

“Don’t pretend. You’re not my mom. Isn’t that right... Double Trouble?”

Angella smirks and turns back into their reptilian form. Many of those present gasp astonished. “Remarkable, princess,” they say. “How did you notice?”

Glimmer snorts. “First of all, my mom doesn’t drink. Second, she would’ve scolded me for serving wine to underage guests. What did you think you were doing?”

“Relax, honey. I just wanted to join your party. And have some fun.”

“And this is how you have fun?” Glimmer says.

“You have no idea,” the shapeshifter replies. “Actually, I stopped by the lab earlier where the tech princess is working on building her machine. You know, I was looking forward to meeting this Entrapta character. But I felt kind of... frustrated,” they add, looking down.

“Huh? What do you mean?”

“I tried to tease her in various ways, but she took each of my sentences literally and didn’t catch any of my trigger attempts. After a while I gave up. And when I transformed in front of her, she seemed fascinated by my ability and demanded to study it thoroughly... with a scalpel in her hand. It was enough for me to leave quickly. I preferred to come here.”

Glimmer laughs. “Yes. Entrapta... she’s like that.”

From the opposite corner of the room, two voices stand out from the others, engaged in a heated discussion.

“...and that is why we should free all horses from stables all over the world,” Swift Wind says between snacks. “In fact, in this world and all others! And there should be free hay and apples for everyone! Enough of this capitalist oppression. Resources should not remain concentrated in the hands of a few while others struggle to survive!”

“Rubbish!” Mendo shouts. “Unproductive elements of society like Moroboshi have no right to enjoy the same privileges as those who have worked hard to earn them. A family like mine has prospered for countless generations because of this. Our wealth and success do not come by accident!”

“But that just perpetuates a cycle of inequality!” replies Swift Wind. “Opportunities should be the same for everyone from the beginning!”

“Opportunities should be given to those who deserve them!” replies Mendo. “Not to those who would only squander their wealth without building anything good!”

Some of the princesses watch the debate in boredom. Mermista whispers to Netossa, who is sitting next to her: “That boy, Mendo, is very handsome, don’t you think?”

“Bah!” Netossa replies. “You know very well that I fish in other waters! If we really must talk about these earthlings, I find that one over there much more attractive,” she points at Ryunosuke.

The aforementioned Ryunosuke notices that they are talking about her, so she gets up and comes to sit in front of the group. “Hey, hi,” she says.

“Hi!” Netossa replies, smiling at her. Spinnerella, next to her, does the same. Mermista limits herself to a raised eyebrow.

“Um, I wanted to ask you something,” Ryu says shyly.

“Of course,” Netossa says. “Speak up.”

“I’ve been watching you all and...” Ryunosuke hesitates for a moment, then continues. “I always thought that a girl, and especially a princess, should be feminine, delicate, graceful... And I don’t want to say that you’re not, but... I’ve noticed that you’re also tough... You’re strong, you know how to fight and you know how to stand up for yourself. You don’t need men to protect you! I’m puzzled... I thought I wasn’t capable of acting like a girl, but when I look at you, I have doubts...”

“Oh, poor thing!” says Spinnerella. “You’re a bit confused!”

“You bet,” Ryu admits.

“A girl can be sensitive and delicate,” Netossa says, casting an affectionate glance at her wife. “But she can also be strong and independent. You don’t have to be conditioned by prejudices or the requirements of society. Be yourself and you’ll be happy!”

Ryunosuke thinks for a moment. “Maybe you’re right.”

“Of course!” says Spinnerella. And she gives Netossa a kiss and says: “My darling knows a lot!”

Ryunosuke watches them kissing in amazement. “Wow, that is new too,” she says. “Girls can really be amazing!”

Suddenly, a loud commotion is heard from across the room.

“Damn it! Who gave her an umeboshi?” Ataru shouts.

“What is an umeboshi?” asks Glimmer.

“A pickled plum,” Ataru answers. “For Lum’s race, it’s worse than alcohol! She only has to eat one to get completely drunk!”

Indeed, the alien girl is fluttering in the air, belly up, sending small electric shocks all around her. Her eyes are half closed and her face is red and flushed. “D-darling,” the girl says. “W-wheeere are we?”

“Oh, man, she’s really plastered!” Bow says.

“She’s dangerous in that state!” Ataru says. “Be careful!”

“And I’m afraid she’s not the only one...” Glimmer says, pointing at Adora.

The blonde girl sitting next to Catra empties what must be her fifth glass of wine. The catgirl looks at her worriedly. “A-Adora...”, she says. “What’s wrong with you?”

Adora blinks owlishly, as if trying to recognize Catra, before a lazy grin spreads across her face. “Hey, Catra!” she tells her. “There’s two of you. That’s nice. Bwahaha!” She laughs, then snorts.

“A-Adora?” says Catra.

“I don’t know if you know this, but I love you,” Adora says. “But, shhh! Don’t tell anyone... It’s a secret!”

Catra feels her own face warming.

“Darling!” Lum yells and then starts to cry, sending an electric shock to Ataru. “You cheated on me!”

“N-no! L-Lum, stop!” Ataru says, startled by the zap. “I didn’t cheat this time...”

“You said you looove me,” Lum says, still crying and throwing electric shocks. “But it’s not true!”

“Yes, I love you… Aaaaghh!” Ataru tries to say, but another discharge hits him.

“I LOVE CATRA, TOO!” Adora shouts at the top of her lungs. “But, shhh! It’s a secret!”

Catra becomes increasingly embarrassed.

“How nice!” says Lum, regaining her smile. “Then we all love each other!”

“YESSSSS!” says Adora, clapping her hands. “That’s good! Bwahaha!”

Glimmer runs her hand over her face. “What a disaster, these two. It’s better if they don’t touch alcohol again. They obviously can’t handle it. Get the bottles out!”

“Too late,” Bow says. “And in Lum’s case, it wasn’t even alcohol...”

Everyone laughs.

Just then, General Juliet enters the room. She scans the crowd for Glimmer, and as soon as she spots her, she approaches. “Princess! Emergency!”

“What is it, general?” asks Glimmer.

“The Horde is attacking Bright Moon. It’s a full-scale assault!”

“WHAT?”

“The troops are being led by Hordak himself,” says Juliet. “They’re coming from the Whispering Woods. And that’s not all... Along with them is a giant robot, at least thirty feet tall!”

“Ugh,” Catra says. “Ran’s Oni Killer model whatever! I totally forgot about it!”

Chapter End Notes

> The title of this chapter is a fusion between the titles of She-Ra (2018) season 2 episode 2, “Ties That Bind”, and Urusei Yatsura’s fourth movie, “Lum the Forever” (1986).

A Beautiful Dreamer's Destiny

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Your Majesty, the situation is grave," says General Juliet. Queen Angella, the princesses, and the other members of the Rebellion, all gathered in the war room, listen with trepidation. "Horde soldiers surround Bright Moon from all sides. There are tanks, assault bots, and other machines. And then there's this... giant robot with female features. Pretty creepy, if I dare say so."

"How did they get past the Whispering Woods? The trees were supposed to shield us," Angella asks.

"Oh, it's all down to the Oni Killer model A," Ran giggles. She and Entrapta, who were in the lab building the machine to open the portal, have also been summoned to the council chamber. "Thanks to the power provided by the Virtual Energy Recovery system, she can cut her way through even the most tangled forest. She's also equipped with a three-dimensional scanner to determine the shortest and safest route from the Fright Zone to Bright Moon. It's she who has led the troops here, avoiding obstacles and dangers."

"And when were you going to tell us about this robot?" Glimmer barks, addressing Ran and Catra.

"Uh... among so many things, it slipped our mind," Ran says.

"Ran!", Benten scolds. "As always, you cause trouble."

"Me? Look who's talking," Ran replies. "When we were in school, it was you and Lum who caused trouble, if I remember correctly. And this time it's not my fault either... It's Lum's fault, as usual!"

"What does Lum have to do with this now?"

“If she hadn’t bullied me as a child, I wouldn’t hold a grudge against her,” the pink-haired girl replies. “And I wouldn’t have let Catra convince me to build this robot to get back at her.”

Catra’s ears droop.

“Stop putting all the blame on others!” Benten tells Ran. “Learn to take responsibility!”

“Don’t fight,” Angella says. “The Horde will attack at any moment. What is the status of the portal, Princess Entrapta?”

“It’s complete now,” the pigtailed girl replies. “Powered by the sword of the First Ones, it should open as intended. But for some reason I still don’t understand, it can’t hold itself stable. Something is missing... Perhaps we should wait until they’re ready to open theirs from the other dimension as well: last time it hepled to prevent instability. This is critical if we don’t want to cause a catastrophe for the space-time fabric.”

“Very good. In the meantime...” Angella says.

Just then there is a great rumbling. The walls of the room begin to shake.

“Hordak and his soldiers have struck the first blow!” shouts Bow.

“We have to stop them,” says Glimmer. “This is not just about defending Bright Moon. If they destroy the castle before we have a chance to open the portal, it will be the end of all of reality!”

“And we don’t even have She-Ra. Adora is still drunk, not to mention that she couldn’t use the sword anyway because Entrapta needs it...” says Perfuma.

“Lum is also out of commission, at least for a few hours,” Ataru says. “And to think, her electric shocks could have been useful for once.”

“Then we have to take care of it,” Mermista says. “It’s time to show what the Princess Alliance is capable of.”

“Adventure!” shouts Sea Hawk. “Let’s defend Bright Moon!”

“Can we join in?” asks Benten.

“Of course. The more the merrier!” Glimmer replies with a smile.

The energy flows into the cannon mounted on Hordak’s arm, recharging it. Perched on a cliff overlooking the battlefield, the Horde Lord smiles as he prepares to strike another blow at the pillar that holds the great runestone of Bright Moon. All the while, he watches with satisfaction as his tanks fire at the castle walls.

“Advance! Don’t give the enemy a break!” he orders.

On the plain below, assault bots and foot troops, commanded by the Force Captains, move forward. Flashes of green energy are fired at multiple targets. Cracks begin to appear in the walls. Crowds of civilians flee across the fields, taking advantage of the few remaining escape routes. The Horde soldiers ignore them, intent on attacking the castle’s defenses.

Suddenly, the water in the lake outside the walls begins to stir. A huge wave rises, splashing over some of the tanks, drowning them and sweeping them away.

“You will not pass!” shouts Mermista. “This kingdom is under Sea-Ra’s protection!”

“And under mine too!” Ryunosuke adds, uppercutting a Horde soldier. Behind her, another wave rises, crashing over more soldiers. “I love the sea!” the girl exclaims.

A dozen small round robots descend from the cliff and move toward the two girls, surrounding them. But before they can fire, they find themselves frozen in huge blocks of ice.

“Wow!” Frosta exclaims. “This is great. We are so cool, Oyuki!”

“Well done, Frosta,” replies the queen of Neptune. “They won’t bother us anymore!”

In another area of the battlefield, Mendo and Sea Hawk fight side by side with their swords. Perfuma blasts enemies with roots and vines that envelop them. Netossa throws giant nets that deflect the shots fired by the soldiers. Spinnerella summons strong winds that blow away the small assault bots. Shinobu uses her super strength to lift huge boulders and throw them at the tanks.

“Advance! Advance!” Hordak orders his troops. “The skiffs will cover you!”

Sure enough, scores of skiffs, each carrying two Horde soldiers, emerge from the woods, hover over the battlefield, and begin hurling projectiles at the members of the Rebellion.

“You’re not the only ones who can fly!” shouts Swift Wind. He too, wings spread, flies across the field, carrying Bow on his back as he begins to shoot his arrows. Many of them hit Horde aircrafts, causing them to crash.

“And when it comes to aerial combat, I’m second to none!” shouts Benten. The alien girl herself is aboard a skiff, the same one she first arrived on in Bright Moon. Maneuvering it with the skill that years of space biking have given her, she moves among the Horde’s troops. Joining her on the aircraft is Glimmer, who fires glittering projectiles at the enemy, causing panic in their ranks.

“Wonderful! We’re winning!” Bow exclaims.

But the boy spoke too soon. Horde tanks, soldiers and small assault bots are not the main danger. The giant robot built by Ran, thirty feet tall, with feminine features and curly hair,

advances in the middle of the battlefield with a menacing look, despite the ridiculous coating that covers its metal body, resembling a maid's dress with an apron. Then she raises her arm and throws a punch to the ground, making it tremble.

"Stop her!" Glimmer shouts.

Spinnerella approaches the robot, ready to unleash a windstorm. But she suddenly feels her strength failing her, and she collapses to the ground.

"Ugh... again? What...?" she says.

"Spinny!" Netossa exclaims, worried. "What's happening to you?"

"We'll take care of it!" Frosta exclaims. She and Oyuki raise their hands, ready to bombard the robot with an ice storm.

But only a few snowflakes materialize in the air. And then Oyuki falls to her knees. "I... I feel tired," she says in surprise.

"Oyuki!" Benten shouts. "What's wrong?"

"Damn it!" Ran exclaims. "The Oni Killer's Virtual Energy Recovery system has been activated."

"What the hell do you mean?" Benten asks.

"The robot can absorb the energy from the surroundings and the magic of her opponents," Ran answers. "And she uses it to feed herself. That's her strength. The Oni K model A is the best robot I've ever created!"

Glimmer groans. "Then how do we defeat her?"

Ran thinks for a moment. Then she says: "I had to leave the Fright Zone before the design was completely finished. That left the robot with one weak point... her mouth! If I could have worked on her longer, I would have come up with a model B without that flaw. But as it is, the VER system's input stream

passes through her mouth, which is unshielded and can be turned off. You have to strike there!”

“Roger!” calls Bow, who takes aim and shoots an arrow in the direction of the robot’s lips. But the machine raises her arm and protects herself with her hand. Bow’s arrow falls to the ground.

“It won’t be that easy. The Oni K model A is programmed to protect her access port in any possible way,” Ran says.

“C’mon!” Glimmer exclaims. “Let’s try again. All against the robot!”

The princesses, the earthlings, and the other soldiers of the Rebellion turn their attention to the Oni Killer, trying to reach her mouth without getting too close. Perfuma throws a vine at her, but to no avail. Mermista tries with a water ball. Ataru, Megane and the other Stormtroopers toss rocks at her. The robot easily dodges each attack.

Benten tries to approach her with the skiff, but the robot, moving with surprising agility, hits the craft with her open hand, causing it to fall to the ground. The alien girl is saved by a net from Netossa, on which she lands safely.

“It’s no use!” Glimmer exclaims. “If we get too close, the Oni K will absorb our energy or attack us. And from a distance, we can’t hit her mouth!”

“Glimmer!” Angella calls to her. The princess turns to see that the queen and Micah have left the castle and are in the courtyard outside. She immediately teleports there. “Mom! Dad!” she exclaims. “What are you doing out here?”

“We came to help you, my daughter!” Micah replies, tracing a protective spell with his hands. Just in time, before a shot from Hordak’s arm cannon lands on them. The blow shatters against the magical energy shield.

“It’s dangerous!” Glimmer says. “Go back inside. General Juliet will protect you.”

“Oh, Glimmer... how you’ve grown,” Angella says, looking at her with pride. And then she adds: “Because of this, I believe it’s time for you to access your full power. You must be able to express your best self in battle.”

“W-what do you mean, mom?”

“I’ve decided to hand over the Moonstone connection to you completely. I want to step aside. The Bright Moon runestone will be all yours.”

“M-mom!” Glimmer says.

“You’ll never need to recharge again. You’ll finally have all the power you deserve... power fit for a queen,” Angella says. Placing her hands on Glimmer’s cheeks, she adds: “Now that my Micah has returned to me, it’s time for me to retire... and let you fight your own battles. Starting now!”

Glimmer feels a force flow through her body. She senses an energy moving through her, coming from Angella’s hands, framing her face. Her entire aura lights up and a pink glow envelops her.

“I... I feel strong... powerful!” Glimmer says.

“You are,” Angella replies. “Now it’s time. Defeat Hordak and end the threat of the Horde once and for all. When the battle is over, after we’ve saved reality and returned the earthlings to their homes, there will be time for an official ceremony... your coronation. But for now, don’t hesitate. Go back to fight! And win!”

Glimmer smiles at her mother. She nods. Then the girl teleports back to the battlefield.

The princesses and their allies are still trying in vain to hit the mouth of the Oni Killer model A. Another shot from Hordak’s cannon heads their way. Netossa can barely block the blast with one of her nets.

“How’s it going, Bow?” Glimmer asks, firing an energy missile at the robot. In vain.

“Not good at all, Glim!” the boy replies. “We’re in deep trouble!”

“Ugh!” Glimmer says. “What good is more power if we can’t get close to that damn robot? She can absorb the magic and energy of any living being...”

Bow pauses for a moment, as if struck by a sudden realization. Then he says: “Any living being... Of course! You’re a genius, Glimmer!”

“Huh? What do you say?”

“Quick!” replies the boy. “Let’s take Ran and teleport ourselves into the castle. We have to get to Entrapta’s lab!”

“I want to go out, Catra! I want to go out! I want it! I want it! Bwahahaha!” laughs Adora, snorting.

“No, babe,” Catra replies patiently, holding up the blonde’s forehead and running a hand through her hair. “You can’t go to fight. You’re still wasted. And you have no sword. I won’t let you.”

“But our friends are fighting. And I want to help them. I’m very gooood at fighting, you know?”

“Yes, I know...”, Catra says tenderly.

“I fought against my love once...”, Adora says. “Wait. That was you. You are my love.”

“I know, dummy,” says Catra and gazes at her with extreme sweetness.

“Uh, Wildcat?” Scorpia asks. “Sorry to interrupt, but... what if they really need us out there?”

“Those princesses can manage on their own for once. I said you and I would stay here and take care of Adora and Lum until their drunkenness is over, and that’s what we’re going to do!”

“Maybe you’re right...” Scorpia replies. “By the way, where is Lum?”

“What do you mean?” exclaims Catra. “Weren’t you supposed to look after her? I was... busy with Adora!”

Scorpia looks around. Only the three of them are left in the large hearth room. “Um...”

“Damn it, Scorp! What if she went out to fight? We have to find her!”

“Wooow... I want to fly too,” Adora says, staring at the ceiling and grinning stupidly.

Catra and Scorpia look up and see Lum leaning upside down against the ceiling. The alien in the tiger-striped bikini has her eyes half closed and continues to emit small electrical discharges around her.

“Oh, that’s where she was,” Scorpia says with a sigh of relief.

“I want to fly too! Bwahahaha!” Adora laughs. “And sleep also. I want to sleep... and dream. Yes, dream. I bet I would be a beautiful dreamer!” She snorts.

“We can’t go on like this”, Catra says, rolling her eyes. “When will they sober up?”

“I can help with that,” says Cherry. The girls jump. They hadn’t noticed that the monk had entered the room. Little Ten flutters beside him.

“W-what do you mean?” Scorpia asks.

“Cherry has his own special antidote for drunkenness,” Ten says. And indeed, the old monk is carrying two glasses filled with a strange, thick, cream-colored liquid.

“What is this goo?” Catra asks.

“A special recipe of mine,” says Cherry. “If they drink it all, they’ll be okay. At least I hope so.”

“Wow, great!” says Scorpia. But Catra looks suspiciously at the two glasses.

“What’s in them?” she asks.

“Professional secrecy,” Cherry answers. “Do we make them drink it or not?”

Catra remains undecided. While she considers whether or not to accept the monk’s proposal, Adora, who is sitting on her lap, leans forward, grabs one of the two glasses, and swallows the contents in one gulp.

“No, Adora!” exclaims Catra.

Too late. Adora grimaces in disgust. She shuts her eyes firmly. Then she sticks out her tongue. She spits. She opens her eyes.

“C-Catra?” the blonde says as her eyes meet the catgirl’s.

“How do you feel, Adora?” asks Catra.

“Like a mess,” Adora answers. “What happened?”

“You were smashed, dumbass! Why did you drink so much if you knew you couldn’t handle the alcohol?”

“Uh... I really didn’t know it. It was the first time I drank wine and got drunk...”

“Um, the wine part, maybe, yeah... but the drunk part, actually, it wasn’t the first time,” Scorpia says. “It happened before in the Northern Reach. Do you remember? Oh boy, you got on my nerves then.”

Adora stares at her amazed. Then she realizes. “Aaah! That’s why that feeling wasn’t new to me!”

“You really are an idiot,” Catra laughs.

Meanwhile, Ten has joined Lum on the ceiling and made her drink the contents of the second glass. “W-where am I?” says the alien girl. “Where is darling?”

“The moron is out with the others,” Ten says. “They’re fighting the Horde.”

“Fighting?” Lum says. “Then quickly, we must go and help him!”

Scorpia looks at Catra. Adora glances at her, too.

The feline closes her eyes. Then she lifts her head and says, “Alright. Let’s go.” And turning to Scorpia, she adds: “Let’s win this battle... Super Pal Trio style.”

“Yeah!” Scorpia exclaims, smiling.

“Entrapta!” Bow exclaims as Glimmer teleports him, herself, and Ran into Bright Moon’s lab, where the princess of Dryl is working on the portal machine. “We need your help!”

“Sure!” Entrapta replies, pulling her mask over her head with a tuft of her hair. “Tell me everything! I always enjoy hearing about new projects.”

“The robot that Ran built for the Horde is seemingly impossible to defeat, even for the princesses,” Bow explains. “No living creature can get near her. But I thought... maybe you could build a rival robot that could stand up to her.”

“The VER Oni Killer model A absorbs enemy energy from her mouth,” Ran confirms. “Another robot could get close to her and knock her out. But... will we have time to build one?”

Entrapta pauses for a moment to think. Then she nods. “Build one from scratch, no,” she says. “But we can repurpose Betty,” and she gestures to the robot behind her that she brought over from Beast Island. “Her core is up and running, and she obeys my commands. But the wonderful thing is that I had already considered modular expansion, so she is already equipped with the necessary interface systems for additional mechanical limbs. Adding two rudimentary legs to allow her to rise to the same height as the Oni K, and two arms to hold her still while she turns off her VER system, will require only a few simple calibrations.”

“Ummm,” Glimmer stutters. “So...?”

“Betty will be ready in a few minutes!” Entrapta enthuses. “And she will have anthropomorphic features!”

Leaving Bright Moon Castle and heading out onto the surrounding plain, Adora, Catra, Scorpia and Lum waste no time joining their friends in the fight against the Horde. Flying above the ground, Lum shoots electrical discharges from the tips of her hands, blasting the circuits of the Horde’s last small assault bots. “Get away from my darling, you pieces of scrap metal!”

“Wow…” Scorpia says, admiring the alien in action. “Wait! I forgot that I can also fire electric shocks now!” And she, too, emits some reddish discharges from her pincers that hit the tanks. “Did you

see, Lum?" the scorpion lady shouts. "We have similar powers! We are the Super Electric Duo!"

Lum smiles at her. Then she looks for Ataru in the field. As soon as she sees him in the distance, hiding at the edge of the forest with Megane and his other classmates, she quickly flies to their side.

For their part, Catra and Adora engage in hand-to-hand combat with the last remaining Horde soldiers. Watching each other's backs, the two girls exchange knowing glances between blows. Catra had forgotten how exhilarating it was to fight alongside Adora, like when they trained together years before in the Fright Zone against rival cadet teams. How she missed that feeling!

Suddenly the ground shakes. Step by step, the VER Oni K model A slowly moves towards them. Catra and Adora remain paralyzed as the robot's shadow covers them. Instinctively, Catra hugs Adora and closes her eyes.

The machine is about to raise her arm and hit them when Betty emerges from the castle. As Entrapta had promised, her robot now has anthropomorphic features and is equipped with long arms and legs. She starts to run towards the enemy with extraordinary speed. VER Oni K model A realizes this, stops attacking Catra and Adora, and turns towards the opponent, ready to defend herself.

When she is a few feet away, Betty attacks with a blow. But it is easily parried by her rival, who grabs one of her arms. Betty also grabs VER Oni K A's other arm, and the two robots begin a strange dance, with their limbs intertwined.

Glimmer, who reappears on the battlefield with Bow, Ran and Entrapta, watches them in bewilderment.

"The mouth!" Ran says. "That's the Oni K's weak spot. She has to hit her in her mouth."

“Did you understand, Betty?” Entrapta shouts. “Aim for her mouth!”

Betty moves to close the distance between them, while the Horde robot tries to resist. But it’s all in vain. Betty’s head approaches VER Oni K A’s. The two mouths collide.

For a few endless seconds, the two giant robots do not move. There’s silence. Then a strange buzzing can be heard.

“It almost seems...” Bow says.

“...that Betty and VEROniKA are making out!” says Glimmer.

The arms of both robots go down. But their lips do not part. The two robots remain still, kissing, oblivious to everything else.

“The VER system is off,” Ran says. “That means the Oni Killer’s battle mode has been automatically deactivated.”

“And Betty got herself a girlfriend,” Entrapta laughs.

Ataru, Lum, Catra, Adora and the others witness the scene in amazement.

The princesses and earthlings, exhausted but happy, gather in the center of the plain, at the foot of Bright Moon Castle.

“So did we win?” says Shinobu. “Is the battle over?”

“Not yet!” a deep and authoritative voice shouts. “You forget me!”

Everyone turns to see Hordak approaching. The cannon on his arm is gathering energy, ready to be unleashed.

“You’ve defeated my army. This is the end of the Horde. But I will have my revenge,” Hordak says. Spotting Catra among the princesses, he aims the cannon at her. “Force Captain Catra!” she adds. “At least you will pay for your betrayal!”

“Look out, Catra!” Adora shouts, pushing her friend out of the cannon’s path just in time.

“Don’t worry, princess. I know how to defend myself!”, Catra says. And with a feline leap, she reaches Hordak and hits him with a spinning kick, destroying his cannon.

The Horde lord lets out a scream of pain and falls to the ground, surrounded by fragments of his weapon. Adora beams. The princesses exult in seeing Catra defeat their greatest enemy. Slowly, they approach and surround him.

“You’ve lost, Hordak,” Glimmer says. “Just surrender. The war is over. The Rebellion has won.”

“I... will… never surrender!” says Hordak, kneeling and holding the arm where the cannon was attached. “You’ll have to kill me!”

“Suits me fine!” Glimmer says, approaching him with her fists raised and filled with sparks.

“No, Glimmer, stop...” says Bow. But before he can intervene, Entrapta stands between Glimmer and the fallen Horde lord.

“Hordak!!!” cries the princess of Dryl, running to embrace the man.

“E-Entrapta?” he says in surprise. “You here? But... but how? I thought you were lost... banished to Beast Island...”

“Oh yes, I was,” Entrapta replies. “But I’m back. And I’m ready to resume our experiments if... if you want. We have another portal to open, for starters.”

Everyone around them is silent. Then it's Mermista who speaks first: "Absolutely not. We're not okay with this."

"He must pay for his crimes," Netossa adds. "He has made too many people suffer."

"But he... he's my lab partner," Entrapta says, facing the other princesses.

"We can't let him go," Frosta adds. "Hordak is our worst enemy. It's only his fault if..."

Suddenly the whole sky lights up. A kind of purple blanket rises from the horizon, reaching to the zenith and then dropping again. A chill runs through the princesses as they feel the power of their runestones flowing through them.

"What... what's going on?" Perfuma exclaims.

Adora understands. And trembles. "L-Light Hope!" she cries, holding onto Catra. "It's Light Hope! She's activating the Heart of Etheria! Now that Glimmer has full access to the Moonstone, all the runestones are aligned and the planet is finally balanced..."

"And she dragged Etheria out in the wider universe!" Entrapta adds with enthusiasm, but also with concern. "We're not in Despondos anymore!"

"W-what does that mean?" Shinobu asks.

"Is that good or bad?" Mendo asks.

"Bad!" Adora replies. "Light Hope will use She-Ra... she will use me to channel all the power of the Heart and focus its destructive energy. And I won't be able to resist it... Unless..."

Adora stops. Catra looks at her worriedly.

"Unless..." Adora continues after a few seconds. "Entrapta!" she says, addressing the pigtailed princess. "Do you still need She-Ra's

sword to open our portal?”

Entrapta thinks for a moment, then says, “I don’t know... Maybe not! If we are no longer in Despondos, the anomalies that made it difficult to open the portal should no longer be there. I believe we will be able to open it even without the enormous magical power of the Sword of Protection. The technology of the First Ones that we already possess could be sufficient, possibly enhanced by the runestones of the other princesses. Why?”

Adora smiles. She turns and looks Catra straight in the eyes. The feline feels herself shiver.

“Because I want to destroy this stupid sword once and for all,” the blonde says, still smiling. “Glimmer! Teleport me to the lab, quickly!”

Without hesitation, Glimmer grabs Adora and the two disappear in a sea of sparks. They reappear in the lab, next to Entrapta’s portal machine, which has She-Ra’s sword in its center.

Adora grabs the weapon. Glimmer looks at her with concern. But the blonde doesn’t hesitate. “Good riddance!” she says. And she brings it down abruptly, with all the strength she has. The tip of the blade hits the ground. And in an instant, the sword shatters.

At the same moment, in the Crystal Castle in the middle of the Whispering Woods, the artificial intelligence called Light Hope begins to dissolve. The last spark of her consciousness turns to a memory from almost a thousand years before: a happy memory that should have been erased long ago, but for some reason was preserved... a bouquet of flowers... a smiling girl. “Mara...”, thinks Light Hope. And before she disappears forever, she adds: “Thank you... Adora.”

“Is... is it over now?” Ataru asks.

“Looks like it,” Mendo replies. “Fortunately. I couldn’t bear another danger.”

“Uh-oh,” Ryunosuke says. “What are those?”

Large shadows appear on the ground. Everyone lifts their gaze and watches in horror as hundreds... no, thousands of menacing spaceships appear out of nowhere in the sky.

“More spaceships?” Glimmer groans. “And who are they now?”

“Prime!” Hordak exults, rising to his feet. “The great Horde Prime is here! My message did reach him!” Then he turns to Glimmer and the other princesses and laughs: “It’s over for you. You may have defeated my army, but you’re no match for the immensity of the Galactic Horde.”

Everyone looks in horror at the array of ships above them. The crafts project beams of green light downward. Within moments, the ground fills with robots and creepy Hordak clones, all white with cold green eyes.

“Adora!” cries Catra. “What do we do now?”

“We’re in trouble...” the blonde answers. “Without the sword, I can no longer transform into She-Ra.”

“No time to be discouraged,” says Glimmer. “We already won one battle today... or maybe two. We can win another!”

And so, despite their fatigue, the princesses and their allies once again take on the enemies. It soon becomes clear, however, that the robots and clones of Prime are far more formidable opponents than those previously defeated.

With her powers magnified by a full connection to the runestone, Glimmer teleports around the battlefield, striking the clones and then transporting herself a few feet away to disorient them. Oyuki and Frosta team up again, instantly freezing numerous robots. Lum and Scorpia also attack in unison, throwing electric shocks and lightning bolts in all directions. Mermista and Ryunosuke summon waves of water that sweep away enemies. On the back of Swift Wind, Bow shoots his arrows from above. Benten, who has restarted a skiff, flies over the battlefield with Perfuma, who throws vegetable projectiles. Mendo and Sea Hawk attack with their swords. Lonnie, Rogelio, Megane and the other Stormtroopers fight with their bare hands. And Entrapta and Ran give new instructions to Betty and VEROniKA, prompting the two giant robots to support their friends.

Overwhelmed by the unexpected resistance, the army of robots and clones struggles at first. But after a few moments, they begin to regroup and counterattack in a more orderly fashion.

“Ugh,” says Mermista. “They’re moving in a coordinated way. It’s almost like they’re communicating telepathically.”

“The clones are obviously part of a hive mind,” Entrapta says. “They move as one. I’m afraid we won’t be able to defeat them. We need reinforcements...”

And just then, in the middle of the plain, a portal begins to open. Inside its bright interior, three figures slowly emerge: a woman dressed in white with a long red skirt and a staff in her hand, flanked on either side by two strange and huge beasts: a kind of giant ox whose body is coated with tiger stripes, and a seven-foot-tall cat, all white with a brown ear.

“Nurse Sakura!” Ataru exclaims.

“Waah! Rei!” Ran shouts, her eyes filled with joy.

“And my friend Kotatsu-neko!” Ten says.

“We heard you were in trouble,” Sakura says, “and we’re here to help!”

“Of course!” Entrapta exclaims. “Now that Etheria is no longer in Despondos but in the same universe of planet Earth, there are no more obstacles to the creation of dimensional portals. My machine in the lab started working automatically, connecting to the correct space coordinates thanks to the ritual performed by priestess Sakura!”

Rei and the Kotatsu cat charge at the army of robots and clones, sending dozens of them flying into the air with their paws. The tide of battle seems to be turning once again. The earthlings and the princesses rejoice.

But suddenly, another beam of green light descends from the largest ship, which is right above Bright Moon Castle. And a sinister figure appears on the ground. He also looks like Hordak, but much more imposing. His face has multiple green eyes. His aura is intimidating.

“I did not expect such a backward planet to resist my forces,” he says. “But it’s completely useless. This whole mess must be wiped away.”

“Horde Prime!” Hordak exclaims. “You’re here!”

“Is that you, little brother?” Prime says, noticing Hordak for the first time. “I thought you had perished.”

“I was pulled into a shadow dimension,” Hordak says. “All this time, I have been trying to return to your side. And I have built an empire in your name. To show you that I am worthy, so that I may retake my place by your side. I have bent its people to my will.”

“To... *your* will?” says Prime. He watches Hordak carefully. “Why can I not see your thoughts?”. Then he walks up to him and grabs

him, putting his hands on his face. And after a moment: “I see now. You… have given yourself a name. You tried to create an empire of your own. There was even a time you wished I would not come for you, is that so?”

“No, brother...” Hordak protests. “I did it, all of it, for you.”

“You have forgotten who you are!” Prime says, growing increasingly angry and threatening. “You truly think you are worthy to stand beside me, to be my equal? I made you in my image, but you have become an abomination... A failed clone... An imperfect one...”

“Imperfection is beautiful!” Entrapta exclaims. The princess of Dryl steps forward, ignoring the danger. “And this is my lab partner! Leave him alone!”

Prime lets go of Hordak and instead grabs her by one of her braids, lifting her off the ground.

“And who are you?” she says. “How dare you challenge Horde Prime? Looks like I’ll be using you as an example for everyone. I will destroy you immediately.”

Seeing Entrapta in danger, Hordak’s eyes widen. He stands and shouts: “Stop! Don’t touch her!”

“Oh, is that so, little brother? Are you going to rebel against me?”

Hordak hesitates. “Rebel...? I...? No... No... But she...”

“This girl is nothing but a nuisance to me,” Prime replies. “I will wipe her away, just as I will wipe out all of her friends. And then I’ll have to recondition you.”

Hordak hesitates again. But then his face takes on a look of determination. “No, you will not,” he says. “You’re right. You made me in your image, but I am more than that.” He takes a step, grabs a rifle left on the ground by one of the Horde soldiers, and points it at Prime. “I gave myself a name, I made a life of my

own. I made...” he looks at Entrapta and smiles. “...a friend. I am Hordak, and I defy your will.”

Hordak shoots Prime, who is hit and falls to the ground. Entrapta, freed from his grip, runs up to Hordak and hugs him, smiling. “You saved me! I knew you weren’t evil!”

“How dare you, little brother?” Prime says, rising again to his feet. “You will pay for this! I will obliterate you along with your ally.” And raising his arm, now wielding some mysterious kind of weapon, he aims it at Hordak and Entrapta, who are still embracing.

But before he can fire, he is struck from behind by Catra, who has jumped onto his back. “Stop there! I won’t let you hurt a third of the Super Pal Trio!”

With incredible swiftness, Prime grabs Catra’s ankle just as the feline leaps in the air. “And who are you, child?” he says, holding her upside down. “Do you want to perish too?”

Adora, who has watched the whole scene nearly motionless, feels a great strength emanating from her when she sees Catra in danger. “For the honor of Grayskull!” she exclaims, almost without realizing it. And she finds herself enveloped in a flash of light. A new She-Ra emerges from the light, stronger, more beautiful, more powerful. Even without the sword, she has managed to transform! Her dress is slightly different, the tiara is reminiscent of the old mask of Catra, and her hair is not loose, but gathered into a ponytail.

Wow, Catra can’t help but think, looking at her and blushing despite the position she’s in. *She’s...*

“She’s hot,” Benten says, not far away from them. Catra growls. How dare this alien? But she’s right. She really is hot!

“She-Ra?” Prime says in astonishment. “But how...? I thought I wiped out all the First Ones many centuries ago...”

“Leave my girlfriend alone!” She-Ra shouts. “It’s over for you!”

Prime drops Catra and laughs. “You are powerful, I can feel it,” he says, “but your strength is not enough to defeat me.”

“No, you’re wrong,” She-Ra says. And immediately, she is standing in front of him. A powerful life force seems to emerge from the ground around her every step, a glowing magic that sustains life: grass and plants bloom in an instant. Prime’s smile suddenly fades: this girl carries a powerful and vital magic such as he has never seen before.

And so the galactic tyrant decides that there is no need to take unnecessary risks. Better to avoid a direct fight. He turns to flee, but suddenly finds himself in front of the gigantic and silent figure of the Kotatsu cat, who grabs him and holds him tightly with his paws.

“You beastly, cursed creature! Let me go!” Prime screams.

But it’s no use. Kotatsu-neko is also endowed with some kind of supernatural strength, and his tight grip cannot be broken.

She-Ra approaches Prime slowly and solemnly. Finally, she grabs his face with both hands. “It’s time for you to go,” she says. And in an instant, Prime’s consciousness, in the form of a blackish blob, leaves the cloned body he has inhabited for decades. The light disintegrates it. Kotatsu-neko releases the clone, which falls inert to the ground.

She-Ra sighs. She flashes a smile at the cat, who smiles back. Then she transforms back into Adora.

She is immediately caught in a strong embrace. It’s Catra who hugs her. The two girls need not exchange words.

“We won!” Glimmer shouts in the background.

The plain around the castle is filled with laughter, cries of joy and celebration. Angella and Micah, holding hands, congratulate everyone who has contributed to this great victory. Not only has the Horde been utterly defeated, but Etheria has finally been restored to its former glory, an unbelievably gorgeous world, bright and filled with magic and life.

“I’m glad to meet you in person,” Castaspella says, greeting Sakura. A dozen feet away from them, the portal is still open, ready to bring all the inhabitants of Tomobiki and their alien friends back to Earth. “We worked well together. I’m almost sorry that you have to leave now.”

“Don’t worry,” Sakura answers. “If I understood correctly what the girl with the prehensile hair explained, our two planets are now in the same dimension, that is, in the same universe. Opening a portal between our worlds will no longer be so difficult: we can come and visit you whenever we want.”

“Yes!” exclaims little Ten, flying around the two women. “So I can play with my new friend again.” Fluttering next to him, giggling and laughing, is the Imp.

“If there’s food, I won’t miss it,” Cherry adds. “And then I’d like to meet that strange forest lady again. I wish I could get to know her better.”

Catra, extremely perplexed, glances curiously at the big Kotatsu cat. She sniffs him, but stays a few feet away. Adora approaches her and looks at her tenderly. “What are you doing?” she asks.

“I can’t figure out if this creature... is a real cat or a hybrid like me,” Catra answers.

Kotatsu-neko stares at her with an indecipherable expression. Adora laughs.

Then Swift Wind, descending from the sky, lands next to the blonde. “Hi, Adora! I missed you during the battle”, he says.

“Hi Swifty, good to see you again,” Adora says, hugging him. Then, noticing that Catra seems to be looking at the winged unicorn with some suspicion, she adds: “Don’t be afraid, Catra. He’s a good friend. Say, now that the galaxy is free from the threat of Prime, we have a whole universe to explore. Who knows how many other creatures we will meet. Maybe you too have a pet waiting for you somewhere on a distant planet.”

Catra groans. But then she joins in with Adora and Swift Wind’s laughter.

Around them, earthlings, aliens and princesses all hug and say goodbye.

“Thank you for fighting along with us,” Glimmer says. “We couldn’t have done it without you.”

“Thank you for rescuing us,” Shinobu replies. “I didn’t think we’d ever get a chance to go home.”

“And if you want to come back one day,” Glimmer adds, with Bow at her side, “we will take you to the most beautiful places on our planet... starting with the steam grotto of Mystacor!”

“Wonderful!” Shinobu says. “Of course, you’re welcome in Japan as well. We could visit the hot springs in Hokkaido!”

Oyuki and Frosta hug each other. “We ice princesses are the best,” says the young Etherian. The queen of Neptune smiles at her: “You can say it out loud. We rock!”

Chibi and Kyle also say goodbye. “Be careful,” the earthling tells him. “Don’t let others push you around.” “You too,” the former Horde soldier replies. “I will miss you.”

Ryunosuke hugs Mermista and then Lonnie. Mendo and Sea Hawk exchange their swords. Benten bids farewell to Spinnerella and

Netossa. Ran, with Rei (back to human form) at her side, laughs next to Entrapta. She then approaches Catra and says, "Goodbye, Catra-chan. Please, now that you've made peace with Adora, don't fall back into your old habits."

"Don't worry," the feline replies. "The days of revenge are over for me. And I hope, for you as well." And she slips into Adora's arm, pulling her close.

One by one, all earthlings and aliens pass through the portal and disappear from Etheria. First goes Sakura, followed by Cherry and Kotatsu-neko. Then Megane, Perm, Kakugari and Chibi. Then Mendo and Shinobu. Ran and Rei. Ryunosuke. Ten. Benten and Oyuki. The last ones are Ataru and Lum, who, before leaving, turn around to bid farewell to the inhabitants of Etheria, especially Catra and Adora. The two couples hug each other.

"So goodbye, and thank you for everything," Lum says. "Sooner or later we will visit you again."

"We count on it," Adora says. "Consider yourselves already invited to our wedding!"

Catra blushes. "W-wedding?" she says. Her legs tremble.

"Oh yes!" says Lum. "And then, of course, we will meet again to celebrate the birth of our children!"

"C-children?" Ataru stutters. He and Catra are paralyzed, while Lum and Adora light up and giggle.

Seeing Ataru and Catra turn pale, Lum and Adora kiss them on the cheek at once.

"It's a beautiful dream come true," Adora and Lum say.

"A nightmare, you mean," Ataru says.

"Y-you're such an idiot," Catra says to Adora.

And at the same time, “Darling no baka!”, Lum says to Ataru, smiling.

And as the Japanese boy and the alien in the tiger-striped bikini cross the portal that brings them back to Earth, together with the happiness of a new friendship and the promise of a bright future, a last sentence hangs in the air, spoken tenderly by Adora to Catra and by Ataru to Lum at the same time:

“Yes... I’m your idiot.”

Chapter End Notes

> The title of this chapter is a fusion between the titles of Urusei Yatsura’s second movie, “Beautiful Dreamer” (1984), and She-Ra (2018) season 4 episodes 12-13, “Destiny”.

End Notes

And so it ends!

Thank you for reading and staying until the end. If you enjoyed it, comments and/or kudos are welcome.

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